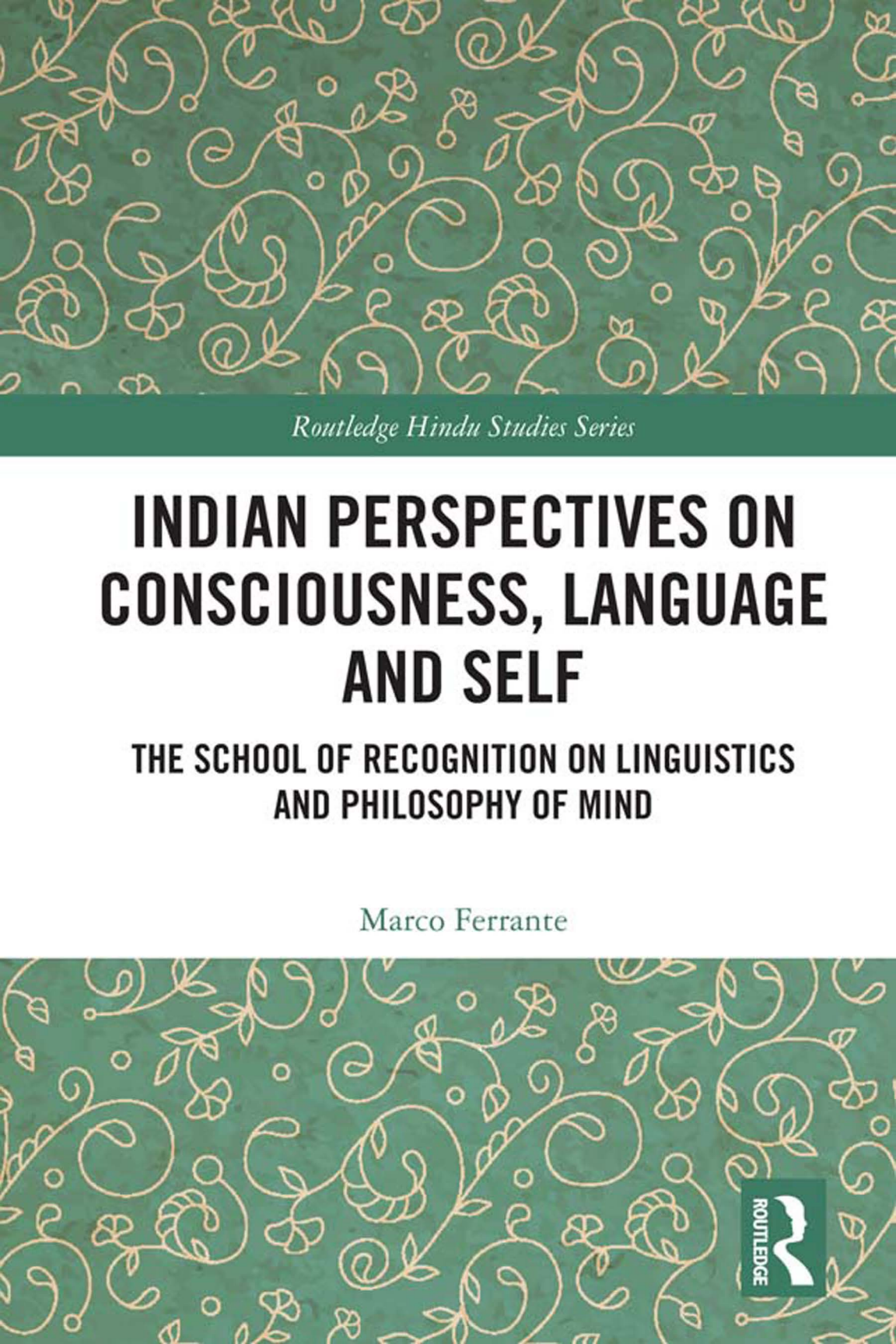




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INDIAN PERSPECTIVES ON CONSCIOUSNESS, LANGUAGE AND SELF

**THE SCHOOL OF RECOGNITION ON LINGUISTICS
AND PHILOSOPHY OF MIND**

Marco Ferrante



Indian Perspectives on Consciousness, Language and Self

This book examines the theory of consciousness developed by the school of Recognition, an Indian philosophical tradition that thrived around the tenth c. CE in Kashmir, and argues that consciousness has a linguistic nature. It situates the doctrines of the tradition within the broader Indian philosophical context and establishes connections with the contemporary analytic debate.

The book focuses on Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta (tenth c. CE), two Hindu intellectuals belonging to the school of Recognition, *Pratyabhijñā* in Sanskrit. It argues that these authors promoted ideas that bear a strong resemblance with contemporary ‘higher-order theories’ of consciousness. In addition, the book explores the relationship between the thinkers of the school of Recognition and the thought of the grammarian and philosopher Bhartṛhari (fifth c. CE). The book bridges a gap that still exists between scholars engaged with Western traditions and Sanskrit specialists focused on textual materials. In doing so, the author uses concepts from contemporary philosophy of mind to illustrate the Indian arguments and an interdisciplinary approach with abundant reference to the original sources.

Offering fresh information to historians of Indian thought, the book will also be of interest to academics working on Non-Western Philosophy, Comparative Philosophy, Indian Philosophy, Religion, Hinduism, Tantric Studies, and South Asian Studies.

Marco Ferrante is a specialist in Indian philosophy, with a special focus on epistemology, philosophy of mind, and philosophy of language. He was Berggruen Fellow in Comparative Philosophy at the University of Oxford, UK.

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Indian Perspectives on Consciousness, Language and Self

The School of Recognition on Linguistics
and Philosophy of Mind

Marco Ferrante

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In the end, this book came to combine the main research interests of my *gūrūs*. In classical India, it was quite standard practice for a pupil to discuss the work of his teacher(s) later in life. Due to unforeseen circumstances, I have not been able to follow this (wise) approach. I hope nonetheless to have been able to achieve at least something close to the high scholarly standard of Raffaele and Vincenzo.

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This book is dedicated to Mara, Federico, and Alessandro: “il mio universo in voi”.

Abbreviations

ABh	<i>Abhinavabharati</i> of Abhinavagupta
ĪPK	<i>Īśvarapratyabhijñākārikā</i> of Utpaladeva
ĪPKV _r	<i>Īśvarapratyabhijñākārikā–Vṛtti</i> of Utpaladeva
ĪPV	<i>Īśvarapratyabhijñāvimarśinī</i> of Abhinavagupta
ĪPVV	<i>Īśvara-pratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinī</i> of Abhinavagupta
MA	<i>Madhyamakālaṃkāra</i> of Śāntarakṣita
MK	<i>Mūlamadhyamakakārikā</i> of Nāgārjuna
NS	<i>Nyāyasūtra</i> of Gautama
NSB	<i>Nyāyasūtrabhāṣya</i> of Vātsyāyana
PS	<i>Pramāṇasamuccaya</i> of Dignāga
PSV	<i>Pramāṇasamuccaya–Vṛtti</i> of Dignāga
PV	<i>Pramāṇavārttika</i> of Dharmakīrti
PVin	<i>Pramāṇaviniścaya</i> of Dharmakīrti
ŚD	<i>Śivadr̥ṣṭi</i> of Somānanda
Sp.Kā	<i>Spandakārikas</i> of Bhaṭṭa Kallaṭa
ŚSū	<i>Śivasūtras</i> of Vasugupta
TS	<i>Tattvasaṃgraha</i> of Śāntarakṣita
TSP	<i>Tattvasaṃgrahapañjikā</i> of Kamalaśīla
VP	<i>Vākyapadīya</i> of Bhartṛhari
VPV _r	<i>Vākyapadīya–Vṛtti</i>

Introduction

Consciousness is possibly the most decisive feature of mind and surely the most puzzling. Its definition has long been a philosophical concern, and it is today one of the most hotly discussed questions in philosophy of mind and cognitive sciences. Whether conceived as an ability that is explainable in terms of brain activity or as a peculiar capacity that is impossible to reduce to physical processes, consciousness is still resisting a shared definition.

This book analyzes the way in which some classical Indian philosophers living in the second half of the first millennium CE discussed the problem of consciousness and produced sophisticated and original insights on its nature.¹ Its main characters are authors who belonged to the so-called ‘School of the Recognition’ (Pratyabhijñā in Sanskrit), a Śaiva religious–philosophical tradition that flourished in Kashmir between the ninth and the eleventh c. CE. The main exponents of the school, Utpaladeva (925–975) and Abhinavagupta (975–1025), were primarily prompted by apologetic reasons, that is, by the desire to defend the idea of personhood, of self, from the sharp criticism the Buddhist traditions had voiced against the notion for centuries. With this basic purpose in mind, these authors developed an innovative discourse on consciousness that was arguably one of the most refined in the premodern world. The main claim of this book is that Utpaladeva, the leading theoretician of the school, proposed a theory of consciousness that today would be categorized as a higher-order one. This means that he conceived consciousness as the result of the activity of second-order mental states operating on first-order ones, which are those that directly derive from experience. In addition, Utpaladeva regarded this activity as conceptual and language dependent, thus arriving at the conclusion the consciousness has ultimately a linguistic nature. Finally, he also clearly claimed that mentality is an inherent component of all things, thus endorsing a form of panpsychism. In drawing part of this picture, Utpaladeva was heavily influenced by the ideas of an earlier philosopher, the grammarian Bhartṛhari (460–510). All this results in a complex and intellectually engaging situation, in which the Pratyabhijñā thinkers formulated their theories in opposition to those advanced by the Buddhists but with the crucial support of notions that are traceable to the work of Bhartṛhari. Accordingly, to appraise the originality of Utpaladeva’s philosophy of consciousness, it is absolutely vital to keep in mind the contributions of the two other parties of our story.

2 Introduction

This book engages with the thought of these thinkers from three complementary points of view. Its primary purpose is explanatory. The doctrines we examine are put forward in texts composed in technical Sanskrit, and their interpretation is far from being completely settled. These texts are undoubtedly hard for the modern reader, since they require the knowledge of a complex language and are immersed in a cultural environment that is very distant from ours. It is for this reason that I have tried as much as I could to assume a rather strict philosophical perspective, downplaying all the aspects that could make the affirmations of these thinkers somehow even more baffling. Inevitably, such a course of action has its own drawbacks. The aspect suffering most from this approach is probably the religious inclination these philosophers had, an aspect that I have consciously deemphasized but which remains crucial. Eventually, the esoteric circles to which these intellectuals belonged aimed at revealing to initiates the pervasiveness and omnipresence of Śiva, the tradition's godhead. It is precisely the recognition of Śiva's ubiquity that gives to the school its name and frees human beings from the fetters of transmigration. This reveals how the motives of the Pratyabhijñā's philosophers were absolutely typical of the Indian context, as their doctrines had a strong soteriological drive and were primarily aimed at engendering liberation (*mokṣa*). Still, this does not exclude that the school defended most of its ideas through rational arguments that are worth to be taken seriously. Similar considerations apply to the other main figure discussed here, Bhartṛhari. This intellectual was first and foremost a Sanskrit grammarian who has nevertheless given substantial contributions to the philosophical debate of his time and, as I hope to show, not only in the domains in which his authority is normally acknowledged, that is, semantics and philosophy of language. In his case, too, I have picked what is relevant to my discussion without any aspiration for comprehensiveness.²

The reason behind the choice to focus on philosophical arguments is related to the second perspective this book adopts, which is an argumentative and comparative one. In dealing with the doctrines of these intellectuals, I have made an effort to engage with them critically, that is to say, to evaluate whether they are rationally consistent or not. In doing so, I have tried to establish a connection with contemporary analytic philosophy whenever possible. This approach allows readers and me to have a conceptual framework helpful to contextualize what these thinkers were contending. Furthermore, it gives me the possibility to highlight a pressing problem for those engaged with the study of non-Euro-American thought. The problem at stake is that still too often, scholars working on Asian or African philosophies have to struggle with the notion that these traditions have produced just religious mysticism, or second-rate speculation. To challenge this prejudice, this book is also a work of comparative philosophy, an academic field that is gradually gaining recognition but whose credibility is somehow still open to question. Tim Connolly has discussed some of the objections that can be raised against the discipline (Connolly, 2015), and some of his remarks can be helpful to put in the right perspective the motives and the methodology of this book. As I hinted earlier, the grossest attack one can mount to non-Euro-American thought is simply to say that it does not meet the standard of real, i.e. Euro-American, philosophy.

Even though this type of criticism is progressively losing ground, there are still scholars voicing it.³ The “exclusion viewpoint”, as Connolly calls it, is weak and easy to reject. The notion suffers, in the first place, from broad generalization, as it presupposes that one can lump together under a single label all Euro-American philosophical traditions. Moreover, it tends to be too narrow, as it defines philosophy by highlighting some features and minimizing others. The problem with this approach is that whatever key feature one chooses to determine what philosophy is, it would end up being an arbitrary one, and it will certainly leave some (crucial) traditions out. To give an example, by choosing the role of evidence and logical argumentation as the hallmark of the discipline, many ancient Greek thinkers would be excluded. Conversely, if we believe that philosophers must have ethical concerns up to the point of being able to provide models for good living, much of the contemporary debate would not meet the standard. A more compelling objection against the validity of comparative philosophy comes from the non-Euro-American traditions themselves. Connolly calls it the “one-sidedness argument”. The argument rests on the idea that in drawing comparisons, one is merely projecting one’s own categories and bias, most of the time Euro-American ones, onto the cultures of other people. Brought to extremes, the ‘one-sidedness argument’ seems to imply that comparative philosophy is just another form of cultural colonization. A possible reply to this objection is that Euro-American philosophy is far less a monolithic entity than a collection of many and often conflicting strands of thought. In addition, one could point out that some of the problems non-Euro-American philosophers undertake are actually the same their Euro-American peers discuss in their works, and therefore they can legitimately be enquired by using the same methods. Finally, it is worth noting that a comparative philosopher should not necessarily use a universalistic approach to point out affinities between distinct philosophical traditions. One can also do comparative philosophy with the purpose of highlighting differences.

A second type of criticism one can raise against the discipline regards indeed the very notion of comparison. According to some, philosophy in itself comes down to comparing ideas. If this was true, introducing a specific sub-field called ‘comparative philosophy’ would be redundant and useless. Following Connolly, one could reply that comparing thinkers and notions belonging to one culture is not the same as comparing between traditions that are radically alien. In the latter case, fresh philosophical questions tend to emerge. A good example is precisely the issue we are discussing right now. Examining whether a comparison between mutually unfamiliar traditions is admissible—which is a philosophical issue in itself—can emerge only after a comparative point of view is adopted.

If one in the end allows that comparing different philosophies is legitimate, it remains to be seen how the comparison should actually proceed. Connolly identifies two main methods, the ‘descriptive’ and the ‘constructive’. By following a descriptive approach, one is essentially using concepts of a given tradition, normally one’s own, to better understand and clarify those of another. Arguably, one can question the legitimacy of this line of action, too, but it is difficult to deny the fact that the experience we have of others is always mediated by our own

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cultural make-up and categories of thought. Nevertheless, one must be careful not to fall into two traps. The first is the temptation to detect too many commonalities between one's own philosophical posture and the less familiar one. An inaccuracy of this kind would strengthen the 'one-sidedness' argument and eventually lead to universalism, the idea that all humankind thinks approximately in the same way, notwithstanding historical circumstances. At the same time, one must also seek not to take the opposite path, which consists in highlighting only differences and in regarding the other traditions as completely alien to ours. This latter approach easily falls into romanticism, that is to say, into an idealization of the other as embodying principles and values that are entirely dissimilar from those we hold.

Connolly's second approach to comparison, the constructive one, starts from quite different premises. By adopting it, one focuses on a specific philosophical problem and explores the possibility that arguments of a different tradition might turn out to be useful to solve the problem at hand. The main advantage of this way of proceeding is that the thought of other cultures takes an active role, and it is used to address contemporary concerns. Still, one may also question whether it is legitimate to apply the arguments of a philosophical tradition to problems emerging in another, thus embracing the notion that there is some sort of incommensurability between cultures. A discussion of this issue would lead us very far from our point, but I generally agree with Connolly's conclusion that there is no incommensurability as such but just incommensurate aspects that await to be commensurate.⁴ It seems to me that to reject the notion of comparison between philosophies is tantamount to rejecting the notion of translation between languages. Translating concepts from a language into another is not an easy task; it must be done with care, and something gets inevitably lost in the process. But I suspect that few would go as far as to contend that translations are useless or even inherently impossible. The same happens in the case of philosophy, in which certain conceptions can be compared with those of other cultures with the purpose to acquire new information. Something is surely lost on the way, but something is gained, too—at the very least, the awareness that the same problem can be tackled from different but often equally legitimate standpoints.

Connolly's overall considerations can be applied to the particular case of Indian philosophy. According to a schematization introduced by Roy Perrett (2016, pp. 16–20), scholars seemed to have investigated Indian thought by adopting four main approaches, which he calls, partially following an earlier classification of Amartya Sen (2005, pp. 140–142), the magisterial, the exoticist, the curatorial, and the interlocutory.

The magisterial approach was taken by some early explorers of Indian thought, in particular of those active during the period of British rule on India and sympathetic to the cultural agenda of the Raj. The magisterial approach explicitly minimize the value of Indian culture and highlight its inferiority to the European tradition, up to the point of voicing blatant racism. In Connolly's model, this approach would correspond to the 'exclusion viewpoint'. But in a sense, it is even

less commendable, since magisterial scholars often regarded Indian thought not only as unable to meet the standard of genuine philosophy but also as a serious menace to the intellectual health of Indian society.

Perrett's second approach, the exoticist, is particularly evident in the works of eighteenth-century German intellectuals, like Herder, Schelling, and Schopenhauer (though it is detectable also in the production of more recent interpreters like Radhakrishnan, Eliade, or Zimmer). Even if this perspective is generally appreciative of Indian culture, it is also dangerously misleading. The main problem with the exoticist scholar is that she easily runs the risk of falling into romanticism and 'one-sidedness'. Romanticism is a detrimental attitude that is well-known to specialists in Indian philosophy, since it has beset the discipline for decades. It sets in when the strong argumentative and rational component of South Asian culture is brushed aside, and India is pictured as the land incarnating values Europeans have never possessed or not possess any longer, such as detachment, transcendence, spirituality, and anti-materialism. On the other hand, one-sidedness develops when Indian thought is distorted and used, consciously or not, as a means to reinforce one's own ideas, as it is most evident in the case of the philosophy of Schopenhauer.

If the magisterial and exoticist approaches are largely a thing of the past,⁵ Perrett's third approach, the curatorial one, is still used. It is the approach of the so-called 'classical Indology', a discipline rooted in rigorous textual analysis and therefore perfectly aware of the rationalist dimension of Indian philosophical literature. In the past two centuries, the curatorial approach has vastly increased our knowledge of the history of Indian thought, but it has nonetheless one major disadvantage. Normally, it is not concerned with the validity of the arguments the indigenous traditions offer. If a notion is true, plausible, or plainly untenable, is not a question for the curatorial scholar, who is usually interested in producing the most reliable and philologically sound examination of the texts she is working on. From a philosophical perspective, this is a limit. Categorizing the curatorial approach according to Connolly's nomenclature is difficult. In this case, several factors might be at work: some scholars working on philosophical texts have an extensive philological training but less familiarity with philosophical methods; some others may consciously or unconsciously endorse a version of incommensurability, whereby it is sound to investigate Indian philosophy as a historical phenomenon, but without taking a stand on whether the doctrines the indigenous thinkers maintain are rationally acceptable or not.

The fourth approach—the one that Perrett favours and which I have tried to apply in this book—is the interlocutory one, which is meant to be an improvement over the curatorial. As the name betrays, this way of dealing with Indian thought seeks to establish a dialogue between 'us' and 'them'—between what they claim and our own notions and cultural premises. This is a dialogue that is based on a common ground, which is, I believe, a shared notion of truth. Even though the fact is sometimes overlooked, most Indian thinkers were guided by a genuine desire to establish how things really are, namely, to discover truth. That this truth can have, as it happens often, a soteriological value is quite a different thing, which usually

does not diminish the merit of the argumentations these thinkers offer. This book is precisely an attempt to *interloquire* or, in other words, to establish a conversation with Indian philosophers on some specific problems, without for this reason concealing the cultural make-up of its author.

If asked to plot Connolly's considerations on the present book, I would answer that I have mostly applied a descriptive method, insofar as I have used Euro-American categories to better understand what the Pratyabhijñā thinkers, the Buddhists and Bhartṛhari are claiming. Can I be accused of one-sidedness? I leave the answer to the reader, but a couple of considerations are in order. In the first place, I have largely made use of what Connolly believes to be the most effective antidote against this kind of mistake, contextualization. All that I am going to argue in the following is based on a careful analysis of textual passages, which are abundantly quoted and translated. The interpretation I have given to this material is obviously debatable, but it is in my opinion the most rational one can come up with. In the second place, I think there are two pressing reasons why the works I am going to examine require a descriptive approach, even at the cost of being charged of one-sidedness. I hinted at both earlier. The first and most important is that the interpretation of these texts is not always clear, also for specialists in the field. I therefore believe that adopting a different perspective—in the present case, that of contemporary philosophy of mind—can only enhance our understanding of what these traditions were contending. The second reason is that we badly need to show that Indian thinkers were actually doing philosophy. One way to do this is to point out that their doctrines, though not necessarily similar to those of Euro-American traditions, comply with the same requirements—search for truth and application of logical thinking—and are translatable into our conceptual language.

Apart from the explanatory purpose and the endorsement of a comparative perspective, this book aims at addressing a third and final aspect, which is more strictly concerned with the history of Indian thought. I am talking about the influence Bhartṛhari had on the development of Pratyabhijñā's ideas. The importance of the grammarian for the Kashmiri school is not something I am discovering here. Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta (as well as Somānanda, the founder of the tradition) profusely quote the grammarian's masterpiece, the *Vākyapadīya*, and modern scholarship has already examined the issue.⁶ Nonetheless, this acknowledgement has often consisted in noting some general affinities between the two parties, like the fact that both endorse a non-dualistic ontology or defend an epistemology in which language occupies a critical role. Here I am favouring a somewhat different approach to the question. In what follows, I will try to show that Bhartṛhari's contribution to the intellectual construction of the Pratyabhijñā is limited to a very specific set of notions, those strictly related to the development of a higher-order theory of consciousness. This by no means minimizes Bhartṛhari's ascendancy over the Śaivas but rather the opposite: circumscribing the grammarian's impact to one of the most significant parts of the Pratyabhijñā's doctrine actually makes his influence even more significant.

As far as the structure of the book is concerned, the volume is arranged in seven chapters followed by an appendix of translations. The first four chapters

focus on the arguments the Śaivas present against their Buddhist rivals. Chapter 1 provides readers with preliminary information about the authors under analysis, the Pratyabhijñā's, the Buddhists—especially those belonging to the so-called 'logical-epistemological school', the Pramāṇavāda—and Bhartṛhari. This part aims to establish a historical framework for the ensuing discussion, and it also offers a basic summary of the epistemological and metaphysical positions of these thinkers. Chapter 2 illustrates the main arguments the Buddhists advance against the notion of self, taking into consideration both the standard criticism the tradition has voiced against it over the centuries, and the particular shape these arguments assume in the Śaiva literature. Chapter 3 is concerned with the way the Pratyabhijñā pursues its main philosophical purpose, that is to say, how the Śaivas counter the Buddhist criticism of selfhood described in the previous chapter. The Pratyabhijñā's thinkers focus in particular on the mechanism of memory and argue that a past event cannot be recollected without assuming the existence of a permanent self that persists over time. The crucial argument the Śaivas offer is that knowledge is a self-revealing event, and as such, it cannot be the content of other knowledge episodes. This implies that the explanation of memory the Buddhists defend, which is founded on the idea that a past event is recollected through a chain of causally linked cognitions, is inadequate. Chapter 4 continues to explore the notion of non-objectification of cognitions by presenting some possible precursors of the Pratyabhijñā's treatment of the question. In particular, it is concerned with the work of a Buddhist thinker, Śāntarakṣita (eighth c. CE), and more thoroughly, with that of Bhartṛhari, arguably one of the first Indian thinkers to advance this idea. Chapters 5 to 7 have a more philosophical slant and discuss the most innovatory aspects of the philosophy of the Recognition. Chapter 5 analyzes the main features of Utpaladeva's theory of consciousness, it elucidates its conceptual and linguistic nature, it shows how crucial was the influence of Bhartṛhari on it, and it illustrates how the theory is positioned within the contemporary debate. Chapter 6 discusses how the Śaiva intellectuals were aware of the fact that the private, phenomenal dimension of consciousness plays a crucial role in defining what consciousness is. Chapter 7 examines some specific problems—such as the disputable claim that in cognizing something one is always aware of oneself as the subject of knowledge—and more in general what kind of self and personhood the Pratyabhijñā thinkers have in mind when they talk about self or personhood. In it I also argue that Utpaladeva's philosophy is best understood as a form of panpsychism. The appendix contains the translation of selected passages from the works under consideration, passages that are relevant to the case I am making. This serves two purposes: it is useful to Sanskritists, who can relate my affirmations to the original texts, but it also provides the non-Sanskritists with a first-hand experience of how Indian philosophical texts proceed.

This last remark leads me to the audience I had ideally in mind while writing this book, an audience that is made up of both philosophers and specialists in South Asian culture. As for the philosophers, I have to say clearly that it is not my intention to contend that Pratyabhijñā's or Bhartṛhari's theories of consciousness are unattackable, bulletproof interpretations, provided theories of that sort exist.

Much more humbly, I hope I have been able to push the idea that these thinkers had something important to say, among several other things, on the problem of consciousness. As for the South Asian specialists, my ambition is a little greater. I hope to have spelled more precisely what these thinkers were arguing for, to have shown how and to what extent Bhartṛhari contributed to the Pratyabhijñā's doctrine, and to have made clear that the overall influence of this philosopher and grammarian goes well beyond the realm of traditional grammar and semantics.

Notes

- 1 The periodization of the history of Indian philosophy is a problem in itself. I am using the term 'classical' in a rather loose way, following the distinction recently proposed by Roy Perrett (2016, p. 7). In the history of Indian thought, Perrett distinguishes an ancient period (900 BCE–200 CE), a classical period (200 CE–1300 CE), a medieval period (1300 CE–1800 CE), and a modern period (1800 CE–present). For an updated and detailed discussion of the question, see Franco (2013). As for the term 'Indian', I am using it as a synonym of South Asian, thus indicating all the modern countries of the Subcontinent.
- 2 There are other valuable books on consciousness and mind in Indian philosophy. Noteworthy are Timalsina (2009a), devoted to the Advaita Vedānta's discussion of the question, and Chakrabarti (1999), focused on the Nyāya school. Jonardon Ganeri has discussed questions related to the topics examined in this book in several publications. See in particular Ganeri (2007, 2012). I discuss the latter in some detail in Chapter 7. Readers keen to know all the details of the philosophy of the Pratyabhijñā, including its theological aspects, are strongly encouraged to consult Isabelle Ratié's exhaustive monograph (Ratié, 2011a) or to directly immerse themselves in Utpaladeva's work, which has been masterfully edited, translated, and annotated by Raffaele Torella (Torella, 2002). For a general introduction to Bhartṛhari's thought, Subramania Iyer's old volume is still very useful (Iyer, 1969). Similar considerations apply to the more philosophically oriented work of Aklujkar (1970). Finally, one can look at a more recent monograph by Jan Houben (1995a).
- 3 A recent book by Peter Park (2013) has convincingly put into question the notion that philosophy was an exclusively Greek innovation. Even though the idea is nowadays deeply entrenched, Park has shown that until the late eighteenth century, there was no scholarly consensus about the origins of philosophy. Indeed, a good numbers of European intellectuals were persuaded that the emergence of philosophical thinking was somehow connected to the wisdom of 'eastern peoples', like Egyptians, Jews, Persians, and Indians. Park claims that the idea of a Greek origin of philosophy was developed and promoted by a group of influential European thinkers, particularly Kant and his followers. Park further contends that this stance was adopted as an ideological strategy to corroborate the then widespread conception that Europeans were a racially superior people. The operation was so successful that the notion that ancient Greeks 'discovered' philosophy, overcoming intellectual backwardness and mythical superstition, has been repeated almost like a mantra in the past two centuries. Thinkers having nothing in common such as Bertrand Russell and Martin Heidegger agreed on the Greek origins of philosophy. The former wrote: "Philosophy begins with Thales" (Russell, 1945, p. 3). The latter concurred with him: "The often heard expression 'Western-European philosophy' is, in truth, a tautology. Why? Because philosophy is Greek in its nature; Greek, in this instance, means that in origin the nature of philosophy is of such a kind that it first appropriated the Greek world, and only it, in order to unfold" (Heidegger, 1956, pp. 29–31). Although professional philosophers are now much more cautious about this sort of sweeping generalizations, the exclusionary attitude is still observable. See, for instance, Pigliucci's position described by Connolly (2015, p. 13).

- 4 See Connolly (2015, p. 83). A powerful argument against incommensurability is the one elaborated by Donald Davidson. Davidson argues against conceptual relativism, especially against Thomas Kuhn's work on scientific paradigms (Kuhn, 1962). This latter view posits the existence of 'conceptual schemes', which are different, incommensurable ways by which humans organize their experience. A crucial notion for the relativist is that a conceptual scheme is expressed in a language that is untranslatable into that of another conceptual scheme ("The failure of intertranslatability is a necessary condition for difference of conceptual schemes", Davidson, 1974, p. 12). Davidson rejects all this by showing that the idea of different conceptual schemes implies a basic paradox ("different points of view make sense only if there is a common coordinate system on which to plot them; yet the existence of a common system belies the claim of dramatic incomparability", Davidson, 1974, p. 6) and by attacking the notion of untranslatability. Although he discusses both complete and partial untranslatability, we can briefly consider just the former, the latter's rejection being based on it. His argument goes as follows. A language and its associated conceptual scheme is something that stands in a certain relation to experience. The point is to understand the nature of this relation. Davidson examines two metaphors that are usually employed to describe the relation. Conceptual schemes either organize something or they fit it. After some discussion, he comes to the conclusion that both metaphors are just colorful ways to say that "something is an acceptable conceptual scheme or theory if it is true" (Davidson, 1974, p. 16). The crux of the whole argument is to discern whether the truth of a sentence is independent from its translatability. For Davidson, it is not. To prove his point, he applies Tarski's theory of linguistic truth, according to which a sentence *s* of a language *L* is true if and only if *p*. Here *s* stands for a description of *s* and *p* as *s* itself in English, or for a translation of *s* in another language. For example: 'the snow is white' (*s*) is true if and only if 'the snow is white' (*p*). The example loses its triviality if *s* is a sentence of another language, like: 'la neve è bianca', if and only if the 'snow is white'. Davidson's point is that the notion of translatability is implicit in that of truth. We can tell that a sequence of sounds is language only because we are able to interpret it in our own tongue. This entails that language is by nature open to interpretation and translatable; otherwise it does would not possess 'language-hood'. On this construal, Davidson concludes that both notions of untranslatability and conceptual scheme make little sense.
- 5 Actually, whether the exoticist approach is definitely over is unsure. Although no serious scholar would today attribute to Indian thought the traits of idealism, spirituality, and anti-rationalism so common in the past, the notion still lingers in the lay perception of the culture of South Asia.
- 6 See, for instance, the discussions in Iyer (1969), Dwivedi (1991), Filliozat (1994), Torella (2002, 2008), Rastogi (2009), and Vergiani (2016).

1 Historical and philosophical contexts

The school of Recognition

The expressions *pratyabhijñā*, *pratyabhijñādarśana*, *pratyabhijñā* system, ‘school of Recognition’, etc., all indicate the philosophical, theological, and ritual theories of a group of authors and spiritual teachers who lived and taught in Kashmir between the tenth and the eleventh centuries CE. These authors belonged to the same intellectual lineage—often in a relationship of master and disciple—and were probably initiated to the same ritualistic tradition, a variety of Śaiva Tantrism. The *Pratyabhijñā* works are part of that prolific and diverse religious and intellectual movement—sometimes labelled post-scriptural exegesis¹—which followed the emergence and the propagation throughout the Indian subcontinent of a specific type of texts known as Tantras. These texts, which presumably did not appear before 400 CE, presented themselves as depository of a peculiar soteriological wisdom that differed both in character and aims from the one revealed in the two classes into which the authoritative texts of the Vedic tradition are usually divided, the so-called *śruti* and *smṛti* (Sanderson, 1988, pp. 660–661). By applying a form of hyper-ritualism, the tantric adept, or *tāntrika*, aspires to achieve various spiritual goals, spanning from the release (*mokṣa*) from the cycle of births to the acquisition of supernatural powers (*siddhis*). Furthermore, by complying to the precepts of a spiritual tradition that entails various degrees of esotericism, transgressive behaviours, and a strict liaison with a guru, the *tāntrika* is able to achieve her religious purposes more quickly than her Vedic counterpart.² However, the Tantras rarely go as far as to negate the validity of the Vedic orthodox systems; much more often, they simply regard them as provisional, imperfect, and hierarchically inferior ways to cope with the knowledge of ultimate things.³ In early medieval South Asia, tantric literature was widespread and covered the whole spectrum of Indian religions, so that a vast body of Śaiva, Śākta, Vaiṣṇava, Buddhist, and to a lesser extent, Jaina Tantras has been preserved.

Following a classification introduced by Alexis Sanderson (Sanderson, 1988, pp. 667–679), Śaiva Tantras can be divided into two main groups. The first one includes the 28 tantras that form the scriptural basis of a tradition known as Śaiva-Siddhānta. Its adherents—who were openly concerned with the civic domain of religion—embraced a dualistic ontology and adopted rituals and social

behaviours which were largely acceptable to the standard Vedic practitioners (Sanderson, 2009a, p. 118). The second group comprises a much more diverse collection of texts characterized by the veneration of terrific forms of Śiva (particularly Bhairava) and/or of his female counterpart.⁴ These texts generally backed a non-dualistic ontology and constituted the scriptural authority of a number of traditions which were far less involved in the public sphere of religion, and whose rituals often displayed transgressive and antinomic behaviours. However, following again a recurrent hermeneutical scheme, the non-Saiddhāntika traditions did not reject the teachings of the Siddhānta but regarded them as preliminary to their own.

The religious setting of medieval Kashmir was extremely diversified, and its culture was the result of the interaction of different traditions. The first major religion to set foot in the valley was probably Buddhism, but Brahmanism with all its tantric varieties followed rather soon.⁵ There are reasons to believe that by the end of the ninth century the Śaiva-Siddhānta and most of the non-Saiddhāntika schools were active. By this period, they started to interact with one another, thus paving the way for that post-scriptural phase that is the main concern of this book. A first watershed moment occurred in the second half of the ninth c. when two crucial works were composed, the *Śivasūtras* of Vasugupta and the *Spandakārikās* of Bhaṭṭa Kallaṭa, a disciple of the former (hereafter ŚSū and SpKā); as Sanderson puts it, they were “the first attempt from the Śākta—Śaiva domain to present a non-dualistic metaphysics and a gnostic soteriology in opposition to the dualistic and ritualistic exegesis of the Saiddhāntika Śaiva scriptures” (Sanderson, 2007, p. 426). Even if these two works were far from being a full-fledged exposition of Śaiva non-dualistic philosophy—they had rather different purposes and were composed in a style that did not allow too much elaboration—they nevertheless quickly gained an aura of authoritativeness and became an object of quasi-sacred veneration for later authors.

The tendency towards non-sectarian debate became finally explicit with the establishment of the school we are directly concerned with. The Pratyabhijñā took shape thanks to the teaching of a series of gurus whose lives covered a little more than a century, roughly from the beginning of the tenth c. to well into the eleventh c. The first exponent of this lineage is Somānanda, a scholar and spiritual teacher whose date has been assigned to 900–950 CE (Sanderson, 2007, p. 411). Somānanda was the first to attempt to organize and philosophically explicate the teachings of Śaiva non-dualism, a task he carried out in the *Śivadṛṣṭi* (ŚD), in all likelihood his only work.⁶ He was a brahmin and was probably involved in the court of the kings of Kashmir (Nemec, 2011, p. 20). The ŚD’s most striking peculiarity is the use of a mixed register, which blends mystical intuitions on the nature of the ultimate reality with philosophical analysis and criticism of opposite views. This has prompted John Nemec to argue that the work “was probably intended for a philosophically oriented audience, but one that was primarily made up of tantric initiates, or for potential initiates who would be predisposed to the scriptural tone and high, if mixed, register of the work” (Nemec, 2011, p. 20).

A radical shift in the purposes and the positioning of the Pratyabhijñā came with Somānanda's disciple, Utpaladeva (925–975), who was undoubtedly the great innovator of the school and its central figure; to his writings we owe the name of the tradition itself and an in-depth exposition of its basic tenets. Most important was Utpaladeva, who put the Pratyabhijñā into the wider inter-religious debate that was at the heart of the classical phase of Indian philosophy. Apart from subtler theoretical differences, the main rift between Somānanda's ŚD and his pupil's works was the latter's being open to the influence of a number of traditions, including Buddhist Pramāṇavāda, Bhārṭhari, Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika, Mīmāṃsā, Sāṃkhya, etc. Scholars have proposed different reasons for this shift, indeed all plausible. Raffaele Torella has hypothesized that the purpose of the school was “to offer itself implicitly as an alternative to the dominant Śaiva Siddhānta, or at least to establish itself as a non-extraneous element” (Torella, 2002, p. xiii). Sanderson, on the other hand, has stressed that the decision derived “from the nature of the commentators' social milieu, which is one of Śaiva Brahmins eager to consolidate their religion on the level of high culture”.⁷ The result is the development of what David Gordon White has defined High Hindu Tantra, an intellectual construction stemming from the necessity of an “internalization, an aestheticization, and a semanticization of Kaula [i.e. antinomic and extreme] practice”. That is to say, “the transformation ‘from a kind of doing to a kind of knowing,’ a system of ‘overcoding’ that has permitted householder practitioners to have it both ways and lead conventional lives while experimenting in secret with Tantric identities” (White, 2003, pp. 219–220). Whatever the reason, Johannes Bronkhorst is certainly right in pointing out that this opening to others implied a radical influence of the adversary tenets on the Pratyabhijñā's ones. And, implicitly, this also proves how remarkable was the capacity of attraction of the Indian rationalist tradition: in the end, even Tantric intellectuals were eventually forced to prove the validity of their theses by recurring to rational scrutiny (Bronkhorst, 1996a).

Utpaladeva's main theoretical accomplishment are the *Īśvarapratyabhijñākārikā*, the ‘Stanzas of the Recognition of the Lord’ (ĪPK). At the same time,⁸ he also composed a first brief explanation of the stanzas, known as *Vṛtti*; later in life (Torella, 2014, p. 116) he analyzed the complex *kārikā-vṛtti*, in a further work, the *Vivṛti* or *Ṭṭkā*, a more comprehensive and detailed commentary which is almost totally lost.⁹ This is certainly a severe blow for the study of the Pratyabhijñā. By judging on the basis of the few fragments preserved, there is little doubt that the *Vivṛti* must have constituted the very heart of the system and had a great impact on the achievements of Utpaladeva's most brilliant and influential successor, Abhinavagupta. After these works, Utpaladeva composed three specific treatises, meant to analyze in greater detail themes he had already touched on in the ĪPK: the *Īśvarasiddhi*, devoted to the defend the notion of God, a task which he carried out by adopting a Naiyāyika point of view; the *Ajaḍapramāṭṛsiddhi*, which aims at proving the existence of a conscious knowing subject; and finally, the *Sambandhasiddhi*, concerned with the defence of the metaphysical notion of ‘relation’ from the Buddhist criticism. To these theoretical writings Utpaladeva added two other works: a commentary on the ŚD, which is only partially preserved, and a popular collection

of mystical hymns, the *Śivastotrāvalī*, which the author composed throughout his life and which was collected by his pupils after his death.

Among Utpaladeva's followers, the most significant is certainly Abhinavagupta (975–1025), who was made acquainted with the Pratyabhijñā tradition by a teacher known as Lakṣmaṇagupta (950–1000). Lakṣmaṇagupta did not leave any work behind, but he is traditionally regarded as a direct disciple of Utpaladeva. Abhinavagupta was truly one of the great intellectuals of India, a polymath who gave outstanding contributions to many fields, from metaphysics to aesthetics and theology. From a philosophical and religious standpoint, his crucial achievement was the systematization of the teachings of the Pratyabhijñā, which he employed as a theoretical device to harmonize the ideas and the practices of the many Tantric currents present in the Kashmir of his time. He also further expanded the boundaries of the tradition by making the interconnection with other schools much more explicit and edulcorated the power of antinomic rituals with the purpose to create a synthesis palatable to a wider audience. Whether Abhinavagupta succeeded in the process of harmonization of the various strands of the so-called Kashmir Śaivism, in terms of both ritual practices and theoretical background, is questionable,¹⁰ but it is out of question that after his intervention many typical themes of the Pratyabhijñā set foot in traditions that were far from the original one, sometimes even geographically. Later in life (Gnoli, 1999, p. lxxxi), Abhinavagupta devoted to the Pratyabhijñā his two main philosophical treatises, both of them in the shape of commentaries on Utpaladeva's works. Probably also relying on an already developed oral analysis of the ĪPK (Torella, 2002, p. xlii), Abhinavagupta composed a first commentary on Utpaladeva's *kārikās* named *Īśvarapratyabhijñāvimarśinī* (ĪPV), later followed by a longer work titled *Īśvarapratyabhijñāvivṛtivismarśinī* (ĪPVV), in which he commented the lost *Vivṛti*. As far the spreading of the Pratyabhijñā doctrines is concerned, there is no doubt that Abhinavagupta played a role that is difficult to overstate. The ĪPV in particular has long been regarded as the literary and philosophical masterpiece of the school,¹¹ the work in which the ideas advanced in the original stanzas are expanded and contextualized by abundant references to views of other schools, which is something that in Utpaladeva's preserved works is often missing. Nevertheless, our appreciation of the originality of Abhinavagupta as a theoretical thinker—at least as a Pratyabhijñā thinker—is inevitably affected by the lack of Utpaladeva's *Vivṛti*. According to a tradition he himself fostered,¹² Utpaladeva composed his three main works with different aims and readers in mind. The stanzas were addressed to those who have already reached the highest level in the philosophical and religious path. For these persons, even the relatively concise form of the *kārikās* is enough to fully realize the message of the school. But those who are, so to speak, in the middle of the path, they must read and meditate the stanzas with the aid of the short explanations provided by the *Vṛtti*, thus eliminating even the slightest influence of alien (and erroneous) doctrines. At the lowest level, those who are still at the mercy of false opinions should approach the Pratyabhijñā's teaching through the *Vivṛti*, the work in which all details are carefully explained and fallacious notions refuted. If this scheme is true—and there is no reason to

doubt it—it is obvious that Utpaladeva’s most interesting work, at least from the point of view of a historian of ideas, is the longest one, the *Vivṛti*, precisely the one that is missing. This inevitably casts a shadow on Abhinavagupta’s centrality as a theoretician of the Pratyabhijñā: as long as the *Vivṛti* remains mostly unknown, there is no way to determinate whether what is contained in Abhinavagupta’s commentaries is the result of original thinking or rather a learned restatement of what Utpaladeva has put forth beforehand. Since the publication of his edition and translation of the ĪPK with the *Vṛtti*, Torella has frequently questioned the originality of Abhinavagupta’s role in building the theoretical edifice of the Pratyabhijñā. He wrote: “Abh.’s contribution to the Pratyabhijñā—in the light of what can be inferred from the hints at and the quotations of the *ṭīkā* [i.e. the *Vivṛti*] contained in the ĪPVV and other passages of the *ṭīkā* which have been handed down to us in various ways—appears far less original than is generally thought . . . it seems clear that the majority of the themes and subjects that Abh. touches on find their direct correspondence—or at least their starting point—in Utp.’s *ṭīkā*” (Torella, 2002, p. xliii). The discovery and publication of fragments of the *Vivṛti* and hence the possibility to access a little more substantial material did not induce Torella to change his mind; rather, it was the opposite. As recently as 2014, he concludes an article dedicated to the lost *Vivṛti* by remarking that “now that it is possible to look, however partially, into the *Vivṛti*, . . . we are no longer allowed to consider Utpaladeva a mere predecessor of Abhinavagupta and that the latter is the great master of the Pratyabhijñā, but we must rather take Utpaladeva, particularly with his Īśvarapratyabhijñā–Vivṛti, as the real centre of gravity of the system, and Abhinavagupta mainly as his brilliant commentator” (Torella, 2014, p. 125). That said, it is also worth to keep in mind that the search for originality was not an issue for the Pratyabhijñā philosophers (Pandey, 1963, p. 166), neither it was in the broader context of Indian culture. However, it remains a concern for modern interpreters aiming at reconstructing history of ideas. Whether certain concepts were introduced by Abhinavagupta or were already present in Utpaladeva’s formulation remains a historically open question, which is relevant also to some of the issues we are going to deal with in the following.

Before proceeding further, it is useful to have a closer look at the works that are the object of our analysis. Utpaladeva’s ĪPK are arranged into four main chapters (*adhikāra*), each one with a title that is meant to give an idea of its content. The first two deal more explicitly with philosophical arguments and are largely devoted to investigating the nature of knowledge (*jñānādhikāra*) and action (*kriyādhikāra*). The remaining two, the *āgamādhikāra* (‘Chapter on Traditional Teachings’) and the *tattvasaṃgrahādhikāra* (‘Chapter on the Summary of Principles’), are instead more concerned with outlining a coherent theological picture. Each chapter (except for the last one) is further divided into sections (*āhnika*, possibly meant to be studied in one day), which usually deal with a circumscribed part of the argument. To each *āhnika* Abhinavagupta assigns a short title in the ĪPV. As for the positioning of the work within the tradition, Utpaladeva is explicit in rooting his *kārikā* in the intellectual framework provided by the ŚD of Somānanda, a text to which he pays homage at the end of his own treatise (ĪPK

4.16). Totally complying with the stereotypical humbleness that dictated the relationship between master and disciple in classical India, Utpaladeva presents his work as a simple restatement of the ‘new path’ (*abhinavo mārgaḥ*) the honourable Somānanda had discovered and expounded. Apart from this rather conventional display of modesty, the difference between Utpaladeva’s purposes and those of his master is revealed by a close reading of the *Vṛtti* commenting on the nature of this “new path”: “This new, straightforward path, has been put forward in the treatise named *Śivadr̥ṣṭi*, composed by the honourable Somānanda, who had a direct experience of the form of the blessed Parameśvara. Having endowed this path with a logical justification, I made it enter the hearts of men”.¹³ According to the passage, Somānanda had “a direct experience of the blessed form of Śiva”, which he revealed in the ŚD. Conversely, Utpaladeva’s motives are apparently more down to earth, for he simply aims at propagating Somānanda’s path by, literally, making it “to enter the hearts of men”. The point is how to accomplish that purpose and to understand whose hearts are in question. As Utpaladeva explicitly claims in the *Vṛtti*, the only possible way to disseminate the Śaiva truths is by use of logical arguments; the intention is to persuade those cultivated and well-read people who, although divided by religious breaches, recognize the value of rational arguments. The centrality of this apparently hasty remark, put at the very end of the ĪPK, is hard to overstate and epitomizes the tone of the entire work. In Utpaladeva’s own words, whilst the ŚD testifies to a direct experience of truth, the task of the ĪPK is to firmly ground this experience in reason and to defend it from external criticism. The quasi clairvoyant nature of Somānanda’s insights is also reinforced by Utpaladeva’s use of the culturally loaded word *sākṣātkṛta*, by which he confers to his master an immediacy of perception that is usually reserved to divine or semi-divine beings.¹⁴ In contrast, Utpaladeva chooses for himself the humble function of a mere expositor. Now all this must be taken with a pinch of salt, since rhetoric is playing a part in Utpaladeva’s affirmations. For instance, even if in the ŚD theological and religious considerations seem to prevail, the work is not at all a purely mystic one, but it also passionately engages with divergent opinions.¹⁵ Likewise, although the overall character of the ĪPK is undoubtedly argumentative and deeply embedded in the philosophical atmosphere of its time, in it theological issues are not entirely passed over.

Another, perhaps even more explicit suggestion that Utpaladeva was more concerned with the philosophical implications of the Śaiva doctrine and less with its theological side can be gleaned at the opposite end of the work, namely at the very beginning, where the author says: “Having somehow obtained the state of servant of Maheśvara and wishing to help the whole of mankind, I am going to give a rational justification of the recognition of the Lord, which causes the obtainment of all success”.¹⁶ Utpaladeva again makes it clear that his main duty is to prove the validity of the Pratyabhijñā doctrine on rational grounds. Yet quite interestingly, he remains vague on how he actually came to gain this doctrine. He limits himself to say that he has ‘somehow’ obtained the status of slavery to Śiva, with a vagueness that is only partially mitigated by the commentary, in which he adds that such a desirable condition is simply due to the grace of the Lord.¹⁷ This looks like a

further indication that in the composition of the work, rational argumentation and apologetics prevail over the phenomenological description of the highest reality, although the demonstration of the latter surely remains the ultimate purpose of the whole Pratyabhijñā's enterprise.

After having expounded his program, Utpaladeva's first preoccupation is to logically justify the existence of the treatise itself. This is a quite typical move in Indian technical literature. An author is allowed to proceed to the actual content of his work only after showing that all that he is going to say is absolutely necessary. Utpaladeva develops his argument in the very first section of the 'Chapter on Knowledge' by setting out with an objection: if the Lord is eternally established (*ādisiddha*) as agent and knower, how can one epistemologically determine his existence or non-existence? Here one should read a bit between the lines and keep in mind that Śiva corresponds to consciousness and self. The question would then become if everyone is perennially acquainted with their own self as the subject of action and knowledge, how can one epistemologically determine the self's existence or non-existence? Utpaladeva's answer is that, even if self is always perceived by everybody (*dr̥ṣṭe 'pi*), its true nature (hence of consciousness and Śiva) is nonetheless not discerned (*anupalakṣite*). This happens because of delusion, a false disposition that precludes people from true knowledge. The purpose of the treatise is thus to establish how things really are by recognizing the self's essential nature. It is also worth appreciating the epistemological finesse of the term 'recognition'. In fact, what is at stake is not to determine the self (or Śiva) by means of a new cognition. That would be a purposeless effort, for the self is ever established. The point is rather to dispel delusion, to overcome the idea that there is something different from consciousness, and to recognize that the entire reality is indeed a manifestation of consciousness itself. This is, in a nutshell, the task of the Pratyabhijñā's philosophers.

Put in this way, Utpaladeva's agenda may look like one of the many monistic philosophies Indian culture has produced. Yet much of Pratyabhijñā's originality lies in how its thinkers picked up different ideas and blended them to build a coherent picture. A picture that is, however, unacceptable to the school's main opponents, the Buddhists.

The main adversaries: the Pramāṇavāda school of Buddhism

In the same article quoted earlier, Torella summarizes the philosophical program of the Pratyabhijñā as follows: "The philosophy of the Pratyabhijñā is built upon two main cornerstones, both of them due to Utpaladeva: the above mentioned attitude to the Buddhist pramāṇa philosophers, made of a subtle interplay of attraction and rejection, and the acceptance of the legacy of Bhartṛhari, which had been so openly despised by Utpaladeva's guru Somānanda" (Torella, 2014, p. 125). Utpaladeva's philosophical program is carried out with a specific intention in mind, as the Śaiva aims at showing that which is usually regarded as the most important teaching the Buddha put forth, non-self (*anātman*), is false. The version of Buddhist philosophy which is mostly discussed in the Pratyabhijñā works is the one elaborated by the so-called logical—epistemological school, often indicated

with the Sanskrit term *Pramāṇavāda* (literally the “School of the right means of knowledge”). This tradition emerged in the early sixth c. CE, thanks to the work Dignāga,¹⁸ whose ideas were later refined and expanded by Dharmakīrti (sixth or seventh c. CE),¹⁹ one of the most outstanding figures of South Asian intellectual history. The school combines the soteriological emphasis of earlier Mahāyānic traditions with an extremely sophisticated epistemological discourse, and it was often engaged in polemics with Brahmanical schools, particularly Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā.²⁰

Many arguments developed by the *Pramāṇavāda* are discussed throughout this book; nevertheless, it is useful to have a preliminary look at the main positions of the school on ontology and epistemology. The *Pramāṇavādins* claim that reality is reducible to two basic ontological categories, the particular and the universal. One cognizes these two aspects through just two different means (*pramāṇas*) of acquiring knowledge (*pramā*), respectively, direct perception (*pratyakṣa*) and inference (*anumāna*). Brahmanical schools accepted other *pramāṇas*, but the Buddhists dismiss them as particular cases of inference. Ontologically speaking, the bare particular, or *svalakṣaṇa*, is all that truly exists. It is a fleeting entity characterized by causal efficiency (*arthakriyā*), insofar as it appears for an instant—the time necessary to be generated by and generate an effect—and then disappears. Given the right conditions, a *svalakṣaṇa* is able to produce a reliable, direct perception of itself, which is non-conceptual and immediate. But, crucially, the *svalakṣaṇa* is also capable to yield an altogether different kind of awareness, which Dharmakīrti calls *ekapratyavamarśa* (‘unitary judgement’) or *niścaya* (‘determinate cognition’). This second type of cognition arises indirectly. Under appropriate conditions, the perceptual awareness of the *svalakṣaṇa* activates in the mind a latent tendency (*vāsanā*), which is the result of successful applications of the determinate cognition in question that have occurred earlier in similar contexts. This determinate cognition is a universal, it is grasped linguistically, and it is the content of the only other *pramāṇa* the Buddhist epistemologists accept, inference. Whatever comes under this designation has therefore a negative connotation; although useful for practical concerns, it is ultimately a mental fabrication (*vikalpa*) that is only indirectly linked to the real *svalakṣaṇa*. This entails an ontological view whereby reality is conceived as made up of innumerable, instantaneous, and causally active particulars, which are held together by an infinite chain of cause–effect relations. Any objectification of this fleeting stream (be it in terms of self, substance, universal, relation, and so on) is seen as an error whose consequences transcend the philosophical dimension and end up affecting the path to deliverance.

At its core, the *Pratyabhijñā*’s struggle in favour of the existence of a self is an effort to dismantle the epistemological and ontological picture we have just outlined. But different from earlier Brahmanical philosophies, who fought the Buddhist ideas straightforwardly, *Pratyabhijñā*’s disposition towards Buddhist logic and epistemology is subtler. Although Utpaladeva’s final theses obviously diverge from those of the *Pramāṇavādins*, there are nevertheless points of contact between the two sides. In general, one gets the feeling that the Śaivas had an attitude of acceptance of some basic technicalities of Buddhist epistemology—like the

self-revealing nature of knowledge or the idea that cognitions cannot be the object of other cognitions (see also the discussion in Chakrabarti, 2012) but with the crucial stipulation that these technicalities are correctly understood only within Pratyabhijñā's own framework, which requires the existence of a permanent self and, ultimately, of an all-pervading consciousness. A further point of similarity in the complex relationship between the two parties concerns certain ontological outcomes of the Pramāṇavāda, especially those that seem to slide into an idealistic, 'only-consciousness' (*cittamātra*) perspective.²¹ According to this stance, the final result of philosophical analysis consists in realizing that objects of cognitions are confined to the mind and, accordingly, that there is no compelling reason to postulate the existence of external objects.²²

Overall, Utpaladeva's strategy of refuting the Buddhist doctrines is based on the belief that it is philosophically possible to reconcile the supposed persistence of a unitary metaphysical principle with the multiplicity that characterizes the phenomena. Whether this is a viable position is the problem that besets any form of non-dualism, hence an issue several Indian thinkers have faced well before Pratyabhijñā's time. In retrospect,²³ the most influential answer to the question is perhaps that of Śaṅkara's Advaita Vedānta, according to which true reality consists in a unitary and all-embracing principle the tradition calls Brahman. In this perspective, ordinary phenomena are seen as illusory manifestations of Brahman, and the fact that they are perceived as different from the unitary principle depends only on an epistemic error caused by ignorance. Once true knowledge sets in, the illusory world slips away, and what remains is a state of being in which just the single, unitary reality persists. All this, of course, entails that between world and Brahman, there is a total otherness, so Advaitins' strategy to justify non-dualism eventually leads to the conclusion that phenomena are unreal.²⁴ The Pratyabhijñā is following an altogether different path. For the Śaivas, the manifested phenomena and the unitary principle (in their case, the all-encompassing consciousness of Śiva) are regarded as essentially the same. If difference is experienced, the cause is again an epistemic mistake that ultimately depends on the will of the unitary principle itself. In the history of Indian philosophy, this road was not taken by the Pratyabhijñā only. There are reasons to believe that certain, pre-Śaṅkarian strands of Advaita Vedānta were more cautious in negating the reality of phenomenal experience, but unfortunately, the literary traces those traditions left are scant at the most.²⁵ In the Brahmanical milieu, there is only one thinker whose work is adequately preserved and who seems to have explored the possibility of a 'dynamic' version of non-dualism in which the reality of ordinary experience is retained. This thinker is Bhartṛhari, an author the Pratyabhijñā philosophers knew very well.

The main ally: Bhartṛhari and his legacy within the Pratyabhijñā

In the article quoted in the previous section, Torella mentions a second 'cornerstone' on which Pratyabhijñā's thought is built, which is the legacy of Bhartṛhari

(460–510 CE). The author in question is another looming figure in the intellectual history of South Asia. First and foremost a Sanskrit grammarian—no doubt the most influential to have lived in the common era—he was responsible for broadening the interests of traditional grammar (*vyākaraṇa*) by exploring a variety of concerns that was unknown to his predecessors. Not that in premodern India, the analysis of language was unheard of; rather the opposite. Bhartṛhari was rooted in a very ancient tradition of grammatical investigation that reaches back into the work of Pāṇini (possibly fourth c. BCE)—the first known intellectual to analyze and systematize Sanskrit—whose extant work, the *Āṣṭādhyāyī*, remains a mainstay in the history of human linguistics. Pāṇini's mainly morphological analysis of Sanskrit was carried on in the third c. BCE by Kātyāyana, who glossed the *Āṣṭādhyāyī* with his *vārttikas*, and by Patañjali, the author of a lengthy and systematic commentary known as *Mahābhāṣya* (second c. BCE), which incorporates also Kātyāyana's glosses. These three authors are often referred by later tradition as the 'three sages' of grammar (*munitraya*), and after a few centuries, they gained such an authority in the field that their figures ended up being almost divinized (Deshpande, 1993). Bhartṛhari is the fourth character in this lineage, even if the gap between him and his closer predecessor, Patañjali, is no doubt significant. Bhartṛhari's date was established in the 1960s by Erich Frauwallner (Frauwallner, 1961, pp. 129–135), who worked on a number of citations of Bhartṛhari he was able to trace in Buddhist literature. Frauwallner's main clue for dating the grammarian were the reasonably established dates of two authors—Vasubandhu, the Buddhist author of the *Abhidharmakośa*, who is thought to have lived between 400 and 480 CE, and Dharmapāla, who was probably active between 530 and 561. Frauwallner first established the date of Dignāga. Since the latter explicitly mentions Vasubandhu and one of his works is commented by Dharmapāla, he must necessarily have lived between the two. Moreover, Dignāga quotes Bhartṛhari, and this obviously proves that he must have been active after him. The decisive fact to set an even more precise date for the grammarian is contained in a passage of Bhartṛhari's masterwork, the *Vākyapadīya* (VP), in which the author refers to his teacher, whose name, Vasurāta, is revealed by the commentator Puṇyarāja. Now a grammarian named Vasurāta is mentioned in a biography of Vasubandhu composed by Paramārtha. Such Vasurāta, we are told, was a contemporary and a fierce rival of Vasubandhu. Elaborating on all this information, Frauwallner concluded that this Vasurāta must have been the same man Puṇyarāja regards as Bhartṛhari's teacher. On this basis, he dated the author of the VP to the second half of the fifth c. CE, a date that has never seriously been questioned so far.²⁶

We have little information on Bhartṛhari's life, and what we have is largely spurious. As for the works he composed, we can be reasonably sure of only two.²⁷ A commentary on Patañjali's *Mahābhāṣya*, which is only partially preserved (Iyer, 1969, pp. 4–5), and his masterpiece, a long, independent treatise on various aspects of language known as 'Treatise on Sentence and Word', or *Vākyapadīya*. The VP is composed of roughly 2000 *kārikās* in *anuṣṭubh* meter; it is divided into three main chapters, each dealing—at least in theory but the subdivision is often fuzzy—with a specific topic. The first chapter is mainly dedicated to the

philosophical foundations of the work, dealing with ontological and epistemological notions alongside linguistic ones; the second is largely focused on establishing that in semantics, the prominent linguistic unit is the sentence and not the word; the third, divided in turn in 14 subchapters (*samuddeśas*), is a vast and mixed section that discusses in detail linguistic and philosophical problems the other two chapters just touch upon. It is the VP that shows how Bhartṛhari extended the range of topics a grammarian can discuss. Apart from the analysis of purely linguistic issues—which is surely present—the text is so infused with philosophical preoccupations that on the whole, the work is less as an investigation of the grammatical technicalities of Sanskrit than an in-depth exploration of how language is related to the way humans understand reality and act in the world. Bhartṛhari possibly composed a further work, a commentary on the first two chapters of the VP, known as *Vṛtti*. The attribution of this work to the author of the *kārikās* is a matter of fact for the whole ancient tradition, but it has been put into question by modern scholarship. On the basis of philological and conceptual grounds, some scholars have claimed that the commentary must have been composed by a later author.²⁸ Others, on the other hand, prefer to remain faithful to the tradition, thus considering Bhartṛhari the author of both the stanzas and the commentary thereon.²⁹ As of today, the question is not yet settled. The reasons adduced by the supporters of a different authorship of the *Vṛtti* are sometimes well grounded, yet they do not seem sufficient to overthrow a long tradition that claims for the same authorship. For this reason, in this book I am adopting the traditional stance, and I will treat the *Vṛtti* as composed by the author of the *kārikās*.

Some words must be spent also on the commentarial tradition the VP generated throughout the centuries. Nowadays, three ancient commentaries are still extant, excluding the *Vṛtti*. The first one, an extended analysis of the first chapter of the stanzas and the *Vṛtti* thereon, is called *Sphuṭākṣarā*, even if it is best known by the generic name of *Paddhati*. Its author is Vṛṣabhadeva or Śrīvṛṣabha. We have no information about him except for the scant details he himself gives in the dedicatory verses of his work. Likewise, his date is unknown, too, even though there are reasons to believe that he must have lived around the eighth c. CE.³⁰ A second work, commenting on the *kārikās* of the second *kāṇḍa*, is ascribed to Puṇyarāja. A third one, a commentary on VP's third chapter, was composed by an author named Helārāja. Puṇyarāja's and Helārāja's dates and geographical collocation are a controversial issue: their activity has been connected in several ways to the culture of Kashmir, and both might have been native of the valley. Nevertheless, our present knowledge does not allow more than some tentative hypotheses. In the case of Puṇyarāja, he himself mentions the name of his master, Sāśāṅkaśiṣya, in his work. For this reason, it has been suggested that Puṇyarāja could have been the disciple of a certain Sahadeva (a commentator on Vamana's *Kāvyālaṅkārasūtra*), in turn a disciple of Śāśāṅkadhara. This would explain the name Sāśāṅkaśiṣya (literally, 'pupil of Sāśāṅka') attributed to Sahadeva. Both Śāśāṅkadhara and Sahadeva were active in Kashmir (Iyer, 1969, pp. 41–42).³¹ Helārāja's relations with the valley can be established on slightly firmer grounds. As Iyer points out,

the name Helārāja is mentioned in Kalhana's *Rājatarāṅgiṇī* (twelfth c. CE), in reference to an earlier author who himself too wrote on the history of Kashmir. Moreover, Iyer noticed that Helārāja's father bore the name of Bhutirāja, which is the same of one of Abhinavagupta's gurus.³² Finally, in his commentary on the *Bhagavadgītā*, Abhinavagupta tells that also Bhutirāja's son (therefore, perhaps, Helārāja) was one of his teachers. On this basis, Iyer sees the possibility that Helārāja was one of Abhinavagupta's preceptors, thus dating him to the tenth c. (Iyer, 1969, pp. 39–40).

Although all these details may sound overwhelming, the hint at a relationship between Bhartṛhari's commentators and Kashmir's intellectual atmosphere is important and should not be brushed aside hastily. In particular, the connection between Helārāja and Abhinavagupta could have been a major cause for the attraction the Pratyabhijñā philosophers felt for Bhartṛhari's thought. Concerning this attraction, however, something more must be said, because it is an attitude that emerges only in the mature phase of the Pratyabhijñā. In fact, at an earlier stage of the school, Somānanda adopted a quite different stance on Bhartṛhari, and in the ŚD, he dedicated himself to dismantle one of the most renowned theories of the VP, the one concerned with the differentiation of language into different levels.³³ Somānanda's criticism boiled down to show that the level of language the VP regards as the highest (called *paśyantī vāc*) is actually superseded by a further one (*parā vāc*). It has been noted that the tone of Somānanda's reproach is particularly harsh and the arguments sophistic (Torella, 2008, pp. 509–513; Nemec, 2005). Quite tellingly, in a rather famous verse, Somānanda concludes that grammarians should not deal with philosophical thinking, for it is something beyond their capacities.³⁴ All this criticism seem to disappear in Utpaladeva's texts, and the change of attitude towards Bhartṛhari is clearly a dividing line between an early phase in the history of the Pratyabhijñā, encapsulated in the ŚD, and a mature one, culminating in the works of Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta. It is therefore not surprising that the fact has attracted the interest of scholars, who have been puzzled by how quickly—the time of a generation—the consideration and the status of a thinker changed within the same intellectual circle. Readers can find extensive treatments of the question in several sources, particularly in one of Torella's contributions (Torella, 2008).³⁵ In it the turnaround of Somānanda's followers is analytically studied, with a special stress on Utpaladeva's double standard—very understated and controlled while acting as Somānanda's loyal commentator in the ŚD but clearly influenced by Bhartṛhari's ideas as an independent thinker.

As for this book, it does not advance new hypotheses as to *why* Utpaladeva changed the Pratyabhijñā's attitude towards Bhartṛhari. My main concern is rather to understand *how* Bhartṛhari influenced Utpaladeva, in particular how certain ideas the grammarian developed were crucial to the Śaiva's conception of consciousness. To appreciate all this, we must start by examining this Pratyabhijñā's central apologetic argument, that is, the notion that a mental episode, a cognition, can never be treated as a content of knowledge.

Notes

- 1 For an in-depth overview of Śaiva post-scriptural exegesis, see Sanderson (2007).
- 2 As Torella puts it: “These texts give voice to a need for a more direct participation in the experience of the divine, no longer seen as a transaction managed by specialized personnel with a view to obtaining clearly defined and circumscribed benefits—culminating in an impersonal liberation projected into an indefinite future—but as a transfiguration here and now of the whole person, whose components, including the purely physical, become the very protagonists of the path of the liberation and not the unwelcome extras” (Torella, 2002, p. x).
- 3 This passage from the *Kulārnavatantra* is quite suggestive: “The Veda is higher than everything [else]; the Vaiṣṇava [teachings] are superior to the Veda. The Śaiva [teachings] are higher than the Vaiṣṇava [teachings]; the teachings of the Right are higher than the Śaiva. The teachings of the Left are higher than those of the Right; those teachings ‘whose end is realization’ (Siddhānta) are higher than those of the Left. The Kaula teachings are higher than those teachings whose end is realization. There is no [teaching] whatsoever that is higher than the Kaula”. Cited in White (2003, p. 152). According to André Padoux: “Le traditions tantriques, en général, ne rejettent toutefois pas complètement le tradition brahmanique issue du Vēda. Elles la considèrent comme valable, mais seulement sur un plan inférieur, comme un enseignement ou des règles générales de base aux—quels s’ajoutent sans le oblitérer le règles plus spéciales, plus hautes des tantras” (Padoux, 2010, p. 29).
- 4 Sanderson enlists nine main non-Saiddhāntika systems: (1) the cult of Svachchanda-bhairava and his consort Aghoreśvarī, put forth in the *Svachchandatantra*; (2) that of Caṇḍa Kāpālīnī, taught in the *Picumata/Brahmayāmala*; (3) that of the sisters Jayā, Vijayā, Jayantī, and Aparājita, taught in the *Vīṇāśikha*; (4) that of the goddesses Parā, Parāparā, and Aparā, taught in the *Siddhayogeśvarīmata*, the *Mālinīvijayottara*, and other texts, destined to be known later in Kashmir as the Trika system; (5) the cult of Kālasamkarṣiṇī Kālī, taught in the *Jayadrathayāmala* and in the scriptures of the Krama in Kashmir; (6) the cult of Kubjikā in the *Kubjikāmata*; (7) the cult of Tripurasundarī put forth in the *Vāmakeśvarīmata*; (8) the cult of the Nityā goddesses, taught in the *Nityākaula*; and (9) the cult of Amṛteśvara and his consort Amṛtalakṣmī, taught in the *Netratantra*. All these texts and cults can be further divided into those belonging to the ‘Mantra corpus’ (*mantrapīṭha*) and those belonging to the ‘Vidyā corpus’ (*vidyāpīṭha*). In the first case, the cult is directed at the male deity Bhairava, whereas in the second case, the focus shifts on the goddess, who, venerated in the form of power (*śakti*) of the god, tends to assume a more prominent role. Moreover, it must also be noted that the Vidyāpīṭha corpus often sanctions more esoteric and antinomic practices than the Mantrapīṭha one.
- 5 A religious history of Kashmir is reconstructed by Sanderson (2009a). See also Funiyama (1994).
- 6 It is not totally clear whether Somānanda composed also an auto-commentary on the ŚD, even if it looks improbable. See Nemec (2011, pp. 14–15).
- 7 As for the social milieu of these authors, Sanderson has shown that most of them bore the royal title of Rājānaka, indicating their position as royal ministers. The fact that they were close to the court is also suggested that they contributed to “belles—lettres and the theory of poetry, drama, dance, and music”. See Sanderson (2007, pp. 240–241).
- 8 This what Abhinavagupta says. See the remark in ĪPVV I, p. 16: *sphuraṇaprārambhah sūtre sphuraṇanirvāhas tu vṛttāu iti paramārthata aiḥyam anayor ekakālākṛtatvāt*.
- 9 In recent years, scholars have reconstructed several fragments of the *Vivṛti*, mainly on the basis of marginal annotations found in manuscripts of other works. See Kawajiri (2016a, 2016b), Ratié (2015, 2016, 2017), and Torella (1988, 2007a, 2007b, 2007c, 2007d, 2012a).

- 10 As Sanderson points out, the idea that existed a single, unitary body of practices and beliefs called Kashmir Śaivism, even after the synthesis operated by Abhinavagupta, is incorrect: “The persistent term ‘Kashmir Śaivism’ or ‘Kashmiri Śaivism’ is therefore doubly misleading. Its current use is mistaken because it excludes the Siddhānta, but it also confuses by fostering the illusion that non-Saiddhantika Śaivism was a single, doctrinally unified whole” (Sanderson, 2009a, p. 123).
- 11 The following passage from K.C. Pandey’s pioneering monograph on Abhinavagupta can be taken as an example of this attitude: “The fact . . . is that the philosophical system of Kashmir, with Abhinava’s contribution to it left out of consideration, loses most of its importance. His contribution to the ‘Realistic Idealism’, is of the same nature as that of the great Śaṅkara to the monistic idealism of the Vedānta” (Pandey, 1963, p. 167).
- 12 The distinction is introduced by Abhinavagupta in the *ĪPVV* (I, p. 2–3), but that the idea is already considered in the *Vivṛti* is clear from the commentary. The three works are also associated with the three different levels of language. The *vaikhari* level, the audible language, is associated with the *Vivṛti*; the *madhyamā* level, the mental language, with the *Vṛtti*; and the *paśyantī* level, the subtle and timeless language, with the *kārikās*. See Torella (2002, p. xlii).
- 13 *so ’yam avakra evābhinavo mārgaḥ sākṣātkṛtaparameśvarabhaṭṭārakākāir bhaṭṭaś-rīsomānandapādaiḥ śivadarśināmni prakaraṇe mayā yuktinibandhanena hṛdayaṃ gamikṛtaḥ* (ĪPKVṛ 4.16). All translations in the book are mine, except when explicitly noted.
- 14 The expression *sākṣātkṛta* was originally reserved to the Vedic seers, the *ṛṣis*. On this point, see the lengthy discussions by Aklujkar (2009) and Wezler (2001).
- 15 In Torella’s words: “he [Somānanda] alternates expositions of a non-dualistic doctrine that is felt to be still very near to its scriptural sources—though these cannot be clearly distinguished—logical justifications, visionary tirades and summary dismissal of opposing doctrines” (Torella, 2002, pp. xiv–xv). Nemec claims that the ŚD was probably written for a circle of tantric initiates with philosophical interests (Nemec, 2011, p. 13). Its tone is thus set somewhere between those of the SpKā and ŚSū and that of the ĪPK: “the ŚD is rather more philosophically oriented than the more yogically and/or mystically inclined SpKā and ŚSū, while being simultaneously more theologically oriented and coloured by scripture than the ĪPK” (Nemec, 2011, pp. 17–18).
- 16 *kathamcid āśādyā maheśvarasya dāsyam janasyāpy upakāram icchan / samastasam-patsamavāptihetum tatpratyaabhijñām upapādayāmi //* (ĪPK 1.1.1).
- 17 *parameśvaraprasādād eva labdhā°*.
- 18 On Dignāga, see the seminal work of Hattori (1968). For a reconstruction of the Sanskrit text of his masterwork, the *Pramāṇasamuccaya*, from Tibetan sources, see Steinkellner (2005).
- 19 On this giant figure of Indian and Buddhist philosophy, the best succinct introduction is Eltschinger (2010). Valuable and more extensive works are Dreyfus (1997) and Dunne (2004).
- 20 The engagement between the school of Dignāga, the Mīmāṃsā, and the Nyāya possibly ignited the most fertile phase of classical Indian philosophy. Scholars, such as John Dunne have emphasized that the Buddhists, the Mīmāṃsakas, and the Naiyāyikas, shared common theoretical presuppositions and a common language, notwithstanding their conflicting views (Dunne, 2004). Other scholars, such as Vincent Eltschinger, have instead stressed that the relationship between the parties was quite conflictual and that the logical-epistemological school of Buddhism occurred as a reaction to the harsh, anti-Buddhist scolding that rose in the Brahmanical milieu from around the sixth c. CE onwards, an attitude that is epitomized in the works of the Mīmāṃsā philosopher Kumāṛila (Eltchinger, 2014, pp. 154–190). See also Eltschinger (2007).
- 21 The term *cittamātra* is traditionally used to describe the doctrines of the Yogācāra (or Vijñānavāda) school, a philosophical tradition based on the teachings of the

- Samdhinirmocanasūtra* (composed around the second c. CE), whose most influential thinkers were Aśaṅga, Vasubandhu, and Maitreya-nātha (all lived in the fourth c. CE). The school typically maintains that the perception of external phenomena is exclusively caused by the activity of the mind, without any need to assume the existence of external realities. For an overview of the tradition, see Westerhoff (2018, pp. 140–216).
- 22 Nevertheless, whether this attitude can be ascribed to the earliest Pramaṇavādins, such as Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, is open to debate. For an updated discussion of the question, see Kellner (2017).
- 23 It is actually quite sure that in the classical period Advaita Vedānta's influence was relatively modest. Much of the preeminent status the tradition has gained over time is due to later—modern and early contemporary—historiography.
- 24 The differences between these two approaches to non-dualism are well illustrated by Alper (1979).
- 25 The scarce information we have on pre-Śaṅkarian Advaita Vedānta—often just the names of authors quoted in later works—are presented and discussed in Nakamura (1983).
- 26 A potential challenge to Bhartṛhari's date has come recently from the work of Helmut Krasser, who has proposed an earlier date for some crucial Buddhist philosophers, including Dignāga. If the hypothesis was confirmed, Bhartṛhari should be dated a century or so earlier. However, since Krasser's conjecture is still controversial, in the following, I shall abide by the standard date. See Krasser (2012) for further details.
- 27 It is not clear whether the grammarian Bhartṛhari was also the author of a well-known collection of epigrammatic poems, the *Subhāṣitatriṣaṭī* or *Śatakatrayam*, which is ascribed to an author with the same name. The present scholarly persuasion is that they are two different persons (Iyer, 1969, pp. 10–14; Kusambi, 1948). Furthermore, Kashmirian sources, including the authors under discussion in this book, attribute to Bhartṛhari another work, now lost, whose title is *Śaddhātusamikṣā*. For an extended and updated discussion of this work, see Ratié (2018).
- 28 The first to suggest that the *Vṛtti* could have been composed by another author was Madeleine Biardeau. Biardeau's argument is based on three kinds of evidence. The first consists of passages of the *Vṛtti* that seem to be at odds with what is stated in the stanzas. The second kind revolves around the idea that the commentary is using a technical terminology that was not in use at the end of the fifth c., when Bhartṛhari presumably composed the *kārikās*. In this regard, Biardeau considers the use of the terms *vivarta* and *pariṇāma*. According to her interpretation, in the *kārikās*, both words express the generic notion of 'evolution', that is, they indicate the transformation of the unitary metaphysical principle, Brahman, into the differentiated phenomena of experience. By contrast, the *Vṛtti* seems to hint at a fine-grained distinction between the two concepts, with *vivarta* indicating an 'illusory transformation', which actually does not take place, whilst *pariṇāma* expressing a 'real' evolution of Brahman into something else. The distinction between the two terms is a standard notion of classical Advaita Vedānta and Biardeau takes it as a proof of the later composition of the *Vṛtti*. The third and final argument consists in the fact that the *Vṛtti* seems to allude to the division of Mīmāṃsā in the two sub-schools of Bhāṭṭas and Prābhākaras, something that Biardeau does not detect in the stanzas. Biardeau's view against the single authorship has been adopted later on by other scholars, in particular Johannes Bronkhorst and Jan Houben. Bronkhorst focuses on passages where the *Vṛtti* appears to contradict the stanzas (VP 1.6, 1.13, 1.99, and 1.159) and on the problematic use of the epithet *tatrabhāvān*, 'honourable', attested in the *Vṛtti* to indicate the author of the stanzas, which must therefore be a different one. For his part, Houben takes into account a passage of the *Vṛtti* on VP 1.46 already discussed by Bronkhorst (1988) and Aklujkar (1993b). The first *pāda* of this stanza runs as follows: *ātmabhedaṃ tayoḥ kecid astīti āhuḥ purāṇagāḥ*. The *kārikā* refers to an essential difference (*ātmabheda*) that exists between two kinds of

word (*upādānaśabda*). The problem with the sentence is the presence of the accusative case in *ātmabhedam*. Considering the syntactical construction, one should expect *ātmabhedah*, with the nominative ending. The point is commented in the *Vṛtti* with the following expression: *ātmabhedasya bruvikarmatve dvitīya vākyasvarūpānukaraṇe tu prathamā*. In Iyer's translation: "when the word 'essential difference' is the object of the verb *brū* (*āhuḥ*) it takes the second case-affix (*dvitīyā*) but when the whole sentence as uttered by the followers of tradition is imitated it takes the first-case affix". This remark of the *Vṛtti*, which justifies both readings of *ātmabheda*, is taken by Houben as a proof that the authors of the two texts were different: "whether we interpret it in accordance with possibility a): the *Vṛtti* author is confronted with two different readings: or b): the *Vṛtti* author acknowledges the only one reading in the *kārikā* and mentions the other one on his own accord; in either case (c): the author of the *Vṛtti* must have been different from the *kārikā*, unless we assume (d): that the latter was a debutant, uncertain about his own capabilities and ready to interrupt his discourse on subtle philosophical issues with apologetic, technical comments on his choice of words" (Houben, 1997c, pp. 182–184). See also Biardeau (1964a); Bronkhorst (1988, 1991); Houben (1997a, 1997b).

- 29 The most notable advocate of the single-authorship view is Ashok Aklujkar. He generally disagrees with what seems to be the basic assumption of the supporters of separate authorship. According to them, every time the *Vṛtti* provides alternative explanations of the *kārikās*, one has to suspect a different author for the commentary. Aklujkar is clear in rejecting this premise, as he writes: "What seems to be different explanations are also statements of different theses and thoughts acceptable to Bhartṛhari on different levels and in different contexts". On the contrary, he contends that every *kārikā* is crafted with the purpose of being deliberately generic and vague and therefore ready to be integrated and explained by the *Vṛtti*. This implies that the text was conceived by Bhartṛhari as articulated in two different levels since the beginning and that *kārikās* and *Vṛtti* must be read as a single work. In this regard, Aklujkar is very clear: "No only I do uphold the validity of the traditional ascription, but I also maintain that the V [Vṛtti] is an inseparable part of the *Vākyapadīya* and that is wrong to think of the *Vākyapadīya* as a work consisting of the *kārikās* only" (Aklujkar, 1972, p. 184). See Iyer (1969, pp. 17–40) for a discussion of Biardeau's arguments and Aklujkar (1993b) for a reply to Bronkhorst (1988, 1991). See also Pind (2003) for a discussion of the question from the point of view of Buddhist literature.
- 30 For a discussion of this author and his work, see Ferrante (2013, 2015).
- 31 It is worth mentioning that according to Aklujkar, the commentary on the second chapter of the VP, traditionally credited to Puṇyarāja, must actually be attributed to Helārāja. The latter probably commented on the whole VP, but only the part covering the third *kāṇḍa* is preserved (Aklujkar, 1974).
- 32 Bhutirāja is mentioned in Abhinavagupta's *Malinīvijayavārttikas* (Iyer, 1969, p. 39).
- 33 The notion is elaborated in VP 1.159 and the *Vṛtti* thereon; see Chapter 5 for a discussion of the passage.
- 34 *vaiyakaranatām tyaktvā vijñānānveṣaṇena kim/bhavatām aprastutena na kevalam ihoditam* // (ŚD 2.72).
- 35 The question has been touched upon by other scholars too. See, for instance, Gnoli (1959), Seyfort Ruegg (1959), Dwivedi (1991), Filliozat (1994), and Rastogi (2009).

2 The Buddhist doctrine of non-self

The main preoccupation of Utpaladeva's version of the Pratyabhijñā is to counter the Buddhist criticism of the idea that conscious beings possess a unitary cognitive component that persists throughout lifetime and possibly beyond. Since the Śaiva thinkers defended the idea that all reality ultimately comes down to an all-pervading self, their first task was to take into account and refute the arguments the Buddhist have deployed against the notion of personhood. It is therefore useful, before considering the Pratyabhijñā's reasons, to have a look at how the Buddhist tradition has dealt with the question and how the Kashmiri authors have represented the Buddhist doctrine in their own works. As it happens in most Indian philosophical texts, the first sections of the ĪPK contain the so-called preliminary view, or *pūrvapakṣa*, a part that is devoted to spell the positions of the opponents, with the purpose to confute them afterwards. In this chapter, we first examine some general arguments Buddhism has advanced in support of the doctrine that there is no self. After that, we consider the way in which Utpaladeva has rendered the Buddhist positions in his own works.

The argument from impermanence

For the Buddhists, the notions of 'self', 'I', and 'personhood' are all fictitious. The idea—conveyed in Sanskrit by expressions like *anātman* 'non-self', *nairatmyavāda*, 'doctrine that there is no self', or in Pāli by the term *anattā*—is one of the most original contributions Buddhism has given to the philosophical and religious debate of ancient India. Together with suffering (*duḥkha*) and impermanence (*anitya*), *anātman* is one of the three marks (*trilakṣaṇas*) of existence, and it is often regarded as the key teaching of the Buddha, the doctrine whose comprehension eventually leads the practitioner to the liberation from the cycle of rebirths.

The idea is not mentioned in what is traditionally viewed as Buddha's first discourse—the *Dharmacakrapravartanasūtra* (in Pāli, *Dhammacakkappavattana-sutta*)—but it is addressed in the very next one, the *Anātmalakṣaṇasūtra* (in Pāli *Anattalakkhanasutta*), which is wholly dedicated to the question:

Thus have I heard. On one occasion the Blessed One was dwelling at Bārāṇasi in the Deer Park at Isipatana. There the Blessed One addressed the bhikkhus of the group of five thus: "Bhikkhus!"

“Venerable sir!” those bhikkhus replied. The Blessed One said this:

“Bhikkhus, form is non-self. For if, bhikkhus, form were self, this form would not lead to affliction, and it would be possible to have it of form: ‘Let my form be thus; let my form not be thus’. But because form is non-self, form leads to affliction, and it is not possible to have it of form: ‘Let my form be thus; let my form not be thus’.

“Feeling is non-self. . . . Perception is non-self. . . . Volitional formations are non-self. . . . Consciousness is non-self. For if, bhikkhus, consciousness were self, this consciousness would not lead to affliction, and it would be possible to have it of consciousness: ‘Let my consciousness be thus; let my consciousness not be thus’. But because consciousness is non-self, consciousness leads to affliction, and it is not possible to have it of consciousness: ‘Let my consciousness be thus; let my consciousness not be thus’.

“What do you think, bhikkhus, is form permanent or impermanent?”—“Impermanent, venerable sir.”—“Is what is impermanent suffering or happiness?”—“Suffering, venerable sir.”—“Is what is impermanent, suffering, and subject to change fit to be regarded thus: ‘This is mine, this I am, this is my self’?”—“No, venerable sir.”

“Is feeling permanent or impermanent? . . . Is perception permanent or impermanent? . . . Are volitional formations permanent or impermanent? . . . Is consciousness permanent or impermanent?”—“Impermanent, venerable sir.”—“Is what is impermanent suffering or happiness?” “Suffering, venerable sir.”—“Is what is impermanent, suffering, and subject to change fit to be regarded thus: ‘This is mine, this I am, this is my self’?”—“No, venerable sir.”

“Therefore, bhikkhus, any kind of form whatsoever, whether past, future, or present, internal or external, gross or subtle, inferior or superior, far or near, all form should be seen as it really is with correct wisdom thus: ‘This is not mine, this I am not, this is not my self’.

“Any kind of feeling whatsoever. . . . Any kind of perception whatsoever. . . . Any kind of volitional formations whatsoever. . . . Any kind of consciousness whatsoever, whether past, future, or present, internal or external, gross or subtle, inferior or superior, far or near, all consciousness should be seen as it really is with correct wisdom thus: ‘This is not mine, this I am not, this is not my self’.

“Seeing thus, bhikkhus, the instructed noble disciple experiences revulsion towards form, revulsion towards feeling, revulsion towards perception, revulsion towards volitional formations, revulsion towards consciousness. Experiencing revulsion, he becomes dispassionate. Through dispassion [his mind] is liberated. When it is liberated there comes the knowledge: ‘It’s liberated’. He understands: ‘Destroyed is birth, the holy life has been lived, what had to be done has been done, there is no more for this state of being’”.

That is what the Blessed One said. Elated, those bhikkhus delighted in the Blessed One’s statement. And while this discourse was being spoken, the minds of the bhikkhus of the group of five were liberated from the taints by non-clinging.

(Bhikku Bodhi, 2003, pp. 901–903)

The purpose of the discourse is to establish that the notion of self is delusive. In analyzing the words of the Buddha, one should first examine what he meant when speaking about self. Though the Buddha talks about the notion only in a negative way, the characteristics a self-like entity must possess emerge quite clearly. First, a self must be the essential aspect of the human psychological makeup, the element that persists over time, and which is therefore permanent. Second, it must be an entity that controls and coordinates all other elements of personhood, both physical and mental. Third, an insight on the true nature of self should have soteriological consequences, thus leading to some state of beatitude. An examination of these three features shows how the Buddhist analysis reflects three common notions Brahmanical traditions have adopted to define self since an early period. They viewed the self as a permanent substance (*dravya*) that remains unchanged over time; as something that has the role of an inner-controller (*antaryāmin*), and especially in the Vedāntic and Upaniṣadic literature, Brahmanical traditions also claimed that an insight on the true nature of self leads to bliss and liberation from the cycle of rebirths.

To prove that an entity having such characteristics is a fictitious construction, the Buddha proceeds in a negative way. He starts by defining what the human physical and mental makeup is made of. Thereafter, he shows that none of the elements of this makeup possesses the three defining features of self we have just pinpointed. For the Buddha, human nature can be reduced to five basic components: form, feelings, perceptions, volitions, and consciousness. Collectively known as *skandhas* (Pāli *khandha*), that is, ‘bundles’ or ‘aggregates’, these elements are meant to account for all aspects of experience. Form or body (*rūpa*) indicates any physical or bodily shape; feelings (*vedanā*) designate three specific sensations, those of pleasure, pain, and indifference; perceptions (*saṃjñā*) stand for the mental content of sensory perceptions, such as a patch of blue or the smell of a rose; volitions (*saṃskāra*) indicate the mental dispositions that cause both mental and external activities, like hunger, jealousy, anger, attentiveness, desire etc.; consciousness (*viññāna*) stands for the awareness of one’s own mental contents (Siderits, 2007, p. 36). The *skandhas* are also often indicated by the expression *nāma-rūpa*, literally ‘name and form’. In this latter case, the term *nāma* stands for the four mental aggregates, that is, perceptions, feelings, volitions, and consciousness. They are called this way because they are not perceived by the senses, for they can be expressed only through conceptual activity and, eventually, by means of language. Conversely, the term *rūpa* indicates all that has a concrete, physical nature and is therefore amenable to sensory awareness.

In the discourse, the Buddha is precisely claiming that none of these five aggregates can be the self, because none is permanent, acts as a controller, or is conducive to bliss. Indeed, according to the Buddha, it is precisely the opposite: all *skandhas* are transitory, no one has the characteristics of the controller, and they all eventually lead to affliction. Let us leave aside this last, soteriological aspect of the nature of self and focus on the first two claims, those according to which no aggregate is permanent or acts as the controller of the others. Mark Siderits has

labelled the first the 'argument from impermanence', the second 'the argument from control'. The argument from impermanence can be summarized as follows:

- 1 Since form, feelings, perceptions, volitions and consciousness are impermanent,
- 2 since the human psychophysical makeup consists of nothing but these five bundles,
- 3 and since the self must be by definition permanent,
- 4 the conclusion is that there is no self.

From a logical point of view, the reasoning is evidently sound: if the three premises are true, the conclusion is automatically true. The question is, of course, whether the premises are defensible. Now, premise 3 is unproblematic because those advocating the existence of self maintain that it must be an enduring entity. Premise 1 requires a more thorough discussion. The Buddhists start their argumentation by distinguishing the *rūpa skandha* from the *nāma* ones. In the former case, the hypothesis to reject is that the self corresponds to our physical body. This hypothesis can be formulated in two ways. The first is to suppose that the body is permanent over the course of several lives. Even if it sounds counterintuitive, the hypothesis is quite central for the South Asian context, since the Buddha and most of his contemporary opponents backed the idea of a series of lives combined with the notion of retribution of actions. However, one can defend also a weaker version of the notion that *rūpa* corresponds to self by arguing that a body remains the same for the duration of a single lifetime. As far as the strong version of the argument is concerned, the very fact that a body declines and dies is enough to show that it cannot be regarded as extended over several lives. Accordingly, a body is not at all permanent, and it cannot be the self. But what about the second, weaker alternative? Is it not true that we are strongly induced to think that our personhood remains essentially the same over the years that make up our single lifetime? What would the Buddhists reply to this? Mark Siderits has suggested several answers to the objection (Siderits, 2007, pp. 39–40). Generally speaking, the Buddhist retort would focus on the idea that there is no body as a whole but just smaller parts composing it. These parts are never stable and exist in a state of constant change. More specifically, Siderits considers the case in which the self is conceived as a specific part of the body, such as the heart or the brain. In this regard, if one undergoes a heart transplant, few would agree that after the surgery the person is not the same as before. This principle seems to be valid also in the case of a brain transplant, which is a metaphysically possible scenario. All this seems to point to the conclusion that there is actually no part of the human physical makeup that is permanent. Additionally, one can also argue that living bodies are actually made up of cells that are perpetually renovated (Siderits, 2007, p. 40). This is certainly not an argument the historical Buddha could have put forward. Nevertheless, it is a consideration that further legitimates the Buddhist claim that *rūpa* cannot be the self.

Let us now turn to the *nāma-skandhas*, the mental aggregates. Here the situation is far more complex, since the notion that selfhood is something ingrained in our mental dimension—rather than in the physical one—is stronger and less easy to reject. Here the main contention of the Buddha is that to identify the self with something mental is illusory, because, simply put, there is no such thing as the mind. All that we actually experience in our lives is a series of mental events that come and go in an uninterrupted series. These events are instantaneous—they take place and disappear in a moment—and are linked together by a cause and effect relationship. What normally happens is that this stream of mental events is easily mistaken for a reified entity existing over them, an entity we are used to call mind. But this is precisely an illusion. How strong is the Buddhist argument? For a start, it is not difficult to acknowledge that some of our mental events are actually short-lived and far from being permanent. Think, for instance, to the desire of eating an apple or buying a new pencil. Likewise, perceptions, too, look like transitory. Still, the situation gets more complicated if we consider what Siderits calls “instinctual desires”, volitions that appear to be really entrenched in our human nature, like the will to avoid pain or, adopting Siderits’s example, the desire to escape a life-threatening situation. In this case, these desires look like permanent features of human psyches and therefore as good candidates for the role of self. Still, the Buddhists would keep rejecting the possibility. Their line of reasoning is that these instinctual desires are not always manifest but come to the surface only in certain, unpleasant situations—more specifically, when one has a sensory awareness of something dangerous going on. A fact of this sort can be explained by arguing that there is an inner, persisting tendency to escape dangerous situations, which is latent and becomes manifest only given the right conditions. But also, and this is the position a Buddhist would favour, by assuming that there is a stimulus–reaction link between a dangerous circumstance and our desire to escape it. Differently put, desire to escape is event related: it manifests at due time, disappears, and then resurfaces at another occasion. As Siderits suggests, the Buddhist explanation of instinctual volitions does not postulate the existence of something unobservable, that is, a persisting, hidden desire to escape life-threatening situation. Therefore, on the basis of Occam’s razor or by the corresponding Indian principle of conciseness of explanation (*lāghava*), the Buddhist view on the matter looks like preferable.

It remains to consider premise 2, which Siderits call the “Exhaustiveness Principle”. The main premise of the Buddha’s argument is that the human makeup is made up of five *skandhas*, not one more. It goes without saying that if one is able to prove that in experience, there is actually something more than the five aggregates, the argument from impermanence will be seriously affected. Now, what the Exhaustiveness Principle seems to leave out of the picture is the subjective, private dimension of personhood. By accepting that the five *skandhas* are all that exists, one would grant the existence of physical entities and mental events but of no one to which these entities and events belong. It is important to keep in mind this objection because it is a serious one, and it is exactly the issue the Śaiva thinkers are going to raise against the Buddhist dismissal of personhood.

The argument from control

The second argument put forward in the *Anātmalakṣaṇasūtra* is the argument from control. When the Buddha says “It is not possible to have it of form: ‘Let my form be thus; let my form not be thus’”, he is meaning that *rūpa* and all other *skandhas* cannot work as the controller of others, or, as Siderits puts it, none of them can perform an executive function on the others. The argument from control is based on the idea that something cannot perform the executive function on itself. On the basis of this principle, a self must be an entity on which the executive function is never performed, for it is always the subject of the executive function and never the object. Once this principle is established, the argument proceeds like the one from impermanence. Each *skandha* can actually be the object of the executive function because I can dislike and desire to change my bodily form, my feelings, my perceptions and volitions, my consciousness. If this true—and it is quite evident that it is—then none of the *skandhas* can be the self. Therefore, on the basis of the Exhaustiveness Principle, a self does not exist. Still, the fact that something is performing the executive function is evident and requires an explanation. What is it? If not the self, the only possible answer for the Buddhist is to adopt what Siderits calls a “shifting coalitions” strategy. The idea is that it is never the one and the same part of the supposed personhood that is always controlling the other parts but that this part changes continuously. So, at one time, that which performs the executive function is a coalition between a volition and a perception; for instance, I could see (perception) that my beard is too long, and I could desire (volition) to trim it. In other cases, different coalitions emerge. At this point, an opponent would retort that by endorsing this view, we would get several different I’s instead of the only one I seem to experience when I say, “I have the desire to trim my beard”. In replying to this, a Buddhist would in the end resort to the existence of two levels of truths. The idea is that there is a conventional truth, which refers to the plane our everyday life. At this level, we make use of many conceptual fabrications that are useful for practical purposes—think, for instance, to notions such as those of relation, action, subject, object, mind—but they are not truly real. In fact, there is a second level of truth, the ultimate truth, which corresponds to how things really are. We can attain this level only after we have overcome our own defilements and epistemic biases. In the case of self, the conventional truth is that the word ‘I’ is nothing but a ‘convenient designator’, an expression we use to indicate the apparent persistence of something performing the executive function over time. But things are not really so. The notion of ‘I’ never stands for something ontologically real. From the point of view of ultimate truth, there are neither one controller nor many. The only thing that exists is an uninterrupted series of events, both mental and physical, that are causally linked.

In conclusion, on the grounds of the arguments from permanence and from control, the Buddha concludes that the self is a fabricated notion, more specifically, a mental reification of an endless chain of real, momentary cognitive states

that are glued together by causal relations. In the Buddha's view, to get rid of this conception is possibly the most decisive step one can make towards deliverance.

The arguments from the ĪPK

The arguments I have described in the previous sections remain historically significant in the centuries that intervene between the Buddha's lifetime and the Pratyabhijñā's flourishing. What changed was the interpretation of the ontological nature of the momentary events the Buddhists regard as the fundamental components of reality. The earliest Buddhist philosophy, the one displayed in the texts of the Abhidharma, tended to accept the existence of basic, unchangeable constituents of reality called *dharma*s. On the contrary, the ensuing thought, especially the one developed by the main schools of Mahāyāna Buddhism, brought the notion of causal dependence to extremes, thus advocating the dependent nature of all *dharma*s, and conceiving reality as a perennial stream of mental and physical events. In parallel with these developments, a heated debate on the issue of selfhood started to emerge around the fifth or sixth c. CE and continued until Buddhism declined and eventually disappeared from the cultural life of South Asia. The quarrel saw the confrontation between two sides: the supporters of the real existence of self (which in the following, we are going to call with their Sanskrit name of Ātmavādins), normally Brahmanical authors, and the Buddhists, who kept rejecting the notion. The most important factor in shaping the way the Pratyabhijñā took part in the discussion on the nature of self was the development of the Buddhist Pramāṇavāda tradition, which, as we have seen in Chapter 1, took place between the sixth and seventh c. CE. As it will be clear later, Utpaladeva's rejection of *nairātmavāda* is carried out by employing epistemological and logical arguments that belong to Pramāṇavāda's theoretical framework.

Utpaladeva's discussion about the existence of self is mostly contained in the first chapter of the ĪPK, the 'Chapter on Knowledge' (*Jñānādhikāra*). Utpaladeva's argument against the Buddhist positions hinges on a careful analysis of the nature of memory, a form of cognition the author considers a sort of privileged case study. The reason is easy to see. Since memory is a cognition that is temporally extended, it is somewhat intuitive to associate it with a subject of experience that persists over time. After an initial section in which the author discusses the purpose of the work, the 'Chapter on Knowledge' begins by stating Pratyabhijñā's own position, the so-called definitive view or *siddhānta*. Utpaladeva first provides a typological description of reality by provisionally distinguishing two categories of being, the conscious and the unconscious. However, immediately after, he specifies that this distinction is only apparent, since unconscious entities are ontologically dependent on conscious ones. According to Abhinavagupta's explanation, this is due to the fact that an insentient object cannot be cognized independently from a conscious subject, a remark that makes right away clear the non-dualistic outlook of the school. Accordingly, reality is regarded as made up of a single ontological category, the conscious; non-conscious entities are nothing more than projections of conscious ones. The argument is then expanded by stating that all entities are indeed the manifestation of a single unitary, conscious

being, the self. Self, and conscious beings in general, are characterized by two properties: knowledge and action.¹ All this leads to the conclusion that all reality is to be identified with consciousness, or self, which is ultimately the only existing knowing and acting subject. This basic non-dualistic doctrine, put forth in the very first stanzas of the ĪPK, is philosophically defended in the first two chapters of the work.

After stating his own view, Utpaladeva proceeds by presenting the objections of those who reject the real existence of personhood, that is, the Buddhists. He had probably in mind a vast array of Buddhist literature, from the earliest sources we have considered in the previous section, to the more recent developments in logic and epistemology promoted by the Pramāṇavāda. The breadth of the arguments is already clear at the very beginning of the chapter, where the belief in the existence of self is immediately put into question:

One may object that there is one type of cognition in which the particular appears, and another type, called mental elaboration, which is connected with language and has manifold forms. In either case there is not any permanent knowing subject, since he does not appear in them. Also the notion of “I” actually refers to the body etc.²

This passage prompts some observations. The text clearly refers to the standard Buddhist position according to which the ‘I’ is an illusory notion based on the reification of some components of the psychophysical makeup. But Utpaladeva also makes a more refined, epistemologically oriented observation that reduces the means leading to a veridical cognition to just two: perception (*pratyakṣa*), which is directed at the mere particular, and inference (*anumāna*), which is always linguistically informed and whose content are concepts and universals. We have briefly introduced this notion in Chapter 1 and seen that it was first advocated by Dignāga. So here we have a first clear example of how deeply Utpaladeva’s discourse was influenced by the Pramāṇavādins. Even more interesting is the reason the text gives for not postulating the presence of self in perceptual knowledge or inference. A self, the stanza says, is never perceived in either. The statement, apparently unpretentious, actually hints at another possible means of gaining knowledge, known as ‘non-perception’ (*anupalabdhi*). The status of non-perception as an independent *pramāṇa* is a debated issue in Indian epistemology,³ but in general, the Buddhist traditions did not admit it as a separate means of knowledge, regarding it as a particular case of inference. According to a theory mainly developed by Dharmakīrti, by perceiving the non-presence of an object that is hypothetically perceivable, one can infer its absence.⁴ Dharmakīrti’s argument is obviously open to question, but once accepted, it becomes a powerful weapon against the contention that there is a self, and for a quite simple reason. Those who defend the existence of self conceive it as being always knowable. Accordingly, if the Buddhists can prove that neither of the two admitted means of knowledge, perception and inference, is able to prove the existence of a self, then the only plausible conclusion is that a self does not exist, it is a fictitious notion, it is just pseudo-knowledge.

In the rest of the second section of the ‘Chapter on Knowledge’, Utpaladeva examines a set of arguments against the existence of self, thus implementing a typical strategy of the Indian argumentative tradition: the Buddhist stance is in fact progressively spelled out through a series of hypothetical objections. None of them is actually decisive for the Pratyabhijñā’s view, but all serve the rhetorical purpose of clarifying the *pūrvapakṣa*. Still, this section is of great significance because in it we come across the first discussion of the topic crucial to Pratyabhijñā’s final demonstration of the existence of self, memory. The question is brought up in ĪPK 1.2.3, in which an Ātmavādin claims that memory cannot be explained without admitting the existence of self:

Since the earlier perception has disappeared at the moment of memory, how can memory—being dependent on that earlier perception of the object—arise if the awareness of this perception does not persist till that very moment [of recollection]? This awareness, which persists in different times, is precisely the self, the perceiving subject.⁵

The Ātmavādin’s reasoning looks straightforward. The original cognition takes place in the past and then disappears. If it is remembered, it is because its awareness persists over time. And this persisting awareness is nothing but the self. Nonetheless, in the ensuing *kārikās* (ĪPK 1.2.4–5), the Buddhists weigh the claim and eventually prove it to be false. In doing so, they take into consideration two different ways of intending memory. First, memory can be regarded as the recollection of a thing or event *x*. Second, it can be intended as the recollection of the original perception directed at the thing or event *x*. If the Ātmavādin contends that memory is the recollection of a former perception together with its content *x*, she is mistaken. For once the original perception of an object vanishes, that very perception is irretrievable and so is its content.⁶ Accordingly, postulating the existence of a self is useless. Then the Ātmavādin may try to explore the other option by supposing that memory is a cognition that is directly attending to the original content *x*, without, so to speak, the mediation of the former cognition. Still, in this case, one must explain how the original content *x* continues to exist up to the time of the later recollection. The standard answer to this question is that the original perception leaves a chain of traces (called *saṃskāras*, ‘mental traces or impressions’) that, one after another, bridge the gap between the earlier cognition and the later recollection. But, the Buddhists argue, if one can explain memory in this way, what is the point of postulating a self? Is it not more economical to admit that *saṃskāras* are enough to account for the entire process?⁷ The Buddhists are thus endorsing a mechanistic view of memory in which the ‘impressions’ make all the job and guarantee the connection between the original cognition and its subsequent recollection. Utpaladeva nicely summarizes their position as follows:

From perception derives a mental trace; when memory arises it follows that earlier perception and makes that perception—in which the object is immersed—manifest.⁸

Still, the Ātmavādin would immediately come up with a counterargument.⁹ Even if one agrees on the role played by *saṃskāras*, one must nevertheless define their nature. What are these mental traces? They can only be attributes, that is, qualities of a substance. And this substance, the Ātmavādin would insist, can be no other than the self, whose existence is therefore required. The Buddhist rejoinder to this objection is gripping because it draws on a basic doctrine of their metaphysics, that is to say, on the impossibility to establish a real relation among things.¹⁰ In this particular case, they apply the following reasoning: qualities are either different or identical to a substance; there is no other logical possibility. If they are different, how can they affect substance without modifying its unitary nature? But, on the other hand, if qualities and substance are the same thing, then there is no point in positing the existence of substance. Translating the argument to fit the problem under discussion: if there is a self, what kind of relationship does it have with its qualities? If it could be modified by them, then it would lose one of its most fundamental properties, eternity or permanence (*nityatvam*). But if it is unaffected by qualities, how can it be useful to explain memory? The Buddhist conclusion is, again, that the idea of self is a mental construction.¹¹

A further articulation of the *nairātmavāda* criticizes another typical position of the Ātmavādins, that is, the idea that cognition is a property of the self and therefore it is distinct from it. Again, the main premise is that any relation is eventually unreal. In this case, the one under discussion is between cognitions and self. Cognitions can be conceived as either conscious or inert; there is no other option. If cognitions are inert, they are useless in establishing external objects, but if they are conscious, then they end up being eternal, like the self.¹² But, paradoxically, if one allows that a cognition is eternal, then one is forced to negate that a self possesses such a cognition. The reason is that for the Buddhists, a relationship between two eternal entities—in our case, the cognition and the self to which it belongs—is impossible. Therefore, one must again conclude that the self is a non-existing entity.¹³

To overcome this objection, the Ātmavādin makes another move. She assumes the existence of an intermediate level between the self and the external object, the intellect (*buddhi*). This time the tactic is based on a conception derived from the Sāṃkhya school whereby the intellect has a twofold nature, that is, it is capable of being coloured by the ‘inertness’ of the external object but also fit to reflect the sentience of the self.¹⁴ Yet also in this case, the Buddhists quickly dismiss the argument as inconclusive because to cognize an external object, the intellect must be in the end sentient. And this would lead back to the previous case: what the Ātmavādin calls here “intellect” is again the cognition itself, regarded as sentient. But, as we saw earlier, if a cognition is sentient and eternal, it cannot be related to another sentient reality, like the self is supposed to be by definition. With this last refutation, Utpaladeva concludes the Buddhist *pūrvapakṣa*, and the reader is left with an apparently coherent description of the way memory functions and a harsh criticism of the idea that there is a subject of experience that is capable to know.¹⁵ We can sum up the Buddhist position as follows:

- 1 A self is a fictitious mental construct referring to the body or other components of the psychophysical complex.

- 2 A self is useless to account for memory, which can be adequately explained on the basis of the mental traces (*saṃskāras*) left by the past cognition.
- 3 It is logically untenable to maintain that the self is the knowing subject since it cannot possess a cognition. A cognition can be either conscious or not. If the former, then it would be permanent as the self, and no relation would be possible between two permanent entities. If the latter, then the cognition would be, so to speak, blind and unable to illuminate external objects.

Utpaladeva's rejection of this picture starts immediately after.

Notes

- 1 *vastūnām jaḍajāḍabhedena dvaividhyam. tatra jaḍasvarūpasya jīvanīṣṭhā siddhiḥ, jīvatām punar jīvatvaṃ jīvanam jñānakriye eva* (ĪPVr 1.1.4). "There are two types of entities: conscious and unconscious. With regard to this, the establishment of the proper nature of the unconscious is based on what is living. What makes a living being what it is, that is, its being alive, are knowledge and action".
- 2 *nanu svalakṣaṇābhāsaṃ jñānam ekaṃ paraṃ punaḥ / sābhilāpaṃ vikalpākhyam bahudhā nāpi tadvayam // nityasya kasyacid draṣṭus tasyātrānavabhāsataḥ / ahampratītir apy eṣā śarīrādyavasāyini* // (ĪPK 1.2.1–2).
- 3 'Non-perception', or *anupalabdhi*, is accepted as an independent means of knowledge only by the Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsā and the Advaita Vedānta. These schools argue that it is necessary to postulate the existence of a different *pramāṇa* to account for absence. The rationale is that perception by definition arises from a connection between the senses and their object (*indriyārthasannikarṣotpanna*, NS 1.1.4), so the connection is impossible if the object of knowledge is missing. On the contrary, the Nyāya regards absence as the lack of a specific qualification of the locus. For example, if there is no elephant in my room, it is because the locus (my room) is qualified by the absence of an elephant. Both presence and absence are therefore known by perception, the former directly, the latter indirectly. See Jha (1964, pp. 143–146) and Perrett (2016, p. 102).
- 4 Differently from Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā, Dharmakīrti (PV 3.3–6) argues that absence is inferred. His reasoning is roughly the following: (1) given the right perceptual conditions, if there were an elephant in my room, I would perceive it; (2) I do not perceive any elephant in my room; (3) therefore, there is no elephant in my room. The problem with this account is proposition 2. In Dharmakīrti's view, I know proposition 2 by inference. Nevertheless, it has been noted that this is not totally sound, since there is risk of an infinite regress of inferences (Perrett, 2016, p. 102). On Dharmakīrti's inference, see Hayes and Gillon (1991). On *anupalabdhi*, see Kellner (1997a, 1997b).
- 5 *smṛtikāle pūrvānubhavanāśāt katham pūrvārthānubhavāvaṣṭambhadharmā smṛtir jāyate yadi tadāpi tadanubhavadodho nānuvartate, yaś ca anekakālasthāyī bodhaḥ sa evātmānubhavitā* (ĪPKVr 1.2.3).
- 6 *saty āpi ātmani dṛṣṇāśāt tadvārā drṣṭavastuṣu / smṛtiḥ kenātha* (ĪPK 1.2.4). "Even by accepting the existence of a self, memory is still not explained, for the perception no longer exists, and only through it memory has access to the objects formerly perceived".
- 7 *evam ātmasthairyeṇa kim anupayoginā saṃskārasyātmavāde 'py aṅgikaraṇāt tenaiva ca siddheḥ* (ĪPKVr 1.2.5). "If things are so, what is the point of postulating a useless permanent subject? Even the supporter of the existence of the self accepts the existence of a mental trace, and on the basis of this alone memory is established".
- 8 *anubhavāt saṃskāraḥ saṃskārāc ca smṛtir jāyamānā tam pūrvānubhavam anukurvaty evāvagāhitaviṣayaṃ tam anubhavam ābhāsayati* (ĪPKVr 1.2.5).

- 9 This is a typically Vaiśeṣika line of reasoning. See Torella (2002, p. 92). Also see NSB on NS 1.1.5.
- 10 On the problem of relation in Indian philosophy, see Dravid (1977).
- 11 *smartā draṣṭeva kalpitāḥ*. “The subject of memory is only a mental construct, as is the subject of perception” (ĪPK 1.2.4). *sukhaduḥkhañjñānādibhinnadharmāśrayatven āpi ātmano ‘nupayogo bhinnair dharmair asaṃbhinnasya anupajātaviśeṣasya smrtāv avyāpṛteḥ* (ĪPKVṛ 1.2.6). “The self, even if intended as the basis for qualities that are distinct from it, such as pleasure, pain, knowledge etc., is useless. Being unaffected by modification, and being unrelated to those qualities that are distinct from it, it does not perform any function in the phenomenon of memory”.
- 12 *citsvābhāvyē jñānasya cetyadharmadeśakālāveśayogād ātmana iva nityatādiprasaṅgaḥ. jaḍatve katham arthasyāsau prakāśaḥ* (ĪPKVṛ on 1.2.7). “If a cognition were by nature conscious, the unwanted consequence would be that it would become permanent etc. like the self, because it would be unable to be associated with time and place, which are qualities pertaining to objects. But if it were not sentient, how could it illuminate an object?”
- 13 *evam yadī citsvarūpaṃ jñānaṃ, tat nityavibhurūpaṃ tad apīti ātmāntaram tad iti jñānaheṭuḥ svarūpāsiddhaḥ* (ĪPVV vol. 1. p. 134). “If a cognition were conscious, it would be permanent and all-pervading, then it would be another self. But then [in an inference] the cognition cannot be the inferential sign since its nature is not established”. This remark by Abhinavagupta explains why the Buddhists maintain that both cognitions and self cannot be eternal. If it were so, one would treat cognition as another self, with the same qualities. But in that case, one cannot any longer use the cognition as an inferential sign to prove the existence of self.
- 14 *athārthasya yathā rūpaṃ dhatte buddhis tathāātmanaḥ caitanyam . . .* (ĪPK 1.2.8). “Just like the intellect assumes the form of the object, so it assumes the sentiency of the self . . .”.
- 15 The ĪPKVṛ rounds this up by saying: *tataḥ . . . jñātrṛtvam kalpitam* (ĪPKVṛ on 1.2.11). “Therefore, the notion that the self is the knower is a mental construct”.

3 The true nature of self-awareness

In the third and fourth sections of the ‘Chapter on Knowledge’, Utpaladeva stages the refutation of the Buddhist position on memory and introduces some crucial notions for his overall conception of knowledge and consciousness. His rebuttal of the account we have outlined in the previous chapter revolves around a key idea. For him, a cognition is by nature self-conscious or self-revealing. The idea is expressed in Sanskrit by terms like *svasaṃvedana*, *ātmasaṃvedana*, or *svasaṃvitti*. However, and this is crucial, the very same belief is shared by the Buddhists. Accordingly, Utpaladeva adopts a quasi-Socratic strategy that consists in interpreting the notion so strictly that in the end, the Buddhists are faced with two options: either ditch the idea that cognitions are self-conscious or accept the existence of a subject. For the sake of clarity, I shall divide Utpaladeva’s arguments into two different parts. First, I follow his discussion about the overall nature of *svasaṃvedana*, which has a significant bearing on the way the Pratyabhijñā conceives consciousness itself. Then I focus on a series of more specific objections Utpaladeva makes to the Buddhist account of memory. All his remarks revolve around the fact that conceiving memory in terms of a succession of mental traces is tantamount to imagine a series of cognitions that are the content of one another, a position that for the Pratyabhijñā is untenable.¹

Knowledge of knowledge: a variety of approaches

Before embarking on a discussion of the ‘knowledge of knowledge’, it is useful to spend some words on the way Indian thinkers conceived knowledge itself. Different from Euro-American epistemology that tends to regard knowledge as a mental disposition having the form of a true justified belief, Indian philosophers are practically univocal in considering it an episodic, instantaneous moment of awareness, whose truth-value is guaranteed by the application of appropriate epistemic means. This implies that whenever Indian authors use words like ‘cognitions’ or ‘knowledge’ (thus using Sanskrit terms like *jñāna*, *pratiti*, or *pratyaya*), they have in mind something close to the notion of ‘mental state’. We discuss the question more in detail in Chapter 5. For the moment, it is sufficient to keep in mind that in what follows, I am using the terms ‘cognition’, ‘knowledge’, ‘mental state’, or ‘mental awareness’ rather interchangeably.

Returning to the question of the nature of the ‘knowledge of knowledge’, the issue is a widely debated one in Indian philosophy, and by the time in which the Pratyabhijñā peaked, the topic had long been a source of confrontation among various traditions. In dealing with the issue, it is helpful to reconsider an explanatory model originally developed by B.K. Matilal (1986, pp. 141–179). The scheme summarizes the way Indian philosophers conceived the problem of ‘knowledge of knowledge’ in terms of contrasting propositions. There are essentially two main theses facing each other:

T1: A cognition C1 grasps an object or an event and also itself.

T2: A cognition C1 grasps an object or an event, but in apprehending C1, another cognition, C2, is necessary.

According to T1, a cognition apprehends the object and, concurrently, itself. This practically means that when I see a red apple, I am automatically aware of my seeing. In T2, on the other hand, a cognition requires another cognition (*parasamvedana*) in order to be known. Returning to the previous example, if I see a red apple, I am aware of the content of my awareness, but to become aware that I am aware, a second-order cognition is required. T1 is endorsed by the Buddhist of the Pramāṇavāda school and the Prābhākara school of Mīmāṃsā. It goes without saying that while the Mīmāṃsakas recognize the existence of a knowing subject in the process, the Buddhists do not. This means that for the followers of Prabhākara, T1 comes down to saying that when a knowing subject is aware of something, she is necessarily aware of her own awareness. The ninth c. Prābhākara philosopher Śālikanātha Miśra specified that in a cognitive event, one apprehends the content of the cognition, the cognition itself and the knowing subject. The cognition is therefore regarded as a threefold event (*tripuṭipratyakṣa*). In the case of the Buddhists, T1 simply means that a cognition is self-aware or self-revealing. We shall discuss this position thoroughly in a moment.

T2 is the standard position of the exponents of the Nyāya school. These philosophers would argue that a cognition is normally followed by another one. This ensuing cognition has the nature of an inner perceptual awareness (*anuvyavasāya*, literally ‘subsequent determination’). A significantly different interpretation of T2 is defended by the Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas. For the Bhāṭṭas, the awareness of a given cognitive episode is actually determined by a second cognition. But different from the Naiyāyikas, they would contend that this second cognition is not an inner perception but an inference. Their view is roughly the following: when someone cognizes an object, this object assumes the property of being known (*jñatātā*). On the grounds of this property, the subject infers that an awareness has arisen in her. To put it differently: if I perceive a blue lotus, from the fact that the blue lotus has been perceived (that is, it possesses the property of being known), I am allowed to infer that an awareness has taken place in me.

Now in Matilal’s scheme, this first dichotomy is accompanied by several others. For our purposes, it is sufficient to consider the very next one. The question

is: when I cognize something, am I always necessarily aware of my awareness? The next two theses offer two alternative views on the issue:

T3: Once a cognition C1 arises, it is necessarily conscious of itself.

T4: Once a cognition C1 arises, the fact that such a cognition is also self-aware depends on contingent factors. In other words, it is not true that *any* cognitions is *necessarily* aware of itself. Some cognitions may arise without being cognized.

T3 is defended by the Buddhists (who combine it with T1) and both denominations of Mīmāṃsā (the Bhāṭṭas accept it in combination with T2, the Prābhākaras with T1) and the Vedāntins. T4 is defended by the Nyāya and, in a way we explore more in depth in Chapters 4 and 5, by Bhartṛhari.

To sum up, over time Indian philosophers have accepted three different explanations of the awareness of a mental state. The first (T1) consists of claiming that any cognition is self-aware, thus apprehending its content and itself at the same time. The second (T2) is the position whereby a cognition is made aware by an immediately following inner perception. The third (the Bhāṭṭa's version of T2) maintains that a cognition is known through inference: by perceiving the object, one infers that a cognition has taken place.

Self-awareness in Dignāga's and Dharmakīrti's works

Despite the usual historical uncertainties, we are reasonably sure that the question of the knowledge of knowledge became philosophically relevant when it was formalized by the Buddhist Pramāṇavādins, specifically by Dignāga in the *Pramāṇasamuccaya* (PS).² Besides noting other qualities of self-consciousness,³ there the author maintains that cognitions have a double nature, meaning that they cognize at the same time both their content and themselves.⁴ To give an example, for Dignāga, the cognition of a blue lotus implies both 'the cognition of the blue lotus' and the 'self-awareness of the cognition of the blue lotus'. This is always true for all kinds of awareness. The Buddhist philosopher puts forward three different arguments in support of the claim. In the first place, he argues that if a cognition were to possess just one nature—be it its own one (which he calls the *svābhāsa* aspect) or the object one (the *viśayābhāsa* one)—one would be forced to abandon the ordinary distinction between 'the cognition of a certain object' and the 'awareness that accompanies the cognition of that very object'.⁵ To better understand this point, consider the situation in which a cognition consisted of its object-aspect only. In this case, the self-awareness that always accompanies the cognition would come down to the cognition of the object. It would not be in any way different from it. On the other hand, by supposing that a given cognition possesses only, the *svābhāsa* aspect, one would safeguard the self-awareness of the cognition but of a cognition that is, so to speak, void, and which does not apprehend any object.

In the second place, if a mental awareness possessed just the *svābhāsa* nature,⁶ a later cognition would be unable to illuminate the content of a former one, because the content of the earlier cognition will be gone when the later takes place.⁷

In the third place, memory itself proves that cognitions have two forms: by remembering something, we recollect both the former cognition and its content. This also proves that cognitions are self-aware, since memory applies only to what has already been known. If I remember that I perceived a blue lotus, this means that the perception of the blue lotus has previously been cognized.⁸ It goes without saying that one could explain the awareness of this perception differently, that is, by arguing that the original perception is cognized by a second one, a thesis which corresponds to T2 in Matilal's scheme. Nonetheless, Dignāga rules this possibility out for it would lead to infinite regress. To negate that cognitions are self-aware requires the postulation of a second-order cognition to explain the first, then a third to explain the second, and so on. Hence the conclusion, accepted by the whole ensuing Buddhist tradition, is that any cognition necessarily reveals both its content and itself.

Dignāga's ideas were later expanded and refined by Dharmakīrti, his most influential follower. Rather than insisting on the impossibility to explain memory without postulating the existence of higher-order cognitions, Dharmakīrti's links his discussion with one of his most crucial epistemological tenets, according to which there is no actual difference between a cognition and its content, both being the content of a simultaneous perception.⁹ In this regard, Dharmakīrti claims that a cognition can be cognized only by itself; to suppose that is revealed by another is unsound for at least two reasons. First, one would end up in the rather bizarre situation in which the object is not established at the time of perception—since the perception cognizing it has not yet been established—but it is established at the moment of the subsequent cognition, when the object has vanished. Second, one would again fall into the infinite regress trap: postulating the existence of a second-order cognition to account for the first requires a third-order one to explain the second and so forth.

Pratyabhijñā's understanding of self-awareness

Pratyabhijñā's discussion of *svasaṃvedana* is heavily influenced by the Pramāṇavāda's elaboration we have just examined. Nonetheless Utpaladeva believes that the Buddhist account, though acceptable up to a certain point, is eventually incorrect. As anticipated, the Śaivas aim to show that the way in which the Buddhists conceive the notion of self-awareness is contradictory and that cognitions' self-revealing nature is actually a strong indication for the existence of a self. Let us see how they back this claim and focus on Dignāga's distinction between a content-directed aspect and a self-reflexive one. The Pratyabhijñā authors have no problems in accepting the notion that a cognition and the awareness of its content occur simultaneously, but they emphasize that the two aspects have a radically different nature. Śaivas' attitude towards the question becomes clear if we examine the definition of self-consciousness Abhinavagupta gives in

commenting ĪPK 1.3.2. In the stanza, Utpaladeva is explicitly claiming that a cognitive state is self-conscious (*drk svābhāsaiva*) and cannot be the object of another. But what is most revealing is the explanation Abhinavagupta provides in his commentary:

[In the verse] the word *drś* means “knowledge”. This knowledge differs from what is inert, insofar as its nature consists only of illuminating itself. For what is inert must be regarded as different from light. Hence, the expression “a cognition is self-illuminating” (*drk svābhāsa*) means that: 1) the unfailing nature of a cognition is the capacity to illuminate (*prakāśamānatā*); or that 2) the proper nature of a cognition consists of illuminating itself.¹⁰

The heart of the matter is the interpretation of the Sanskrit compound *svābhāsa*, ‘self-revealing’, which Abhinavagupta understands in two different ways. In the first place, he takes it as meaning that the own (*sva*) nature of a cognition consists in illuminating (*ābhāsa*) something else, a definition that highlights the intentional nature of a cognition, which is innately about something.¹¹ On the other hand, with the second interpretation—according to which the proper nature of a cognition consists in illuminating (*ābhāsa*) only itself (*sva*)—Abhinavagupta emphasizes the fact that mental states have inevitably a reflexive nature, too. Apparently, the Pratyabhijñā was thus reproducing the very same dichotomy between the two aspects of *svasaṃvedana* the Pramāṇavādins had already put forward. Still, there is a radical difference. The Śaivas in fact argue that the Buddhists, though aware of the double nature of cognitions, end up treating the two aspects in the same way, that is, they regard the purely self-reflexive aspect as if it were a content itself. Put another way, they accuse the Pramāṇavādins of holding the view that a cognition is self-conscious but only in the sense that its content corresponds to itself. But this, according to the Śaivas, has nothing to do with the self-conscious nature of a cognition. As we are going to see in detail in Chapters 5 and 6, the self-conscious nature of a cognition consists in the purely private, subjective, intention-free aspect of a mental state.¹² Accordingly, the gist of Pratyabhijñā’s argumentation is that a mental episode is not simply aware of itself as content but only of itself (as often, but not necessarily, having a content, an intention). Using a term the Śaivas often employ, mental states are by nature ‘confined to themselves’, *ātmaniṣṭha*. Accordingly, if the Buddhists define self-awareness in intentional terms, they will infringe the axiom whereby a cognition can never be objectified by another. And this will forbid them from explaining memory as a sequence of cognitions extended over time. The Śaivas’ way out of the conundrum is to accept that, though the *svābhāsa* and *viṣayābhāsa* aspects of a cognition always occur together and are strictly related, they actually differ from one another. It is the *svābhāsa* aspect of a mental state that can never be objectified by other cognitions, for it consists of pure subjectivity or, as the Śaivas prefer to put it, of pure ‘wonder’ (*camatkāra*). In the end, it is this purely subjective dimension that distinguishes a conscious being from a non-conscious one.

The Pratyabhijñā's position becomes even more perspicuous if we recall the discussion on the Exhaustiveness Principle outlined in the previous chapter. The Buddha's arguments against the notion of self were all based on the premise that the five *skandhas* exhaust all human physical and mental experience. We have already seen that the Exhaustiveness Principle can be put into question by arguing that the *skandha*-based account of experience leaves out the strong, intuitive feeling of subjectivity we all get in dealing with our own mental (and physical) states. As Siderits puts it, in the Buddhist view all that we have is a series of physical and mental episodes that are connected as an unbroken flux on the basis of a relationship of cause and effect. The point is that this stream of mental and physical events seems to belong to nobody. This goes against the fact that we have a strong phenomenal perception of subjectivity, of 'I' and 'mine'. Pratyabhijñā's objections go precisely in that direction. They, of course, do not focus on the *rūpa*, the physical *skandha*, but rather on the *nāma* ones, our mental experience. According to the Śaivas, not only do the Buddhists leave the subjective dimension of all mental states out of the picture, but they also construe the emergence of physical and mental events on the basis of a cause-and-effect relationship that implies the objectification of cognitions. For them, the subjective, private aspect of consciousness can never be the content of any activity of the mind.

After this main contention, the Pratyabhijñā intellectuals made a further step. With a leap in the argument whose plausibility is discussed in Chapter 7, the purely subjective aspect of a mental state—which is present in all cognitions and therefore persists over time—is identified with the self, the subject of conscious experience. That for the Pratyabhijñā there is an intimate relation between the self-conscious nature of a mental state and the notion of self is clearly stated in a reconstructed fragment of the *Vivṛti*:

It has therefore been proved that being conscious of itself [on the part of cognition] is pervaded by the light of the I, which is opposed to insentience—and insentience for its part, has the nature of "this", which pervades the property of being knowable by others. Thus it is possible to deny that a cognition is knowable by other [cognition], because this property is pervaded by another that is in opposition to the pervading one.

(Torella, 1992, p. 337)¹³

Here Utpaladeva is giving a logical flavour to the idea we have been discussing at length. He claims that between self-awareness of cognitions and the 'I' (i.e. the self), there is an invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*), meaning that whenever there is self-awareness, one must surmise the existence of self. The same is true with regard to insentient beings and the notion of objectivity (*idantā*). If all this is posited, claiming that a cognition can be the object of something else would lead to the fallacy of attributing to self-awareness a property (i.e. insentience) that is in contradiction with the pervading one (*vyāpaka*), that is, the sentiency of the self.

It remains to see how the Śaivas apply their restrictive conception of *svasaṃvedana* to the specific case of memory.¹⁴ Their main idea is that, being

unable to escape the predicament of objectified cognitions, the Buddhist description of memory is untenable.

The nature of memory

In the previous chapter, we saw that the Buddhists conceive memory as the last cognition of a series of mental events starting with a mental episode taking place in the past. Their argument is that the mental traces—*saṃskāras*—left by subsequent cognitions bridge the temporal gap separating the original perception from the later recollection. For the Pratyabhijñā thinkers, the problem with this view is that *saṃskāras* cannot be but cognitions. Accordingly, to explain memory through a series of mental traces is tantamount to assuming a series of cognitions that are one the content of another.¹⁵ In the ĪPV, Utpaladeva makes a rhetorical attempt to save the credibility of the opponents' position. He affirms that the only way to keep the mental traces in the picture is to imagine that *saṃskāras* guarantee just the similarity between the former perception and the memory happening later.¹⁶ Nevertheless the idea is short-lived and does not stand a further analysis: memory cannot really establish a resemblance without accessing the content of the former cognition, something that is, as we have seen, impossible.¹⁷

Once established that the *saṃskāra* model is implausible, Utpaladeva stages a further counter-objection which he draws from the Buddhist side itself and which is strictly related to the latter's epistemological presuppositions. The Buddhists may try to escape the criticism of the *saṃskāra* scheme by questioning the epistemic status of memory itself. They may contend that what we call memory is a form of conceptual knowledge that appears to have as its content the former perception but actually has not.¹⁸ Accordingly, the Buddhists could claim that there is nothing real involved in the process of memory. In the end, memory is just another case of determinative knowledge, hence a conceptual construction lacking veridicality. Utpaladeva's reply to this move calls attention to the fact that reducing memory to the status of conceptual fabrication is dangerous. It is dangerous for the specific issue under discussion, for it would be a definitive blow to the Buddhist idea that *saṃskāras* play a role in the process of memory.¹⁹ But it is even more dangerous on a general level, because it would imply that most of our knowledge—which for the Pratyabhijñā ultimately depends on the capacity of unifying cognitions through time, hence largely on memory—is essentially defective.

"How can memory derive from error? And what about the establishment of objects? And if such is the case, what is the point of requiring a dependence on the mental traces left by the earlier perception?"²⁰

Besides these two general objections, Utpaladeva points out further inconsistencies in the Buddhist view, especially in the last part of the third section of the 'Chapter on Knowledge', as well as in the corresponding *Vṛtti*. The first counterargument stresses that one is not even allowed to affirm that memory is determinative knowledge. Actually, if the content of the original perception disappears immediately after the perception, as the Buddhist would maintain,

then the former cognition would not appear in memory anymore.²¹ In the second place, memory cannot be explained away by saying that it is an erroneous cognition. This is incorrect because, on the basis of a notion largely accepted by Indian thinkers, one can establish the truth-value of first cognitions only. Being memory a subsequent cognition it cannot be false or true in itself.²² In the third place, the way human activity works presupposes the existence of memory.²³ And, in the fourth place, determinative knowledge cannot by itself explain memory, for it is unable to cognize external objects. In fact, there are just two possibilities: if determinative knowledge is erroneous, then it is unconscious, but how can one establish an object on the basis of unconscious cognitions? On the other hand, if determinative knowledge is not erroneous but conscious, it will nevertheless remain a cognition. And as we have learned, a cognition is self-confined and self-aware but, so to say, unable to go beyond itself and apprehend any external content.²⁴

Let us finally illustrate how the Pratyabhijñā's explain the process of memory. To describe it, Utpaladeva introduces two key ideas that will play a huge role in our ensuing discussion. The author makes his case by building on a distinction between the cognition of the object that happens in the past (*prakāśa*) and a reflective awareness (*vimarśa*) that apparently sets in later, at the moment of recollection. However, these two aspects are partially identical because they share the subjective dimension that characterize all mental states. This aspect, which is ultimately identified with self and consciousness, is that which bridges the gap between the two moments of recollection.²⁵ The point is clearly stated in a passage of the ĪPKVr:

In memory the perceived object that is remembered is manifested as separate, but that is not the case of perception. This is because it is the self itself that is manifested—the object of the notion of “I”—whose nature is informed by the perception. And it is precisely this reality occurring at many different times, known as “I”, that is the self.²⁶

Mental states possess a double nature, having both a self-conscious aspect and an intentional one; it is the self-conscious aspect of self-awareness the one that persists over time. This is also clear from Abhinavagupta's interpretation of Utpaladeva's verse.²⁷ According to him, cognitions have an objective aspect (*arthamāśa*) which is self-confined, always restricted to the past, and absolutely inaccessible to any subsequent cognition. Once occurred and vanished, this part is gone forever. If the original cognition were just made up of it, memory (and knowledge as well) would never occur and no explanation—be it *saṃskāras*, intellect, etc.—could account for it. But there is another aspect, which is purely subjective and which Abhinavagupta calls the “consciousness-part” (*svātmāmāśa*). This part is not affected by time and is perpetual; it guarantees the continuity, and using a crucial term of the school, the dynamic unification (*anusamdhāna*) of cognitions: it corresponds to *vimarśa* and is the paramount characteristic of self and consciousness. One must be careful in noting the difference with the Buddhist

position: *vimarśa* does not *have* the former cognition as its object. It *is* the former cognition, precisely its *svātma* part.

By following this approach, Utpaladeva claims to have explained memory without infringing the axiom of non-objectivization of cognitions. But, most important for us, he has also laid the foundation of an advanced picture of consciousness. By distinguishing the subjective aspect of awareness from the objective one, Utpaladeva argues that consciousness's most intimate nature lies in the subjective, private dimension of a mental state, a position that is close to some of the latest developments in contemporary philosophy of mind. The Śaivas also believe that this subjective dimension forms the kernel of personhood, the real existence of which they are so keen to assert. In Chapter 5 we shall see how they will further argue that consciousness has an intrinsically linguistic nature. But before going into that, it is worth considering the possible influence of earlier philosophies on the Pratyabhijñā's discussion of *svaśamvedana*. Were Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta aware of earlier interpretations of the notion? Are there plausible antecedents to their extensive application of the axiom of non-objectification of cognitions? In the next chapter, we briefly consider a different Buddhist view on the issue, displayed in the works of Śāntarakṣita and his commentator Kamalaśīla. Then we will discuss at length Bhartṛhari's contributions to the question.

Notes

- 1 *satyaṃ kimtu smṛtijñānaṃ pūrvānubhavasamskṛteḥ/jātam apy ātmaniṣṭhaṃ tan nādyanubhavavedakam* // (ĪPK 1.3.1). "True. However, that kind of cognition which is memory, though arising from the mental traces left by the former perception, is restricted to itself and does not know the original perception". *na tu pūrvānubhavāveśābhāvāt pūrvānubhūtārthavyavasthāpikā ghaṭate* (ĪPKVṛ on 1.3.1). "Memory cannot determine the object formerly perceived, since it [memory] does not penetrate the former direct perception".
- 2 Zhihua Yao has reconstructed the historical evolution of the problem in Buddhist sources, discussing also the contribution of some pre-Dignāga's thinkers. See Yao (2005).
- 3 Dignāga claims that cognition's self-awareness has a non-conceptual nature, being a form of perception. This means that in the Pramāṇavāda framework, *svaśamvedana* is a rightful means to acquire knowledge, exactly in the way standard, sense-based perceptions are. Dignāga also adds that to have a non-conceptualized cognition of conceptualized knowledge is absolutely legitimate, for a cognition may be conceptualized as far as its content is concerned, but its self-awareness will remain perceptual and non-conceptualized. See PS 1.6ab *mānaśaṃ cārtharāgādisvaśamvittir akalpikā* / "and the self-awareness of objects or feelings and so on is non-conceptual, and it is a form of mental [perception]". See also PS 1.7ab: *kalpanāpi svaśamvittāv iṣṭā nārthe vikalpanāt* // "Even conceptual knowledge is to be accepted [as a perception] when it is directed at itself. However, this is not the case when it is directed at an object, because there is a conceptualization [of the object]". PSV adds: *atra viśaye rāgādivad eva apratyakṣatve 'pi svaśamvittīti na doṣaḥ*. "There is no mistake [at all in claiming that even] in the case of a content that is not grasped by a direct perception, such as feelings etc., there is self-awareness".
- 4 See PS 1.11 ab: *viśayajñānatajjñānaviśeṣāt tu dvirupatā* / "[A cognition] has a double nature, because there is a difference between the apprehension of the object and the apprehension of that [cognition of the object]".

- 5 See PSV on 1.11 ab: *anyathā yadi viṣayānurūpaṃ eva viṣayañjānaṃ syāt svarūpaṃ vā, jñānañjānaṃ api viṣayañjānānaviśiṣṭaṃ syāt*. “Otherwise, if the cognition of an object were to represent either its content or its own form only, then there would be no difference between the cognition of a cognition and the cognition of an object”. For a discussion of this passage, see Kellner (2010, pp. 211–213).
- 6 Relying on Jinendrabuddhi’s commentary, Birgit Kellner specifies that in this passage, Dignāga is referring to a cognition lacking a content. See Kellner (2010, p. 210).
- 7 See PSV on 1.11ab: *na cottarāṇi jñānāni pūrvaviprakṛṣṭaviṣayābhāsāni syuḥ, tasyāviṣayātvāt. ataś ca siddhaṃ dvairūpyaṃ jñānasya*. “Moreover [if a cognition were to consist of the *viṣaya* aspect only], then later cognitions would not make manifest objects that are remote from them in time, because they would lack a content. Therefore, the double nature of knowledge is established”.
- 8 See PSV on 1.11ab: *yasmāc cānubhavottarakālaṃ viṣaya iva jñāne ‘pi, yasmāc cānubhavottarakālaṃ viṣaya iva jñāne ‘pi smṛtir utpadyate, tasmād asti dvirūpatā jñānasya svasaṃvedyatā ca*. “Since memory arises in a moment that follows that of the perception, [and arises] for the content and the cognition as well, hence a cognition has two forms and a self-cognizing nature”.
- 9 See PVin 1.54ab: *sahopalambhaniyamād abhedo nīlataddhiyoḥ*. “There is no difference between ‘blue’ and the ‘cognition of blue’, since the two are necessarily perceived together”.
- 10 *‘drk’ jñānam, tac ca jaḍāt vibhidyate svaprakāśaikarūpatayā, jaḍo hi prakāśāt prthagbhūto vaktavyaḥ, tena drk svābhāsā, ābhāsaḥ prakāśamānatā sā svam rūpaṃ avyabhicāri yasyāḥ, svasya ca ābhāsanam rūpaṃ yasyāḥ*.
- 11 The point is further corroborated by Bhāskara Kaṇṭha’s commentary on the ĪPV in which Abhinavagupta’s *prakāśamānatā* is glossed as *bāhyasaṃbandhiprakāśakarī tva*, loosely meaning “the capacity of being a knowing, illuminating agent in relation to external objects”. See ĪPV vol. 1, p. 126.
- 12 *saty api bāhye taccharīrasaṃkrāntaṃ na prakāśanam jñānasya rūpaṃ bhavitum arhati, paraprakāśanātmakanijarūpaprakāśanam eva hi svaprakāśatvaṃ jñānasya bhāṇyate* (ĪPV on ĪPK 1.3.2). “Even admitting the existence of external objects, a light which is reflected on the material aspects [of external things] cannot be the proper nature of a cognition, because we maintain that the self-illuminating nature of a cognition is no more than the illumination of its own nature, in the form of the illumination of a different [external] thing”.
- 13 *siddhamtāvatparasamvedyatāvyāpakedantāsvabhāva—jaḍatāvīruddhāhamprakāśa—vyaptatvaṃ svasaṃvidrūpatasya. tena jñāne vyāpakavīruddhavyāptāyāḥ para—saṃvedyatāyā niṣedhaḥ*.
- 14 It is worth noting that the *svasaṃvedana* argument is by no means restricted to the discussion of memory. Let us consider two further cases. The first concerns the analysis of the so-called invalidated–invalidating relation (*bādhyabādhakabhāva*), which obtains between two cognitions in the case of wrong judgements, specifically when a previous false cognition is invalidated by a later, correct one. Standard examples are those of the perception of silver instead of mother of pearl or of a snake in place of a rope. The issue at stake is to explain what sort of relationship exists between these cognitions. Utpaladeva considers the case in which one sees a surface and realizes that it is devoid of a certain object—a jar, for instance. This is again a case of *anupalabdhi* or ‘non-perception’. According to the Buddhists, the mere perception of the absence of a jar is enough to prove that the surface is empty: a later correct perception would in fact negate the validity of the former one, just like the cognition of the mother of pearl wipes out that of silver. But for the Pratyabhijñā authors, the argument is unsound. They believe that the Buddhists are confusing two different ways of conceiving non-existence, an absolute one (*tādātmyābhāva*), in which the contents of the two cognitions (the invalidated–invalidating ones) are identical (the case of silver and mother of pearl) and a relative one (*vyatirekābhāva*) in which the contents differ.

The Buddhist contention that the mere perception of mother of pearl invalidates the perception of silver is valid as far the *tādātmyābhāva* is concerned, but it does not hold for the *vyatirekābhāva*. According to Utpaladeva, the non-existence of an object on a certain surface is precisely an instance of *vyatirekābhāva*, and therefore it cannot be accounted for on the basis of a subsequent true cognition. It is evident that the Śaiva is again resorting to the idea that cognitions are self-revealing and self-confined. A surface and a hypothetical pot that may or may not be placed on it are the contents of two unrelated cognitions, which can be connected only by admitting the unifying activity of a knowing subject. The second case is more metaphysically oriented and regards the possibility of imposing unity over multiplicity. This topic—discussed in the second *āhnika* of the ‘Chapter on Action’ (*kriyādhikāra*)—is of a broader significance, since it comes down to the question whether ‘metaphysical’ notions—such as those of action, relation, time etc.—are legitimate. As we have seen, the Buddhists neatly refute this possibility by arguing that reality is made up of absolutely discrete and ever-changing components. In their view, any attempt to reify this state of affairs produces conceptualized notions, *vikalpas*, which although have some practical use, are also inevitably mistaken. As expected, the Śaivas claim the opposite. According to Utpaladeva, metaphysical ideas are legitimate, and they are so for two main reasons: they are “permanent and useful” (*sthairyopayoga*, see ĪPK 2.2.1). Let us focus on the first aspect. Here ‘permanence’ has an epistemological connotation, somehow connected to the *bādhyabhadaka* relationship we have discussed earlier. It means that the notion of, say, ‘action’ is never set aside by a later cognition, and thus it remains valid over time. In the ĪPV, Abhinavagupta makes clear that there is a substantial difference between the cognition of a certain action, such as ‘Caitra is going’, and that of ‘seeing two moons’, which takes place in erroneous judgements. The latter is in fact invalidated by a subsequent perception, while that is not the case for the former. The decisive argument is again the idea that a cognition is self-contained and impossible to be objectified: the Śaivas could even go as far as accepting that the notion of action is a *vikalpa* (i.e., a reification of a series of instantaneous movements in space and time that are actually independent from one another), but this would not change the fact that this *vikalpa* is in the end a cognition and as such self-restricted and unable to go beyond itself like all other cognitions. How then to explain the persistence over time of metaphysical ideas, whose phenomenological appearance is so hard to deny? Again, this is done by accepting the existence of a conscious subject who unifies the cognitions.

- 15 *smṛtijñānam iti smṛtirūpaṃ jñānaṃ pūrvānubhavasamskārāt yady api jātam tathāpi ātmani svarūpe niṣṭhā viśrāntir yasya tādrśam, na tu ādyasya anubhavasya jñāpakam, tat bhavati. na hi tat tena saha ātmānaṃ miśrayati* (ĪPVV vol. I, p. 209). “Memory is a cognition having the form of a recollection; even if it is born out of the mental traces left by the original cognition, nevertheless it is such that the completion of its activity is confined to itself, to its own nature, and is therefore unable to make the original cognition known. Because this [memory] never mixes itself up with that [original cognition]”.
- 16 *drkṣvābhāsaiva nānyena vedyā rūpadrśeva drk/rase samskārajatvaṃ tu tattulyatvaṃ na tadgatiḥ* // (ĪPK 1.3.2). “A cognition is self-revealing and cannot be known by another cognition, just as the cognition of taste is not known by that of shape. The fact that memory arises from mental traces implies its similarity to the earlier perception, but not the cognition of that”. The idea is then expanded in the corresponding ĪPKVṛ: *pūrvānubhavasamskārajatvena tatsādrśyamātraṃ na tu pūrvānubhavāvagatiḥ*. “Since memory arises from the mental traces left by the earlier perception, there is just a similarity to that perception but not a direct cognition of the latter”.
- 17 *tadabhāvāt tatsādrśyam api nāvaseyam* (ĪPKVṛ on 1.3.2). “Since there is no cognition of this former perception, not even a similarity to it can be maintained”.
- 18 *athā tadviśayatve ‘pi smṛtes tadavasāyataḥ / drṣṭāmbanātā bhrāntyā tad etad asa-māñjasam* // (ĪPK 1.3.3). “One may object that believing that memory is based on

something perceived is an error; it is indeed a determinative cognition of a thing, even if this thing has never really been cognized. However, this is wrong, too”.

- 19 *pūrvānubhavāsparśe ca tadbhinnayogaṣemāyā bhrānteḥ saṃskārajātve ko grahaḥ* (ĪPKVṛ 1.3.4). “And, moreover, why insist so much on the fact that memory—conceived of as error—arises from the mental traces, when it is unrelated to the former direct perception in every respect, not coming into contact with it in any way?”
- 20 *smṛtitaiva katham tavad bhrānteś cārthasthitiḥ katham/pūrvānubhavasamṣkārapēkṣā ca kim itīṣyate* // (ĪPK 1.3.4).
- 21 *pūrvānubhavāprakāśāt tadviśayasampramoṣe ‘dhyavasāyamātrāt smṛtitvaṃ na yuk-tam* (ĪPKVṛ on 1.3.4). “It is incorrect to hold that memory derives only from determinative knowledge, the object of the original perception being absent. This is because the original perception is not manifested”.
- 22 Torella refers to the discussion contained in ĪPVV; see Torella (2001, p. 101). See also Kataoka (2003) and Chatterjee (1979).
- 23 *evam anyonyabhinnānām aparasparavedinām / jñānānām anusamdhānajanmā naśyej janasthitiḥ* // (ĪPK 1.3.6). “In this way, the human world, which is based on the unification of cognitions that are mutually diverse and unable of cognizing one another, would be destroyed”.
- 24 *bhrāntitve cāvasāyasya na jaḍād viśayasthitiḥ / tato ‘jāḍye nijollekhanīṣṭhān nārthasthitiḥ tataḥ* (ĪPK 1.3.5). “If determinative knowledge is an error, one cannot establish an object on the basis of something inert. If it is instead conscious, there is no establishment of the object in any case, because [such a determinative knowledge] would be restricted to its own manifestation”.
- 25 *sa hi pūrvānubhūtārthopalabdḥā parato ‘pi san / vimṛśan sa iti svairī smarātītyapadiśyate* // (ĪPK 1.4.1). “The Free One, the one who grasps the objects formerly perceived, and who also continues to exist later, it has the reflective awareness: ‘that’. That is what is called remembering”.
- 26 ĪPKVṛ on 1.4.4: *smṛtau smaryamāṇo ‘nubhūtārtho yathā prthagbhūto bhāti na tathānubhavaḥ svātmana evāhantāpratyejasyānubhuvamayatvena prathanāt, yaś cānekakālo ‘hamvedyo ‘rthaḥ sa evātmā*.
- 27 See ĪPVV, vol. 2, p. 32.

4 Self-awareness

Pratyabhijñā's forerunners

Pratyabhijñā's strategy to dismiss the notion of *nairātmyavāda* is to give a very strict interpretation to the idea that a knowledge episode is inherently able to cognize itself. The gist of the Śaiva argumentation is that the Buddhist epistemologists, although they themselves support the idea, are actually giving to the concept an erroneous, intentional connotation. For them, a cognition is self-reflexive insofar as it is able to make itself the content of its own knowledge. This is precisely the point Utpaladeva rejects. He rather argues that there is a factor in any mental state that can never be reduced to objectivity. A contemporary philosopher would characterize this view by saying that mental states have a component that is not third person knowable but which is accessible only to the subject of experience. Put another way, a mental state possesses a 'what is like to be' dimension that is intention free and cannot be the content of other mental states. The existence of this purely subjective element is for the Śaiva thinkers the most powerful indication that the notion of subjectivity is true and that, in the end, self and personhood are real things. The Pratyabhijñā thinkers were probably not the first intellectuals to have highlighted the presence of a subjective aspect in consciousness, but they were certainly the most committed to putting the notion at the forefront of their philosophy. There are nevertheless two contributions prior to Pratyabhijñā's time that are worth considering in some detail, as they may have had an influence on the Śaivas' elaboration. The first is that of the Buddhist thinker Śāntarakṣita and his commentator Kamalaśīla, who envisaged a conception of self-reflexivity that is in several respects similar to that of the Pratyabhijñā. Both authors lived in the eighth c. CE and belonged to the so-called Madhyamaka-Yogācāra school, which aimed, as the name betrays, at conciliating the Madhyamaka stance with the idealistic, mind-only approach of the Yogācāra.¹ The second contribution to take into account is that of Bhartṛhari, who probably was the earliest thinker to explicitly state that a cognition is self-reflexive and can never be objectified by another.

A different Buddhist approach: Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla's conception of *svasaṃvedana*

Although Dignāga and Dharmakīrti's influence on the conception of *svasaṃvedana* is profound, their interpretation of the notion is by no means unique in the history

of Buddhist thought. A quite different understanding is found in the work of Śāntarakṣita and his pupil Kamalaśīla. Śāntarakṣita's conception of *svasaṃvedana* has been the object of a thorough study by Paul Williams (1998), which has contrasted his ideas on the question with those of previous Buddhist thinkers. Williams claims that over time, Buddhist philosophers have developed two different notions of reflexive awareness. In some cases, self-awareness is regarded as having an intentional connotation. The idea behind this approach is that a cognitive episode is at the same time aware of itself, as well as of the content at which it is directed. In this intentional understanding, a cognition "in some sense takes an object, and in some sense that object is itself" (Williams, 1998, pp. 20–21). The beginning of this interpretation is traceable to Dignāga's argument from memory that we have briefly discussed in Chapter 3. The argument boils down to the fact that if I am able to remember something from the past, it is only because I can recollect both the content of the original cognition and the cognition itself. For instance, if I remember that I saw a blue thing yesterday, I must have both the memory of blue and that of *seeing* blue; otherwise, the content 'blue' would not be remembered at all. In Williams's words:

The argument is, therefore, an argument for two elements in the original experience irreducible to each other. There is an eye-consciousness of blue and there is another element in the consciousness experience which is taking that eye-consciousness of blue as an object. This is shown by the two elements in the recollection. One can remember that one experienced blue because one not only experienced blue but also knew that one experienced blue. If a person did not know that he or she experienced blue, then how could that person remember experiencing blue, and therefore remember blue?

(Williams, 1998, p. 10)

Still, there is a second and rather different type of self-awareness, which Williams labels "reflexive self-awareness", and which is indeed the one that emerges in the Madhyamaka-Yogācāra tradition. Śāntarakṣita's discussion of self-awareness is mostly contained in a single chapter of his encyclopedic *Tattvasaṃgraha* (TS), more precisely in a section dedicated to exploring the ontological nature of external objects (*bahirarthaparikṣā*).² The question is further addressed in a couple of stanzas of another work of Śāntarakṣita, the *Madhyamakālaṃkāra* (MA). In the TS, the analysis of *svasaṃvedana* takes place in a context in which the author is defending the Dharmakīrtian notion whereby the difference between the content of a cognition and cognition itself is actually fictitious.³ The main reason why Śāntarakṣita embarked on a discussion and a defense of self-awareness is that in the period intervening between Dharmakīrti and himself, the idea had heavily been criticized by Brahmanical traditions, in particular the Bhaṭṭa Mīmāṃsā, whose positions Śāntarakṣita illustrates here by extensively quoting Kumāṛila's *Ślokavārttika* (ŚV).⁴ In refuting Brahmanical criticism, Śāntarakṣita applies both the infinite regress and the

memory arguments we have appreciated in Dignāga's and Dharmakīrti's work.⁵ However, he also considers two further characteristics of self-awareness that the Buddhist epistemologists did not take into account, at least explicitly. The first is that self-awareness is not determined by other cognitions. With regard to this, Śāntarakṣita says: "This is the meaning of self-awareness: it is something that cannot be but cognized and that in order to reveal its own form does not require any other knowing entity".⁶ Then he attributes to self-awareness a second, novel property, by stating that it is the hallmark of conscious beings: "Cognition manifests itself as different from inert entities. This self-awareness of cognition consists precisely in being conscious".⁷ The very same ideas are spelled out, somewhat even more clearly, in two consecutive verses of the MA: "Self-cognizing cognition is not an entity which [exists as] agent and action [with its object] because it would be incorrect for consciousness, which is of a single, partless nature, to be three (i.e., knower, knowing, and known)" (MA 17) and: "Consciousness is produced in the opposite way from that which is of an inanimate nature. That which is not the nature of being inanimate is the self-knowledge of this [consciousness]" (MA 16; both verses are translated in Blumenthal, 2004, p. 237). As Williams remarks, in the reflexive type of self-awareness, "consciousness is self-referring in a non-objectifying way, just as a lamp illuminates itself not as one object among others to be illuminated, but through the very act of being a lamp, an illuminator of others" (Williams, 1998, p. 20). Accordingly, *svasaṃvedana* is intended here as pure reflexivity, as what makes consciousness what it is. MA 17 makes explicit that this second type of self-reflexivity does not involve a subject-object relationship, and it does not posit the existence of anything different from itself. In Śāntarakṣita's view, the reflexive nature of self-awareness is a datum, it is not something that can be proven or argued for, as it is perfectly evident even to the man in the street.⁸ In sum, without reflexive self-awareness, consciousness would not be consciousness at all.⁹ It is quite clear that this conception easily leads to an idealistic outcome. As Williams shows, the fact that there are an intentional and a reflexive kind of *svasaṃvedana* does not mean that one cannot be reduced to the other. For instance, for a follower of the Yogācāra tradition, the intentional aspect of self-awareness coincides with the reflexive one. In the end, if there is no external objective aspect to cognize, pure consciousness cannot but cognize itself. If self-awareness is the hallmark of consciousness only, then things that exist outside consciousness cannot be cognized at all.

All this bears a strong resemblance to the positions of the Pratyabhijñā and clearly shows that also the Buddhists were aware of the fact that consciousness has a key aspect which is purely reflexive and impossible to objectify. Of course, neither Śāntarakṣita nor Kamalaśīla concluded that pure consciousness is actually nothing but the self, as the Śaiva thinkers would argue. Therefore, if we want to appreciate a stance that is even closer to that of Utpaladeva, we must turn to the work of Bhartṛhari, probably the first Indian thinker to highlight the crucial role of the subjective dimension of consciousness.

Bhartṛhari on *svasaṃvedana*: the *Jāṭisamuddeśa* section

In the monograph we just discussed, Williams also suggests that the notion of ‘reflexive self-awareness’ could have been an innovation of the Mādhyamaka-Yogācāra school, perhaps under the influence of Dharmakīrti’s thought: “The idea of portraying self-awareness as the quality of consciousness understood as the reverse of insentience (*bems po*) may well have originated with Śāntarakṣita” (Williams, 1998, p. 25). Actually, this can hardly be the case. Although the fact has admittedly been overlooked, one of the earliest South Asian thinkers to argue explicitly for the self-luminous nature of knowledge—and, consequently, to claim that a cognition cannot be the content of another—was Bhartṛhari. Bhartṛhari concentrated his most decisive statements on the nature of *svasaṃvedana* at the very end of the *Jāṭisamuddeśa*, a subsection of VP’s third chapter dedicated to analyzing competing views on the existence of universals. By drawing the section to a close, Bhartṛhari is faced with the need to offer an alternative theory to the Buddhist ontological standpoint whereby objects and cognitions are singular events. He renders such a position (in VP 3.3.101) by saying that if things and cognitions appear to be somewhat similar, it is not because they are really so but because of a mental fabrication that is devoid of real existence. The VP’s commentator Helārāja elaborates on this by affirming that according to the Buddhists, a unitary cognition is impossible due to cognitions’ intrinsic singularity. This view is then further spelled out by stating that if a conceptualized notion arises, this basically depends on the impossibility to express through language the absolute, radical difference that exists between things and events. Immediately after, Helārāja introduces the view of those who disagree with the aforementioned position but argue for the existence of real universals. In VP 3.1.104, Bhartṛhari calls them the supporters of the “connection theory” (*saṃsargadarśana*). This standpoint is then expanded and thoroughly analyzed, as if it was Bhartṛhari’s *siddhānta*, in four crucial verses: VP 3.1.105–106 and 3.1.109–110. Given the importance of the whole passage for establishing Bhartṛhari’s view on *svasaṃvedana*, I have translated it in its entirety in the appendix, together with Helārāja’s commentary thereupon. The gist of Bhartṛhari’s reasoning can nevertheless summarized as follows.

The starting point of the discussion is common experience. In ordinary life, everyone is able to notice that some cognitions are identical to others. Now, is such an identity based on a common feature, a universal that is instantiated within the various cognitions or not? For Bhartṛhari, the answer is a definite no. There is certainly a common element between cognitions, but it is not intrinsic to cognitions as such; rather, it pertains to their contents: “The universal resides only in the content of a cognition and is subsidiary to cognitions. A cognition is never represented by another form, differently from what happens in the case of its content”.¹⁰ As Helārāja explains, the main difference between the content of a cognition (a pot, a patch of blue, the action ‘running’, etc.) and the cognition itself lies in the fact that the former is explainable in terms of universal features, whereas for the latter, such a representation is impossible.¹¹ In the case of

contents, a common element is in fact identified by cognitions themselves. But in the case of cognitions, what is going to identify a common element? Certainly not another cognition; otherwise, infinite regress would set in. The only property cognitions share is their conscious nature (*saṃvidākāra*), but such a conscious nature cannot be cognized by another cognition, for that would mean treating a cognition as a content, thus contradicting its nature. The fact that we can perceive a similarity between cognitive states depends on the capacity cognitions have to reflect or assume the universals of their contents.¹² Next, Bhartṛhari expands on the reason why a cognition is never objectified by another. He brings in the example of light. Like a source of light is never illuminated by another, similarly, a cognition is never cognized by another: “Just as a light is never illuminated by another light, similarly what has the form of a cognition cannot be apprehended by another cognition”.¹³ Helārāja adds further information by specifying that a cognition is always self-revealing, and this constitutes the distinguishing mark of living beings.¹⁴ Moreover, he says that a cognition is always perceived at the time of the cognition of its content; otherwise, one would need a second-order cognition to explain the first and so forth.¹⁵ Then it is affirmed that ‘the cognition of *x*’ is quite a different thing from ‘the cognition of the cognition of *x*’. Bhartṛhari states that this difference is caused by the fact that ‘the cognition of *x*’ comes down to the content, meaning that the cognition of *x* is produced directly by the external object, whereas this is not the case for ‘the cognition of the cognition of *x*’: “The cognition ‘this is the cognition of a pot’ is different from the cognition of the pot. The cognition of the pot comes down to the external object”.¹⁶ In the commentary, Helārāja gives four reasons to explain the difference between these two kinds of cognitions. For the sake of clarity, let us call C1 ‘the cognition of *x*’ and C2 ‘the cognition of the cognition of *x*’, where *x* is an external object, for instance, a pot. In Helārāja’s first interpretation, the pot in C1 has different characteristics from the pot in C2: the pot in C1 is produced directly from the content, the one in C2 only indirectly. This means that the two are not similar, and a relationship of ‘apprehender and apprehended’ cannot be established, since such a relationship requires similarity. The conclusion is that C2 does not cognize C1.¹⁷ In the second interpretation, C2 must necessarily have a content, for a cognition without a content is unthinkable. The content is clearly the same of C1, that is, the pot. The conclusion is again that C2 does not cognize C1; it is directly cognizing the pot.¹⁸ In the third interpretation, C1 cannot cognize a pot and be cognized at the same time by C2, for in this case, the distinction between an apprehender subject and an apprehended content would vanish and with it any possibility of dependable knowledge. Again, the conclusion is that C2 does not cognize C1.¹⁹ Finally, in the fourth interpretation, C2 can at the most recognize C1 as some form of cognition, but it cannot cognize the conscious nature of C1. Helārāja gives the telling example of someone trying to access the cognition of someone else: one can certainly cognize the same content of the cognition of another person but cannot cognize it in the same way as that person. Therefore, C2 does not cognize C1, and the objectification of a cognition is always inadmissible.²⁰ Finally, the last stanza, VP 3.1.110, is meant to meet a final criticism of the *pūrvapakṣin*, which seeks to

identify the cognition with its content. If a cognition and its content are the same, then one is allowed to claim that cognitions are able to assume themselves as their own content. In the stanza, Bhartṛhari refutes this view by conceding that a cognition is certainly always intentional, that is to say, it is never devoid of a content, but also emphasizing that between cognitions and contents, there is, however, a substantial difference. According to him, whenever we suppose that a cognition *x* is having another cognition *y* as its content, we are just cognizing the universal represented in *x*, which is generated by the content of *y*.²¹ Helārāja expands on this idea by stressing that ‘cognitions of cognitions’ are always rooted in the original object: if a cognition appears to be the content of another, it is just a temporary occurrence, as it happens in the case of a crystal assuming a certain colour.²² At the end, Helārāja returns to the problem of the universal by restating the grammarians’ position on the issue, according to which there is no need to postulate the existence of universals in cognitions, because the similarity we recognize in knowledge is adequately explained on the basis of the universals present in their contents, that is, in the external objects. In Helārāja’s words, “The universal contained in the object produces a unitary cognition, and the unitary cognition expresses the universal in the object”.²³

The entire passage shows how Bhartṛhari’s ideas on ‘cognitions of cognitions’ were close to those advanced later by the Pratyabhijñā. It is also worth noting that although Helārāja’s commentary provides welcome additional material, the basic information is all contained in the stanzas: first, a cognition cannot be objectified by another because the knowledge that derives from an object is radically different from the one produced by another cognition; second, there is no need to postulate a universal of cognitions because ‘pure’ cognitions have only consciousness as their common feature, and consciousness cannot be cognized by anything but itself; and third, a cognition is always dependent on a content. The only crucial notion that Bhartṛhari does not mention in these stanzas—even though Helārāja does—is that only living beings are self-aware of their own cognitions. Nevertheless, in other *kārikās* of the VP, the idea is clearly expressed.²⁴ Before seeing how the Pratyabhijñā adopted Bhartṛhari’s concepts in their own works, let us consider few additional passages of the VP dealing with the same problems.

Bhartṛhari on *svasaṃvedana*: additional material

Apart from the discussion found at the end of the *Jāṭisamuddeśa*, other considerations on the nature of cognitions and self-awareness are scattered throughout the VP. The most substantial is perhaps the one offered by three *kārikās* of the *Saṃbandhasamuddeśa* (3.3.23–24 and 3.3.26). The first two restate the concept discussed earlier as follows:

For on [a cognition] that has the nature of a doubt, which is established as instrumental to determine an object, and which does not abandon its proper nature, [on top of that] one cannot apply a further doubt. When a [subsequent]

determinative cognition is applied to an [original] one, then the [original] determinative one does not retain its distinguishing feature.²⁵

Helārāja's remarks helps to unpack Bhartṛhari's statement:

When there is a “determinative cognition”—i.e. a cognition which has the form of a specific ascertainment, that is to say, whose content is an object being ascertained—then another, self-restricted, determinative cognition (*nirṇaya*) cannot be applied to the first, which is directed at establishing the object. For the own nature of a cognition lies in being dependent on an object. Hence, if one in conceiving a cognition eliminates that, one will be led away from the core nature of the cognition, precisely because that cognition would freely get the status of an object. We have in fact previously proven that “the cognition of a pot” cannot be the object of another cognition, since that would imply the loss of [the cognition's] defining nature, because [the cognition] would abandon its nature of subject (*viśayitvatyāgāt*) by becoming the object of another cognition (*jñānāntaraviśayatve*). Just as in a unitary cognitive event a cognition that is engaged with some other object cannot be itself the object of knowledge—since its activity is not directed at itself—likewise, the expressive aspect of a linguistic unit cannot be the expressed one: the expressive aspect of the word “inexpressible” does not exclude that its meaning is expressible, because that activity [of the word] is not in contradiction with itself.²⁶

The big novelty here is the connection, which Helārāja makes explicit, between the nature of a cognition and that of a linguistic expression. As Bhartṛhari himself stresses soon after, the reference-aspect of linguistic unit is not to be confused with the word-aspect: “A linguistic unit which is employed as expressive cannot be the expressed one. That by which something is cognized cannot be cognized by something else in the same context”.²⁷ As for this, Helārāja comments:

“Being denoted” (*abhideyatā*) is a notion that excludes that of “being engaged in the action [of denoting something else]”, if applied at the same time; for a thing that is employed to express something else cannot turn back to itself. It is indeed the very nature of things that what is endowed with the capacity of the subject cannot be at the same time the locus of the capacity of the object; this means that it is contradictory, etc., to attribute to the same locus, at the same time, both independence and dependence.²⁸

Thus, cognitions and words have a very similar nature, insofar as they reveal both themselves and their content simultaneously. The idea is put forth very clearly already in the first chapter of the VP:

Just as in a cognition both the content and the cognition itself are perceived, in the same way in a linguistic expression both the meaning and the form of that very linguistic expression are manifested.²⁹

Later in the same chapter, Bhartṛhari seems to hint at the idea that it is useless to talk about cognition independently from a content.³⁰ In the second chapter, he explicitly says that a cognition never appears in a ‘pure’ state and that is always coloured by the object.³¹ Still, in a passage of the *Dravyasamuddeśa*, he seems to entertain a slightly different notion, namely, that although a cognition cannot be posited without a content, there is nonetheless a sharp difference between the nature of an object and that of the cognition:

Just as the qualities of an object are utterly non-existent in the cognition, and just like that which is utterly non-identical is established as identical, similarly, the forms of the transformations are utterly non-existent in reality, and yet that which is utterly non-identical appears as identical.³²

Concerning this point, Helārāja’s commentary is more straightforward, as it puts the question in the well-known terms of the dichotomy between what is inert (the object) and what is sentient (the cognition). Interestingly, he flavours Bhartṛhari’s affirmations with arguments that come straight from Dharmakīrti, perhaps with the mediation of a later commentator:

According to the Vijñānavāda view, since what is manifested as having the form of the content of a cognition actually does not exist, a quality like the colour “blue” etc. is self-contained, inert and absolutely absent in a sentient cognition. Thus the author says that there is no similarity between what is sentient and what is inert on the basis of some part. With regard to this it has been affirmed: “If there were similarity [between a cognition and its object] on the basis of one aspect, then everything would apprehend everything. But, on the other hand, if there were similarity in all aspects then a cognition would cease to be a cognition”.³³

On the whole, the passages we have quickly surveyed show how Bhartṛhari was well aware of and upheld the idea that cognitions are by nature self-reflexive; he was also one of the earliest thinkers to regard *svasaṃvedana* as the hallmark of living entities and to claim that due to its very nature, a cognition can never be objectified. Finally, he also believed that although a mental state—and similarly, language—is always about something, the reflexive aspect of a cognition must be regarded as different from the intentional one. In the next section, we examine to what extent Bhartṛhari’s ideas were known to the Śaivas.

Pratyabhijñā’s appropriation of Bhartṛhari’s theses

The most straightforward proof that the Pratyabhijñā authors were aware of Bhartṛhari’s discussion of *svasaṃvedana* is the fact that in the ĪPVV Abhinavagupta cites two of the stanzas of the *Jāṭisamuddeśa* we examined earlier (VP 3.1.106 and 109). The first is quoted precisely where one is expecting to find it, that is, in the third section of the ‘Chapter on Knowledge’, in which

Utpaladeva concentrates most of his considerations on self-awareness. More precisely, Abhinavagupta quotes VP 3.1.106 while commenting on Utpaladeva's *Vivṛti* on ĪPK 1.3.7. Here the author introduces an aspect that we discuss at length in the next chapter. Ordinary reality, Abhinavagupta says, would be inexplicable without admitting an activity of unification of cognitions, which these thinkers call *anusamdhāna* and which belongs only to the subject of experience. In the passage in question, Abhinavagupta is referring to the notion of non-objectification of knowledge to show that the way the Buddhists prove non-existence is wrong. In doing so, he quotes the VP as an authoritative source, restating the well-known idea that a cognition is self-luminous and not objectifiable; otherwise, infinite regress will follow. He says:

[Utpaladeva] now examines the Buddhist way of establishing non-existence with the intention to show that the aforementioned idea whereby ordinary apprehension, directed at itself or at other things, is produced on the basis of “a distinction from what is different” does not hold. With regard to this, it has repeatedly been proven that knowledge has a unitary, self-illuminating nature. As the venerable [Bhartrhari] said: “Just as a light is never illuminated by another light, in the same way what has the nature of knowledge is never made visible in another knowledge”. Therefore, on the basis of the fact that a cognition is not liable to be merged with another cognition, it might be said that if there were two cognitions, a third one should be there to know them.³⁴

The second stanza Abhinavagupta quotes, VP 3.1.109, comes in a different section of the work, whose content is nevertheless similar to the previous one. We are in the fourth section of the ‘Chapter on Knowledge’, precisely in ĪPK 1.4.6, where Utpaladeva maintains that memory never operates on the original perception. The common phrasing “I had this perception in the past” is just a linguistic analysis of a more accurate sentence, such as “this thing was perceived by me in the past”. The point is again to emphasize, even linguistically, that knowledge cannot be objectified. In this regard, Abhinavagupta brings in Bhartrhari right at the beginning of his discussion by saying:

One may object that when a pot is remembered, that is to say, it is in the condition of an object of knowledge, then the original cognition should come together with the knowing subject, but if that [original cognition] is remembered as an object of cognition, what else can be said? We reply. Even if we say, “I had a perception of a pot”, it is the pot the object of the cognition. As the venerable [Bhartrhari] said: “The cognition ‘I have the cognition of a pot’ is different from the cognition of the pot. The cognition of the pot gives access to the object”.³⁵

The source of Pratyabhijñā's notion of self-awareness

Both Śāntarakṣita's and Bhartrhari's conception of self-awareness, with their strong emphasis on the innate reflexive component of consciousness, clearly

prefigure the way in which the Śaiva thinkers understood the notion. Hence, one can legitimately ask whether Utpaladeva again reworked a Buddhist notion and made it fit to his own agenda or Bhartṛhari was really the original source of his considerations. It is really hard to answer this question. On the one hand, we can reasonably suppose that the Śaivas were aware that in Buddhist philosophical circles the notion of *svasaṃvedana* had different interpretations; on the other, it is a fact that Bhartṛhari predates Śāntarakṣita of almost two centuries and that the Pratyabhijñā intellectuals quoted him as their source of inspiration. The last point is evidently a non-compelling argument, for the Śaivas could have quoted Bhartṛhari a posteriori, only to give an authoritative aura to their affirmations. At the end of the day, they could not certainly quote a Buddhist source for that purpose! Still, one cannot dismiss the possibility that Bhartṛhari could have been a real model for them. With the possible exception of the Prābhākara Mīmāṃsā, the grammarian was quite solitary in defending the very same position the Pratyabhijñā argued for, that is to say, that both notions of *svasaṃvedana* and self are veridical ones. That said, if Bhartṛhari's proximity to Pratyabhijñā's philosophy is already evident in their understanding of *svasaṃvedana*, much more profound is the impact the grammarian had on the way the Śaivas developed a theory of consciousness, which, as we will see in the next chapter, is strictly related to the fact that humans possess a language.

Notes

- 1 Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla argued that the two main philosophical traditions of Indian Mahāyāna Buddhism give a coherent and comprehensive account of reality only if reconciled. In their view, the Yogācāra approach is the best at explaining how conventional reality works, while Madhyamaka's theory of emptiness is the best account with regard to the ultimate truth. The notion is clearly stated in MA 92–93: "By relying on the *cittamātra* system, know that external realities do not exist. And by relying on this [Madhyamaka] system, know that no self at all exists, even in that mind. Therefore, by holding the reigns of reasoning, as one rides the chariots of the two systems, one becomes a real Mahāyānist" (Blumenthal, 2004, pp. 171–172). The notion that there are two distinct dimensions of truth is widespread in Buddhist philosophy. Possibly the oldest explicit formulation is due to Nāgārjuna (see MK 24.10).
- 2 On this specific section of the TS see a recent monograph by Saccone (2018).
- 3 *paricchedaḥ sa kasyeti na ca paryanuyogabhāḥ / paricchedaḥ sa tasyātmā sukhādeḥ sātātādivat* // (TS 2010). "There is no reason to ask to whom this determination belongs, [since] determination is the very nature of that [cognition], just like delight and so on is the very nature of pleasure etc.". In his commentary on the TS, the *Pañjikā*, Kamalaśīla adds: *ātmaiva hi sa tasya prakāśātmatayā pariccheda ity ucyate, yathā sukhādeḥ sātāteti. na hi sukhasyeti vyatirekanirdeśamātreṇa tato 'nyatā sātātā bhavet. tasmād yady api nīlasya paricchedaḥ pītasyeti vā vyatirekīva vyapadeśas tathāpi svabhāva eva sa tathā nīlādirūpeṇa prakāśamānatvāt tathocyate, svasaṃvedanarūpatvāj jñānasya*. "For it has been said that determination, because it has the nature of light, is the very nature of that [cognition], like delight is the very nature of pleasure and so on. For if one simply refers to the delight of pleasure, this does not imply that the delight is something altogether different from the pleasure. Therefore even if the cognition of blue or yellow it is talked about as if different from blue or yellow, nevertheless that is the very nature [of the cognition], insofar as it is expressed so because it is manifested as blue and yellow. And the reason is that a cognition has always the nature of self-awareness".

- 4 See, for instance, TS 2012–2015, which are quotations from ŚV *Śūnyavāda* 184–187.
- 5 This is particularly evident in TS 2022–2023 (in which Śāntarakṣita sums up the epistemological argument introduced by Dharmakīrti in the PV in almost paraphrasing it) as well as in TS 2024, which clearly evokes Dignāga’s appeal to infinite regress.
- 6 *svarūpavedanāyānyad vedakaṃ na vyapekṣate / na cāviditam astīdam ity artho ‘yaṃ svasaṃvidāḥ* // (TS 2011).
- 7 *vijñānaṃ jaḍarūpebhyo vyāvṛttam upajāyate / iyaṃ evātmasaṃvittirasyayā ‘jaḍarūpatā* // (TS 1999). TSP elaborates on this as follows: *na hi grāhakabhāvenātmasaṃvedanam abhipretam. kiṃ tarhi? svayam, prakṛtyā prakāśātmatayā nabhasthalavarttyālokaḥ*. “Self-awareness is not to be meant as a knowing entity. As what? But rather as being intrinsically of the nature of light, as the light for the sky”.
- 8 In this regard, Williams quotes Kamalaśīla, who in his Tibetan commentary on the MA affirms that the self-revealing nature of a cognition is evident even to cowherds. To this he adds an explicit remark by a later author, Mokṣākaragupta (eleventh and twelfth c.), who in his *Tarkabhāṣā* says: *anubhavaprasiddhaṃ ca svasaṃvedanatvaṃ katham apahnūyeta*. “The nature of self-awareness is established by perception, how can it be refuted?” (Williams, 1998, p. 24). As Yao has noted, “by rejecting the articulated epistemological formulations, they [i.e. Śāntarakṣita and Kamalaśīla] have returned to a Mahāsaṃghika position, according to which a self-cognition is more simple, fundamental and soteriologically oriented” (Yao, 2005, p. 149).
- 9 Apart from TS 1999, Śāntarakṣita insists elsewhere, too, that “consciousness occurs as the very opposite of that the nature of which is insentience”, amounting to saying that “self-awareness is that which makes consciousness not unconsciousness” (Yao, 2005, pp. 21–22).
- 10 *jñeyasthaṃ eva sāmānyaṃ jñānānām upakāraḥ / na jātu jñeyavaj jñānaṃ pararūpeṇa rūpyate* // (VP 3.1.105).
- 11 *yathā jñeyam vyatiriktasāmānyarūpeṇa rūpyate, rūpavat kriyate, naivaṃ jñānaṃ saṃvidātmasamavetena vyatiriktasāmānyarūpeṇa rūpyate. jñeyadharmāḥ kilāyaṃ yat pararūpeṇa rūpaṇam. jñānaṃ tu [a*]svatantram jñeyam eva na bhavati*. “While the content of a cognition is represented, i.e. appears, in the form of a distinct universal, this is not the case for a cognition, which is never represented in the form of a distinct universal, because it is always accompanied by self-consciousness. In fact, the distinguishing mark of the content of a cognition is that its representation takes place through another form, whereas a cognition is dependent on the content but never becomes it” (Helārāja on 3.1.105).
- 12 *bāhyaparavaśatvenāsvādhīnatvāj jñānānām svata eva vailakṣaṇyānupapatteḥ bahir abhinnena nimittena tatra bhāvyam*. “Now, being unacceptable that cognitions possess differentiation by nature—for they are dependent, insofar as they are determined by something external—such a differentiation must take place on the basis of an external, unitary cause” (Helārāja on 3.1.105).
- 13 *yathā jyotiḥ prakāśena nānyenābhiprakāśyate / jñānākāras tathānyena na jñānenopagrhyate* // (VP 3.1.106).
- 14 *jaḍavailakṣaṇyaṃ hi prakāśakatvaṃ iti tasyāpi prakāśyatve jaḍatāpattiḥ*. “If a cognition were illuminated, it would acquire the nature of an inert thing, for its nature of being an illuminator is what distinguishes it from an inert thing” (Helārāja on 3.1.106).
- 15 *arthaprakāśakāle ca prakāśakasyāprakāśe ‘rthasaṃvedanam eva na syāt. prakāśāsañcetane tallagnārthasañcetanāsiddheḥ. uttarakālāṃ tu vedanaṃ kvopayogi. utpannāyāṃ ca prakāśatāyāṃ ātmasamavetasya tadānīm jñānasyāsañcetanān mama prakāśito ‘rtha ity ātmagāmi saṃvedanam na syāt*. “Furthermore, if at the moment of the cognition of a content the illuminating cognition were lightless, there would be no apprehension of the object at all, because if a cognition is not sentient the content connected with such a cognition cannot be established. And [if the cognition is not perceived at the same time of its content] what would be the use of a cognition occurring

- later in time? In fact, when a manifestation takes place, one could not have a knowledge directed at oneself such as ‘this object has been manifest to me’, since at that very moment the cognition directed at oneself would be insentient” (Helārāja on 3.1.105).
- 16 *ghaṭajñānam iti jñānam ghaṭajñānavilakṣaṇam / ghaṭa ity api yaj jñānam viṣayopanipāti tat //* (VP 3.1.109).
- 17 *anukāryapratyayā eva hi viṣayena janyante nānye jñānāmbanāḥ, vyavadhānāt, sārūpyabālena ca grāhyagrāhakabhāvaḥ* [Iyer’s edition °*bhāvena*]. *vaidharmyena na ca ghaṭajñānam jñānāntare pratibhāsate. ato na tad grhyate*. “For only cognitions that are the content of a further cognition derive from the object, not the others, which are [in turn] founded on cognitions. The reason is that there is an intervention [of a cognition] between the two. A relationship of ‘apprehender’ and ‘apprehended’ is established due to the force of a similarity. But the cognition of a pot appears in the other [i.e. second-order] cognition as having different properties. Hence it is not grasped [by the second-order cognition]” (Helārāja on 3.1.109).
- 18 *evam ca bodhatvāviśeṣāt yady api jñānajñānam iti mataṃ tad api bāhyaviṣayam evety uktam bhavati*. “Even if one thinks in terms of ‘cognition of cognitions’ because there is no difference [between the two cognitions] in terms of awareness, the content of ‘the cognition of a cognition’ is nonetheless the external object. This has been said” (Helārāja on 3.1.109).
- 19 *na hi samvidākāras tajjñānābhimate pratibimbībhavati. sārūpyavaśena grāhyagrāhakabhāvaḥ. anyathā jñānatvāviśeṣād idam asya samvedanam iti pratiniyamo na syāt. ghaṭo iti tu yad etad bāhyaviṣayaṃ jñānam tad viṣayopanipāti viṣayākāram upādatte*. “For the consciousness-nature of a cognition is not reflected in what is imagined to be its cognition. The relation between apprehender and apprehended is based on similarity. If that were not the case, since there is no distinction in terms of awareness, there would be no rule to determine what is the perception of what. But a cognition, whose content is an external object like a pot, conforms itself to that very object and assumes its form” (Helārāja on 3.1.109).
- 20 *ghaṭajñānam iti tu jñānam na jñānarūpānupāti, yato ghaṭajñānagataṃ viṣayam nirūpya, jñānarūpaṃ kim api tad ity etāvad yadi paraṃ nirūpayitum śaknoti, na tu sā tadāyā bodharūpatā tasya pratibhāsate, paraśamvedana iva. pareṇa hi ghaṭajñānam asyotpannam iti kayācid yuktyā jñānam paricchidyate, na tu svavatparasya pratibhāsate iti tato vilakṣaṇam na tasya paricchedadakam*. “But the cognition ‘this is the cognition of the pot’ does not conform itself to the nature of the cognition [‘this is a pot’]. In fact, by ascertaining the ‘cognition of the pot’ as a content, [the cognition of the cognition of the pot] can at most ascertain that [the cognition of the pot] is some form of knowledge; yet the conscious nature of [the cognition of the pot] is not reflected in [the cognition of the cognition of the pot], as it happens in the case of the cognition of another person. A cognition is determined by another on the basis of a certain linguistic expression, such as ‘he had the cognition of a pot’, but this knowledge of another cognition is not manifested for others as it is for oneself, hence the [cognition of the cognition of a pot] is different from the cognition of a pot and does not determine it” (Helārāja on 3.1.109).
- 21 *yato viṣayarūpeṇa jñānarūpaṃ na grhyate / artharūpaviviktaṃ ca svarūpaṃ nāvadhāryate //* (VP 3.1.110). “For what has the nature of a cognition is not apprehended as having that of an object. Cognition’s own nature is not grasped separately from the object”.
- 22 *na ca grāhyākāro jñānasvarūpaṃ, aupādhikatvāt. yathā sphatikasya nīlādi*. “Moreover, the manifestation in the form of an apprehended content is not the proper nature of a cognition; it is rather a temporary qualification, just like the colours blue etc. are for a crystal” (Helārāja on 3.1.110).
- 23 *jñeyasāmānyasyābhinnajñānanakanakatenābhinnajñānasyacajñeyatāpratipādakatvena* (Helārāja on 3.1.110).

- 24 See, for instance, the *Vṛtti* on 1.134.
- 25 *na hy saṃśayarūpe 'rthe śeṣatvena vyavasthite / avyudāse svarūpasya saṃśayo 'nyah pravartate //* (VP 3.3.23). *yadā ca nirṇayajñāne nirṇayatvena nirṇayaḥ/prakramyate tadā jñānaṃ svadharṃ nāvatiṣṭhate //* (VP 3.3.24). I am following Houben's reading of the last *pāda* instead of Rau's *svadharṃnāvatiṣṭhate*. Houben (1995a, p. 222).
- 26 *viśeṣādvadhāraṇarūpe nirṇyamānārthaviśaye nirṇayajñāne tadvāivārthaparicchedavyāpṛte 'paraḥ svagato nirṇayo na pravartate. jñānasya hy arthapāratantryaṃ svadharmaḥ. ata eva jñānāntaragrāhyatvaṃ na bhavatīti ghaṭajñānaṃ iti prāg eva pratipāditam iti jñānāntaraviśayatve viśayityāgat svadharmaṃ haniḥ.*
- 27 *na ca vācakarūpeṇa pravṛttasyāsti vācyatā/pratipādyam na tat tatra yenānyat pratipadyate //* (VP 3.2.26).
- 28 *karaṇasanniveśinas tadvāivābhideyatā viruddhā, anyapratipādanapravṛttasya tadvāiva pratyudāvṛtṭyātmani vyāpārābhāvāt. vastusvabhāvo 'yam yat karṭṛśaktiyuktaṃ na tat karmaśakter adhikaraṇaṃ tadvāiva bhavati, svāntropyapāratantryayor ekadākatra virodhādity arthaḥ.*
- 29 *ātmarūpaṃ yathā jñāne jñeyarūpaṃ ca drśyate / artharūpaṃ tathā śabde svarūpaṃ ca prakāśate //* (VP 1.51).
- 30 *jñeyena na vinā jñānaṃ vyavāhare 'vatiṣṭhate* (VP 1.89ab). "In ordinary reality, one cannot establish a cognition without a content".
- 31 *darśanasyāpi yat satyaṃ na tathā darśanaṃ sthitam / vastusaṃsargarūpeṇa tad arūpaṃ nirūpyate //* (VP 2.426). "The true nature of a cognition is not as it appears; it is formless, and it is ascertained in connection with an object".
- 32 *yathā viśayadharmāṇāṃ jñāne 'tyantam asaṃbhavaḥ / tadātmeva ca tat siddham atyantam atadātmakam //* *tathā vikārarūpāṇāṃ tattve 'tyantam asaṃbhavaḥ / tadātmeva ca tat tattvam atyantam atadātmakam //* (VP 3.2.9–10).
- 33 *vijñānavāde viśayākāśasya bhāvato 'satyatvān nīlādis tatgato dharmo jaḍo 'jaḍe jñāne 'saṃbhavī atyantam iti. jaḍajāḍayor na kenacid aṃśena sārūpyam ity āha. tathā cōktam: ekadeśena sārūpye sarvaṃ syāt sarvavedanam/sarvātmanā tu sārūpye jñānaṃ ajñānatām vrajet //* (Helārāja on VP 3.2.9–10). This stanza is a variant of Dharmakīrti's PV 3.434, which according to Birgit Kellner's reconstruction was originally different, with the two half-verses in the reverse order: *sarvātmanā hi sārūpye jñānaṃ ajñānatām vrajet / sāmye kenacid aṃśena syāt sarvaṃ sarvavedanam //* (Kellner, 2009, p. 201). The stanza is quoted in three different commentaries on Kumārila's ŚV, Sūnyavāda 20, those of Uṃveka Bhaṭṭa (730–790), Sucarita (tenth c.), and Pārthasārathi Miśra (eleventh c.). Manorathanandin comments on this by saying: *na ca jaḍayor grāhyagrāhakabhāvaḥ kenacid aṃśena vastutvanīlatvādinā sarvaṃ jñānaṃ sarvasyārthasya saṃvedanam syāt. sarvaṃ vā nīlajñānaṃ sarvasya nīlasya vedanam syāt*. "There is no relationship of knower-known between two inert things, otherwise any knowledge would know everything. Or each cognition of blue would cognize all blue things".
- 34 *anyavyavacchedair grahaṇavyavahāro 'pi svaparaviśayo ya ucyate, so 'pi nirvāhed ityāśayena saugatīyam abhāvasiddhiprakāram eva vicārayati. tatra jñānaṃ svaprakāśaikaarūpaṃ iti upapāditam asaṃkṛt. yathāha tatrabhavān 'yathā jyotiḥ prakāśena nānyenābhiprakāśyate / jñānarūpaṃ tathā jñāne nānyatrābhiprakāśyate'. tatas ca jñānāntareṇa ekajñānasamsargayogyaṃ na bhavati yenaivaṃ ucyate yadi dve jñāne bhavetām, tadvijñānajñānaṃ tṛtīyaṃ bhavet* (ĪPVV vol. 1, p. 276–277). The current editions of the VP present a slightly different reading of this *kārikā*: *yathā jyotiḥ prakāśena nānyenābhiprakāśyate / jñānākāras tathānyena na jñānenopagrhyate//*.
- 35 *nanu ghaṭe smaryamāṇe vedyadaśādhiśādhiśayini anubhavo grāhakenaiva milatu, tasmīn eva tu smaryamāṇe vedyīkṛte kiṃ vācyaṃ. ucyate. ghaṭe mama anubhavo 'bhūd ity api kathane ghaṭa eva vedyāḥ. yathāha tatrabhavān 'ghaṭajñānaṃ iti jñānaṃ ghaṭajñānavilakṣaṇam / ghaṭa ity yaj jñānaṃ viśayopanipāti tat //* (ĪPVV vol. 2, p. 53).

5 A linguistic consciousness

In the previous chapters, we have seen how the Pratyabhijñā authors claimed to have countered the Buddhist criticism of the notion of personhood. They appealed to an epistemic principle the Buddhists themselves share, namely, that cognitions are self-aware and cannot be the object of other cognitions. The Śaivas maintain that the Buddhists actually hold a wrong and contradictory view on the question, since they do not properly understand the self-conscious nature of a cognition. According to them, cognitions or mental states have a purely conscious dimension which can never be the intention of a mental state, not even of the very same one. This aspect, the Śaivas argue, is what subjectivity consists in and is the basis of the very notion of self. Using a contemporary philosophical jargon, we could say that the Pratyabhijñā authors hold that the notion of self ‘supervene’ on that of pure phenomenal subjectivity. Put another way, this means that whenever there is a change in pure phenomenal subjectivity, a corresponding change in the notion of self necessarily occurs. The converse is, of course, not true, and Utpaladeva explicitly says it.¹

In this and the following chapters, we explore in depth what kind of subjectivity the Pratyabhijñā authors had in mind, what are its main characteristics, and whether the overall picture the school holds is consistent. I shall basically argue that Utpaladeva formulated a theory whereby ‘to be conscious’ comes down to having second-order representations of first-order mental states. This second-order representations are conceptual and language driven. Although the Śaivas made a substantial effort to lay out the details of this theory, the credit for developing it are to be given to Bhartṛhari. Accordingly, I first discuss what the VP has to say on the question, with extensive reference to similar positions held in contemporary philosophy of mind. Afterwards, I show how Pratyabhijñā’s treatment of the question follows Bhartṛhari’s one rather faithfully.

Are cognitions language dependent?

Indian philosophers have often and heatedly discussed the question whether cognitions have a perceptual nature, a conceptual one, or rather a mixing of the two. If in perceptual knowledge the stress is on the sensory character of cognitions, conceptual knowledge is normally regarded as dependent on linguistic elaboration.

In other words, the very fact that we can formulate concepts presupposes the existence of language. If we consider the history of the question in classical India, the idea that a dependable cognition is only perceptual is a centrepiece of the Buddhist Pramāṇavādins' philosophical program. A cognition is true when it is based on perception.² However, a perception is immediately followed by a conceptual elaboration of the sensory data, which, as we have already seen, can have some practical utility but it is in the end inherently mistaken. The opposite view, championed by Bhartṛhari (but supported also by Jaina philosophers and by the so-called 'New Logic', the Navya-Nyāya), is the one we discuss at length in the following: a veridical cognition is actually entirely conceptual, there being no cognitive episodes that occur independently from language. There are finally less drastic positions, advocated by the traditions of Mīmāṃsā and old Nyāya, according to which cognitions are partly perceptual (*nirvikalpaka*) and partly conceptual (*savikalpaka*).³

Bhartṛhari addresses the issue of the conceptual character of knowledge in a cluster of stanzas contained in the first chapter of the VP. In a well-known verse, very often quoted by both classical authors and modern scholars, he quite straightforwardly states that language and knowledge have a close connection:

In the world, there is no cognition without the pervasion of language. All knowledge shines as if pierced by language.⁴

From a linguistic point of view, this stanza displays two peculiar verbs, *anugam* and *anuvyadh*, which, more or less metaphorically, point out that language and knowledge are strictly intertwined, perhaps that there is even an invariable concomitance between the two.⁵ Philosophically speaking, the situation is more intricate, and to understand what Bhartṛhari thinks, we should reflect on the key terms he is using. In the first place, it is worth considering what Bhartṛhari has in mind when he talks about knowledge. In VP 1.131, the word he uses to convey the notion is *jñāna* (together with the synonym *pratyaya*). The expression *jñāna* indicates a very generic act of awareness that stands for a variety of mental events (beliefs, desires, intentions, knowledge, etc.) having an intentional content (i.e. mental events that *refer to* or are *about* things); *jñāna* has thus a broader connotation than that of the related term *pramā*, which indicates a veridical cognition whose appropriateness is guaranteed by the application of reliable epistemic means.⁶ However, both *jñāna* and *pramā* presuppose a conception of knowledge that is different from the one developed in Euro-American epistemology. Whilst Euro-American thinkers commonly see knowledge as a disposition, in the form of a justified true belief,⁷ Indian ones tend to regard it as an episodic moment of awareness (Potter, 1984, pp. 310–311). The concept of *jñāna* can therefore be assimilated to the contemporary notion of 'mental representation', or 'mental state'.⁸ Just like a mental representation, *jñāna* can be regarded as a mental object possessing intentionality and semantic properties, such as content, reference, truth conditions, truth-value, etc. (Pitt, 2000). If we agree on this construal, Bhartṛhari is eventually claiming that to have mental representations, one needs a language.

The second question takes into account concerns what sort of language Bhartṛhari has in mind when he affirms that language had a close relationship to knowledge. Even though we cannot be sure whether the notion was circulating before him, this author is credited with having disseminated the idea that speech is a multidimensional phenomenon, having different levels of manifestation. In the whole of the VP, the concept is discussed in only one place and hardly resumed elsewhere; still the notion stuck and became almost immediately regarded as a central doctrine of the grammarians. In a nutshell, Bhartṛhari claims that language develops progressively and that audible, public speech (*vaikharī vāc*)—the one we use in our everyday exchange—is an external manifestation of two inner levels: an intermediate one (*madhyamā vāc*) and an innermost linguistic principle (*paśyantī vāc*) from which the two lower stages derive:

The “elaborated” word (*vaikharī*) is that which is intelligible to others, which is grasped by the sense of hearing, it is fixed in each and every case and has an audible character. It is a conjoined [word], a collection of discrete sounds whose correctness is well-established or in which the correct grammatical formation is lost. Being present in the axle of a cart, in a drum, a flute or a lute, it possesses unlimited manifestations. The “middle” word (*madhyamā*), on the other hand, is internal, it has a sort of temporal sequence and is grasped by the mind only. Yet, according to some, the middle word is pervaded by the activity of subtle breath and, even if in it sequence is contracted, it possesses a detectable [kind of] breath. The “seeing” word (*paśyantī*), is that in which sequence is subsumed and, albeit unitary, it is pervaded by the capacity to produce sequence. It is movable and immovable and it is that which is obtained by concentration; it is concealed and pure; it has the form of the contents entering into it, the form in which all contents disappear into it and no form at all; it manifests itself in the form of meanings which are diversified, associated and all rest on it. Hence it possesses unlimited manifestations.⁹

If the status of *vaikharī* and *paśyantī* is relatively clear, for they correspond respectively to oral language and to an inner linguistic kernel from which the former derives, the nature of the intermediate state, *madhyamā*, is less obvious. I think the main question is whether Bhartṛhari refers with it to a natural language, Sanskrit in the specific case, or to something altogether different, namely a ‘Language of Thought’ (LoT).

The LoT hypothesis has first been introduced in contemporary philosophy of mind by Jerry Fodor (1975, 2008). The theory belongs to the spectrum of materialist theories of mind, more precisely to functionalism. In this view, a mental state is never defined in terms of its ontological nature, namely, by what a mental state is made of, but by the relations it bears with (1) the external sensory inputs, (2) the behavioural outputs it produces, and (3) other mental states. Fodor combines the basic functionalist approach with computationalism, that is, the doctrine whereby mind is compared to a computer, with mental states equated to the software running on the brain, which in turn corresponds to the hardware.

The relations occurring between mental states, sensory inputs, and behavioural outputs are syntactical and governed by an algorithm. A mental state is therefore nothing but a computational state, and it corresponds to a sentence of a language of the mind, LoT, which is sometimes also called ‘Mentalese’. Put another way, the idea behind the notion of LoT is that thinking takes place through a system of symbols that is different from the one we use in ordinary speech. This hypothetical idiom is regarded as an innate code of the mind and as capable of being translated into natural languages.

The point is whether this model can be used to account for Bhartṛhari’s conception that language is a multilevel phenomenon. Without pushing the comparison too far, I think it is worth noting that some aspects of Bhartṛhari’s conception of *madhyamā* are quite similar to the contemporary understanding of LoT. According to the definition, the author himself gives in the *Vṛtti*, *madhyamā* has three peculiar features: internality (*antaḥsaṃniveśa*), mind dependence (*buddhimātropādāna*), and sequentiality (*parigrhītakrama*). These three characteristics remind those contemporary theorists identify in LoT (Fodor, 1975). First, LoT is distinct from public language, a feature that corresponds to *madhyamā*’s ‘internality’. Second, LoT is exclusively based on the mind, which is consistent with *madhyamā*’s ‘mind dependence’, for it is conceived as an organized network of mental representations. Third, LoT’s basic signs (i.e. mental representations) have a syntactical structure, a feature that approximately corresponds to the notion conveyed by the expression *krama*, intended as ‘regular arrangement’. I am not sure if all this is sufficient to prove that Bhartṛhari conceived *madhyamā* as a form of LoT, but at the same time, I do not see crucial evidences showing that it is not. Indeed, the remark made after the definition of *madhyamā*, according to which some thinkers believe that this stage too is based on the activity of breath—an argument for considering *madhyamā* a case of natural language—seems to corroborate the idea that Bhartṛhari’s first option is actually to regard this stage as mental. The main advantage of the hypothesis that *madhyamā* is a LoT is that we come by an elegant picture of the three stages of *vāc*: *vaikhari* indicating a natural language, *madhyamā* a LoT, and *paśyanti* representing consciousness. All the same, either we consider *madhyamā* a LoT or a natural language; the interpretation I am proposing is not affected in any substantial way.

Knowledge and truth: the *arthakriyā* stance

Whether Bhartṛhari conceived language as a mental or natural fact, his idea that all cognitions or mental states involve concepts and in turn that concepts entail language needs to be put to the test. To understand how he eventually manages to put forward a reasonable explanation of this claim, we must start from an issue that is only apparently unrelated. We must consider the criterion whereby one can distinguish between reliable and non-reliable knowledge. The topic has widely been debated by Indian philosophers, who have generally adopted three different stances on the issue. The first, advocated by the realist schools of Nyāya and Mīmāṃsa, holds that a cognition is true when it matches a state of affairs in the

external world, that is, when it is in accordance with external reality (*yathārtha*). The position is by and large similar to the Euro-American *correspondence theory* of truth and faces the same objections (Perrett, 2016, p. 55). The second theory, traditionally associated with the Sāṃkhya philosophical tradition, is historically less influential. It holds that a cognition is true when it is in harmony (*saṃvāda*) with a network of related cognitions. The theory does not make any claim about the ontological nature of the contents of knowledge and is roughly comparable to Euro-American ‘coherentism’. The third and final position holds that a cognition is true when one can act successfully on its basis (*arthakriyā*). In this view, the truth of a cognition lies in its pragmatic value. This theory is traditionally associated with the work of the Buddhist Pramāṇavādins.¹⁰

What about Bhartṛhari? The author of the VP is not particularly keen to discuss epistemological questions, especially by adopting the typical framework centred on *pramāṇas*.¹¹ Furthermore, he does not seem interested in the notion of *pramā*, which does not appear in the context under discussion. However, since *jñānas* are mental representations and possess truth conditions, there must be a criterion to establish their appropriateness, or as Potter put it, their “workability” (Potter, 1984, p. 318). In this regard, although the question is not addressed straightforwardly, it is clear that Bhartṛhari prefers the pragmatic, *arthakriyā* approach over the others. It is sufficient to consider three examples. In the *Vṛtti* on VP 1.131, he explicitly says that indeterminate, non-conceptual knowledge produces no effect at all: “Just like one has a verbal potentiality in a contracted form, similarly no effect is produced by indeterminate knowledge, even if it arises in relation with objects that are [already] known”.¹² In VP 1.129, Bhartṛhari states that the awareness of actions carried out in ordinary life is grounded on language: “In the world all that is required to be done is dependent on language. A child too understands it on the basis of the traces of previous births”.¹³ The notion is finally made explicit in VP 1.135, where it is claimed that it is indeed language that urges all creatures towards successful actions. If it were not for language, the stanza goes on, everything would be as insentient as a piece of wood: “Language urges all creatures towards successful activities. If it were to disappear, all this world would be unconscious like a piece of wood or a wall”.¹⁴

The main contention here is that to be regarded as proper knowledge, a cognition must have a pragmatic value. And it is already clear that what makes knowledge capable to initiate a successful action is its being inherently conceptual and linguistic. It remains to be seen whether there are good reasons to substantiate this claim.

A higher-order theory of consciousness

The reason why language is required to have dependable cognitions is given by Bhartṛhari mostly in a negative way. Let us consider this telling passage from the *Vṛtti*:

If knowledge were not by nature linguistic, that very vague cognition that has been produced, being unable to contribute to another cognition, would

not function as a means to accomplish the action of knowing. In fact, once there is a cognition of a bare object, whose different parts are not functional to each other and are mutually independent, immediately after comes a unification, a synthesis, the production of a unitary content, that is, the grasping of conjoined capacities as undifferentiated; all this is connected to the linguistic nature of cognitions.¹⁵

It is difficult to overstate how crucial this passage is. Bhartṛhari argues that true knowledge presupposes an act of mental unification, a synthesis of the bare sensations one acquires through the senses. Without it, these very sensations would remain unrelated and not functional to each other. This act of unification implies an activity of the mind that is capable of scanning the sensory data and the associated mental states so as to produce a “unitary content”. All this evidently entails that for Bhartṛhari, there are two kinds of cognitions or mental states. A first-order one directly produced by the external stimuli, which is accompanied by a higher-order one that operates on the former and makes it conscious. Bhartṛhari seems thus to envisage what contemporary theorists of mind call a ‘higher-order theory of consciousness’.

Higher-order theories of consciousness came to the fore to explain how a mental state is conscious. The supporters of the theory believe that a mental state is conscious “if one is conscious of that state in some suitable way” (Rosenthal, 2009, p. 240). This means that consciousness eventually comes down to the representation a mental state has of another. Differently put, consciousness is regarded as a transitive condition, in the sense that it requires that a given state has another one as its content. The first and most obvious objection to this account is that it leads to vicious regress. If one needs a second-order mental state to explain the conscious state of the first-order one, one would need a third-order one to account for the second and so on endlessly. The proponents of higher-order theories meet the objection by simply claiming that higher-order states are unconscious, thus avoiding the charge of circularity. That some mental states are conscious while others are not is therefore a fundamental precondition for ‘higher-order representation’ theorists. The typical example they provide is subliminal perception, that is, the situation in which one is aware of things but in a non-conscious way.

Returning to Bhartṛhari, if we want to formulate the hypothesis that he is conceiving consciousness and cognitions in higher-order terms, we must look for passages suggesting that some cognitions can be entertained unconsciously. With regard to this, Vincenzo Vergiani has clearly shown how Bhartṛhari accepts the existence of ‘liminal cognitions’ (Vergiani, 2012), that is, of cognitive states one is in unconsciously, typically because they happen very quickly or one’s attention is focused elsewhere. They are liminal because they are in between: they are unconscious but not altogether different from conscious ones, mainly because they can be recalled to mind later on. It suffices here to mention an example contained in the *Vṛtti*, in which Bhartṛhari talks of somebody walking fast without being consciously aware of the grass and clods of earth he is proceeding through.¹⁶ Again, the text explains the unconscious nature of these mental representations with the fact that one cannot

initiate any action on their basis. Accordingly, Bhartṛhari's point is that a successful activity requires an awareness of one's own mental states, which consists in a second-order representation of the first-order ones based on experience.

In addition to this, high-order theorists need to further explain how higher-order mental states operate on first-order ones, and they typically diverge on the question. There are two main competing theses in contemporary philosophy of mind. The first claims that higher states have a perceptual awareness of their first-order counterparts (Armstrong, 1968; Lycan, 1996, 2004). According to this view, mental states are conscious due to a specific capacity of mind, an inner sense that scans and perceives the mental states one is in. On the other hand, the second thesis argues that the awareness higher-order states have of first-order ones is not perceptual but conceptual; it is a thought. The upholders of either theories have arguments on their side, with some problems being better solved by the perceptual hypothesis and others better served by the conceptual one. This is not the place to evaluate the merits of one proposal over the other. What is important to our purposes is to see where Bhartṛhari's higher-order theory is positioned. The passage quoted earlier does not say anything explicit about the question, but the fact that language is for Bhartṛhari always involved in cognitions is a strong indication that for him higher-order states operate conceptually on first-order ones.

This eventually leads us to the main issue: why is language necessary to have high-order representations, and in the end, to possess consciousness and knowledge?

Language and consciousness: how to justify their relationship?

Rather surprisingly, in the VP the claim that cognitions and mental states are inherently dependent on language remains essentially unjustified. The fact is certainly peculiar for we are possibly talking about the most decisive aspect of the entire discussion. Still, Bhartṛhari seems somehow to take for granted a picture of the following sort: if consciousness is produced by higher-order representations, then an individual must possess a system of these representations. By a system, I mean a number of basic elements whose relations are determined by a set of rules, that is to say, by a *syntax*. Without such a system, the activity of unification and synthesis of the data provided by the senses—a synthesis which is required to act successfully—would be impossible. The whole claim is of course controversial, and one would have hoped to find a more explicit explanation. Yet it is not certainly indefensible. To appreciate the plausibility of Bhartṛhari's claim, it is useful to go through some of the arguments in support of the hypothesis that language and consciousness enjoy a strict relationship. The first reason to take into account is the native one, that of the *communis opinio* of classical India. The arguments is not necessarily strong, but most Indian philosophers would actually agree that conceptual thinking always entails language. The point of contention is rather if all knowledge is really conceptual. Once established that such is the case, the passage from conceptuality to language is generally regarded as unproblematic.

The second argument brings us back to the question of LoT. One can argue that an LoT is precisely a language, hence a system of signs endowed with basic units, which are combined according to syntactic rules and expressed in sentences of Mentalese. In this weaker sense, it is certainly possible to claim that to think and to cognize, one necessarily needs a (non-natural) language.

Still, and this would be a third argument, several contemporary theorists have defended stronger versions of the idea that there is a close relationship between natural, public language, consciousness, and thought. For instance, the supporters of Higher-order thought claim that one of the main features of higher-order representations, and consciousness in general, is reportability, that is, the capability to report that one is in a given mental state. If one is capable to verbally report being in a mental state, then that state must be conscious (Rosenthal, 2009, pp. 243–244). Furthermore, it is worth considering in some detail one of the most influential arguments in support of the idea that thought presupposes language, the one advanced by Donald Davidson (1975, 1982). Davidson argues for an audacious (and contentious) version of the theory—sometimes labelled ‘lingualism’—insofar as he not only claims that to have high-order thoughts one needs a natural language but that thought *per se* consists in the capacity to have higher-order thoughts. This leads him to conclude that a creature without language is inherently incapable of thinking, thus barring animals and infants from having rational thoughts. Davidson’s arguments can be summarized as follows. His point of departure is that rationality is a social capacity, which pertains only to creatures able to interpret others. In his view, to interpret means to ascribe thoughts to other creatures. Davidson also believes that rationality’s essential feature is the capacity to have propositional attitudes. ‘Propositional attitude’ is a label used to describe mental states like ‘*x* wish that *p*’, ‘*x* thinks that *p*’, ‘*x* hopes that *p*’, etc., in which *p* is a proposition. Examples may be: ‘I wish that you were here’, ‘I think that she will be back soon’, and the like. For Davidson, the only way to determine if a person is rational—i.e. if she has thought—is to determine whether she has propositional attitudes. But for him, the capacity to have propositional attitudes requires a natural language. Let us consider two different sets of arguments for the claim. The first relies on the notion that propositional attitudes are *per se* semantically opaque. Semantic opacity indicates the fact that if we change the words of a sentence that describes the reference of a propositional attitude, the truth-value of the sentence can change. For instance, the propositional attitude ‘The dog believes the cat went up the oak tree’ is different from the propositional attitude ‘The dog believes the cat went up the oldest tree in the garden’. The truth-value of the two sentences may in fact be different or identical. The point is that we cannot *a priori* determine the truth-value of the sentence because we are unable to tell whether the dog knows that both sentences refer to the same object. The only way at our disposal to tell if the contents of a propositional attitude is opaque or not is by knowing a language. Coming back to the example, Davidson’s point is that we could know whether the dog believes that ‘the oak tree’ is coreferential with ‘the oldest tree in the garden’ only by asking him. Since the dog cannot reply to our question, the conclusion is that to have rationality one must have a natural language.

A second line of reasoning in support of lingualism runs as follows. Assume that beliefs are the most fundamental propositional attitudes, insofar as they are presupposed by all other kinds of propositional attitudes. The notion is easy to grasp: even if you fancy an apple (i.e. a desire, hence a specific propositional attitude), you must believe that there is an apple beforehand, so you must have a belief. The second point is that a belief never occurs in isolation, but it is always accompanied by a set of related beliefs. If you believe that New Delhi is the capital of India, you also necessarily believe that there is a city called New Delhi, a country called India comprising a city whose name is New Delhi, and so forth. The third and crucial point is that you cannot have beliefs without having the concept of belief. How does Davidson justify this rather disputable affirmation? He reflects on the fact that a belief can be true or false. There are nevertheless instances in which a belief we were sure to be true turns out to be false upon subsequent reflection, or because of new information. If the belief that I have a coin in my pocket is falsified by a later belief, that is, by the fact that I realize that the pocket is actually empty, this means that the later belief is directed at the earlier one, namely, it is a representation, a concept of another belief. Accordingly, since beliefs can be established as true or false, they must entail the notion of objective truth. But the notion of objective truth is always correlated for Davidson to that of subjective truth: if a certain belief can be true or false, then the holder of the belief must be aware that there is a difference between how things are (*objective side*) and how they appear to him (*subjective side*). But to distinguish the truth-value of a belief, one must have a standard of evaluation that is shared. This standard of evaluation is what Davidson calls *intersubjective truth*, and it is that which develops only in the contest of linguistic interpretation and communication. As Davidson puts it:

What would show command of the subjective–objective contrast? Clearly linguistic communication suffices. To understand the speech of another, I must be able to think of the same thing she does; I must share her world. I don't have to agree with her in all matters, but in order to disagree we must entertain the same proposition, with the same subject matter, and the same standard of truth. Communication depends, then, on each communicant having, and correctly thinking that the other has, the concept of a shared world, an intersubjective world. But the concept of an intersubjective world is the concept of an objective world, a world about which each communicant can have beliefs.

(Davidson, 1982, p. 327)

All this allows Davidson to argue that beliefs are informed by language. Since beliefs are the basic propositional attitudes and the latter the hallmark of thought, it follows that in order to have thought, one requires a natural language.

A different set of arguments to show the dependence of thought on language has been put forward more recently by José Luis Bermúdez (Bermúdez, 2003). Different from Davidson, Bermúdez claims that non-linguistic creatures can actually have thoughts; still they are unable to think a specific type of them, namely,

those which are themselves the content of higher-order representations. Actually, the focus of Bermúdez's elaboration is not on second-order representations but rather on the way first-order ones are conveyed. He argues that reflexive thinking is possible only if the target thoughts (i.e. the first-order representations) have 'vehicles' that allow them to be the object of further thoughts. The point is to understand what these vehicles are and how they work. In principle, there are just two possibilities: the target-thoughts can have vehicles that operate either at a sub-personal or a personal level. The jargon might sound intimidating, but the concept is simple: if target-thoughts operate at a personal level, it means that the owner of the thoughts is conscious of them; by contrast, in the case of sub-personal level, target-thoughts operate on a deeper level, and the subject is not conscious of them. This case clearly corresponds to Fodor's LoT, that is, to a system of representations that occur in the mind and of which the subject of experience is not aware. On the other hand, if the vehicles of target-thoughts operate at personal level, then we have only two further possibilities: either the vehicles are sentences of a natural language or are pictorial representations, in short, images. Given this overall background, Bermúdez claims that (1) vehicles of target-thoughts operate on a personal level, hence there is no LoT, and (2) the vehicles of target-thoughts are sentences of a natural language. How does he justify these claims? As for claim 1, he argues that reflexive thinking seems to imply that the subject is conscious of the thinking. His most explicit argument is that having reflexive thinking entails having the target-thoughts in mind, together with the awareness that these thoughts are inferentially and logically related. This kind of awareness is not possible if one's LoT is the vehicle of target thoughts, because LoT operates by definition at sub-personal, unconscious level. The argument seems to hint at a wider problem in philosophy of mind. One of the main features of thought is its rationality, that is, the fact that thoughts are logically related. A materialist theory of mind that wishes to reduce mental states to brain states will have to explain why mental states have syntactical and logical relations, whereas brain states have not. By arguing that reflexive thought is conveyed by vehicles happening at a personal, conscious level, Bermúdez avoids this objection and claims that rationality comes together with the vehicles themselves. This brings us to Bermúdez's second affirmation: granted that the target-thoughts have vehicles operating at a personal level, are these vehicles sentences of a natural, public language, or pictorial representations? Let us consider the latter case first. In the case of a pictorial representation, we have a mental map which is 'isomorphic' with what it represents. Isomorphism simply means that the relations between the elements of a mental model are mapped onto the relations existing *out there*, between the objects of representation. For Bermúdez, to conceive the vehicles as a mental map, thus based on images, is to understand representation in a weak sense. All that is needed is in fact a relation of resemblance and exemplification between the map and its content. Conversely, conceiving the vehicles as sentences of a language entails a strong interpretation of the representation. Isomorphism is not enough in this case. What is needed are some basic representational units which are to be combined according to certain identifiable rules. In sum, the problem

with pictorial representation is that it is difficult to see how images can inferentially be related. Mental maps can be associated and be the content of other maps, but to have inferential capacity, they must be reduced to propositions, that is to sentences of a language. Thus, by an argument he himself calls 'by elimination', Bermúdez concludes that at least a specific kind of thought—reflexive thought—necessitates speech.

Where would Bhartṛhari position himself in what we have said so far? I think some of his ideas can be fruitfully compared with those we have just gone through. As we saw earlier, his most crucial notion is that to have consciousness, thought and knowledge one needs a syntactical relation between mental states and cognitions. This parallels quite explicitly the idea Bermúdez is defending, that is, that one needs language to guarantee the inferential connections between thoughts. Without a linguistic synthesis, the single mental states one experiences would turn out to be impossible to relate to one another in a logical and successful way. The problematic aspect is whether to consider Bhartṛhari's language—or, better an aspect of his multidimensional conception of language—as a LoT. One may be induced to consider the idea that the system of representations he has in mind is purely mental and innate. As I said earlier, I do not see in principle any objection to this conclusion, but it must be evaluated with other statements he makes. In support of this notion, there is, for instance, the fact that Bhartṛhari insists that language is ingrained in infants and animals as well, which are creatures who do not possess a natural language. Also, this clearly goes against Davidson's conception whereby a natural language is a presupposition for thought and rationality. On the other hand, Davidson's idea that language is an intersubjective affair that takes its proper form in public speech is something that Bhartṛhari would certainly not reject, especially as far as semantic questions are concerned. It is thus evident that trying to accommodate Bhartṛhari's position in a rigid framework is of little use. What is indeed helpful is to reckon that the problem of the relationship between language and thought can be approached in a variety of ways and that these approaches are useful as a background—as a common ground, to use Davidson's words—to better circumscribe and appraise Bhartṛhari's position.

The *svasaṃvedana* objection

I think the picture I have conjured up thus far correctly represents Bhartṛhari's view. There is nonetheless a potentially fatal objection to this account. To admit the existence of higher-order representations implies that these representations act on first-order ones. And this obviously goes against the principle we have discussed at length in Chapters 3 and 4, according to which a cognition is self-conscious and cannot be the content of another. How to make sense of these seemingly contradictory statements?

We have already encountered a possible way out of the conundrum. It is the one devised by contemporary higher-order theorists, who claim that higher-order representations are themselves unconscious, so there is no risk of infinite regress. In Bhartṛhari's case, this would mean that the action of coordination of cognitions

he regards as crucial to having reliable knowledge is not experienced consciously, a position that on the whole looks like tenable. Yet there is a further way to reconcile the notion of non-objectification of cognitions with that of a higher-order theory. If one reads carefully the cluster of stanzas and the commentary we have just analyzed, one cannot fail to notice how often Bhartṛhari lays stress on the fact that language is present at all cognitive levels. This implies that conceptuality, which is the hallmark of higher-order representations, is always at work, a view that allows Bhartṛhari to claim that even the most immediate perceptions have a conceptual content. This does not count as a proof of the dependence of thought on language, but it lets us refine Bhartṛhari's view as follows. When he is defining what makes a cognitive state what it is, Bhartṛhari is probably not thinking of a different cognition having the first one as its content. On the contrary, the first-order mental state must already possess within itself its higher-order representation, thus leading to the conclusion that for Bhartṛhari mental states or cognitions are self-representational. In other words, mental states seem to own two aspects: a world-directed one and metacognitive one, occurring simultaneously. This view is known to specialists in Indian thought, since it is close to the notion Dharmakīrti introduced that knowledge has both perceptual and judgemental (*niścaya*) sides.

The view is also similar to the notion of 'hybrid higher-order theories' or 'self-representational' theories, advanced by some contemporary philosophers of mind to address difficulties posed by standard higher-order models. Thinkers supporting the idea that a first-order mental state already contains within itself its higher-order counterpart, back two different understandings of the theory. Some (Carruthers, 2000) believe that between first- and higher-order mental states, there is a relation of identity; others believe that they rather enjoy a relation of part and whole (Gennaro, 1996, 2005; Kriegel, 2003, 2009). If in the former case the first-order perceptual state becomes conscious due to the higher-order state; in the latter, what become conscious is a complex state "made up of both the first-order perception and the higher-order belief" (Carruthers, 2016).

Summary

Before proceeding to see how all this has been highly influential for the Pratyabhijñā's conceptions, it is beneficial to sum up what Bhartṛhari intends when he posits a strict connection between language and cognitions.

- 1 I have started with the assumption that the notion of 'cognition' (*jñāna*, *pratyaya*) is equivalent to that of 'mental representation'. This is because Indian thinkers normally conceive knowledge as an intentional, episodic awareness rather than a disposition of the mind. Although different from *pramā*, *jñāna* also has truth-conditions. In force of that, there must be a criterion to distinguish between dependable and non-dependable cognitions.
- 2 According to Bhartṛhari, this criterion consists in cognitions' causal efficiency (*arthakriyā*), that is, the possibility to act successfully on the basis of a given mental representation.

- 3 One can initiate a successful action only through a synthesis of first-order, world-directed mental states. Such a synthesis is guaranteed by higher-order representations that are conceptual.
- 4 Bhartṛhari assumes that these higher-order, conceptual representations are rooted in language, be it natural or mental. The VP does not provide substantial evidence for this affirmation, which it is nevertheless defensible.
- 5 Bhartṛhari further holds that a cognition is self-conscious and never the object of another. But he also believes that higher-order representations (i.e. concepts and language) are present in all cognitive states. This entails that each mental representation is at the same time experience directed (it is about something) and self-directed (it is about itself), thus being capable to generate a higher-order thought of itself.
- 6 The conclusion is that in order to have cognitions and to be conscious in general, language is required.

Pratyabhijñā's appropriation of Bhartṛhari's conceptual scheme

The picture we have discussed so far had a huge impact on the way Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta conceived consciousness. The impact is not just a matter of theoretical resemblance, for the Śaivas actually quoted most of Bhartṛhari's stanzas we have hitherto discussed as authoritative sources for their work.¹⁷ To appreciate how far-reaching Bhartṛhari's influence was, it is useful to start with the very definition of consciousness Abhinavagupta gives in the *ĪPV* on 1.5.13. This is the stanza in which Utpaladeva argues that between language and consciousness, an intimate relationship obtains:

The word *citi*, derived from *cetayati*, “to make conscious”, indicates the activity of consciousness, whose essential nature, its essence, is a reflexive awareness characterized by self-savouring. To explain: a pot does not have savouring with respect to itself; it does not have a reflective awareness as a self, it does not cognize with respect to itself, nor it shines as having an uninterrupted nature. This is why it is said to be unconscious. On the other hand, a person named Caitra has savouring with respect to himself, for he has the power to produce an effort towards a raised state, that is the “I”; he has reflexive awareness as a self and cognizes precisely with respect to himself. He is manifested in a limited semblance—that is to say as “this”—in a form that is different from the “I”, and is associated with countless manifestations like blue, yellow, pleasure, pain, their absence etc. This is why it is said that Caitra is conscious. Thus, it is not at all established that reflexive awareness is one thing and non-reflexive awareness is another, for reflexive awareness is capable of everything: it makes identical to itself what is different, and makes itself a different thing; it brings together both difference and identity, and demotes both of them, which were previously unified. This is precisely

its essential nature. Furthermore, reflexive awareness's essential nature is "languageing", consisting in inner speech. This "languageing" is independent from any linguistic convention and is an uninterrupted spontaneous savouring. It is like an internal nodding of the head; it is the life of the conventional sounds existing at the Māyā level, such as "a" etc., because it is the internal support of a reflexive awareness such as "this is blue" or "I am Caitra" and so on. Since speech denotes, conveys, all things through reflexive awareness, consciousness is said to be the "word". This word is supreme because of its completeness. Hence, having a conscious nature and resting on itself, this word arises freely, it never declines, it exists permanently as the "I". This primary freedom of the self is said to be its sovereignty, its supremacy, its independence from others.¹⁸

Abhinavagupta's definition of consciousness (*cit*, *caitanya*) at the beginning of this passage is rather compelling. To be conscious, he says, means to have a reflexive awareness of one's own mental states. We have already encountered the expression 'reflexive awareness' (*vimarśa*, *pratyavamarśa*) in Chapter 3. It should be by now clear that *vimarśa* indicates nothing but higher-order thought, that is, the activity second-order mental representations perform on first, experience-based ones, which the Śaiva thinkers usually call "cognition", "light", *prakāśa*. Crucially, Abhinavagupta adds that consciousness is not limited to the possession of higher-order thought. In it there is also the involvement of a purely subjective aspect, which Abhinavagupta refers to with the puzzling expression *camatkāra*, 'savouring', which we discuss more in detail in Chapter 6.

Also in this case, one could file the same objection already raised to Bhartṛhari's higher-order theory. What about the principle that cognitions are never objectifiable? Pratyabhijñā's answer runs along the same lines: higher-order thought are intrinsic to first-order representations and do not imply that they have the latter as content. Interestingly, Abhinavagupta provides us with a clue about this idea when he says that there is no difference between *vimarśa* and its alleged opposite, that is, first-order experience. The passage is often interpreted as indicating that humans possess an infinite capacity for conceptual representations, but I think that the author is also hinting at the fact that there is no radical difference between higher-order thought and first-order representations, thus meaning that the former is inherent in the latter.

The other aspect to examine is that, just like Bhartṛhari, the Pratyabhijñā claims that higher-order representations are language informed. It is worth considering the way in which Abhinavagupta defends the claim. The most important aspect seems to be that he regards language as an inner capacity of the mind. He does not even use the standard Sanskrit word for language, *śabda*, rather an action-noun form, *śabdana*, by which he aims at highlighting the verbal and hence dynamic character of the expression. This *śabdana*, he says, is not based on conventions like public language but is rather the basis of it. Again, the same question arises. Are we talking about an LoT? The question is legitimate but hard to answer. In any case, what is really similar to Bhartṛhari's conception is

the reason the Śaiva thinkers give to justify the notion that there is no *vimarśa* without language. The point is again that without language, there is no way to coordinate cognitions and therefore no way to carry out a successful and logically tenable action. Abhinavagupta backs the idea with two arguments. The first concerns language acquisition. Without a cognitive synthesis, he claims, a child would never be able to put together the non-conceptual cognitions he experiences in a first moment.

To begin with, in this world, the essential characteristic of consciousness is the association with language, in a way that is comparable to the indication of something with a finger etc. If it were not so, a child would not learn a linguistic usage when he sees a human exchange for the first time. In fact, a child first hears the word in the form of a series of non-conceptual cognitions, then he sees the external referent of the word before his eyes, and thereafter a surface in which the external referent is no longer present. On hearing linguistic expressions such as “bring the pot” or “carry the pot”, how can the idea “this is the meaning of that”, namely this is the meaning of the word “pot”, this is the meaning of the word “bring” and of the word “carry” appear in the heart of the child? The answer is that to say “this object is the meaning of that word” is essentially an act of unification, and unification is a conceptual activity.¹⁹

The second argument concerns the notion that conceptuality and language are present also in immediate perceptions, thus meaning that first-order cognitions and higher-order representations occur together. Consider the following passage from *ĪPV* 1.5.19:

Even admitting that an immediate cognition is by nature momentary, in that too there is reflexive awareness. This is necessary. How could it be otherwise? In fact, if it were not so [i.e. if there was no reflexive awareness in the case of immediate cognitions], then a person proceeding rapidly with a specific purpose, or reciting letters quickly, or reading fast a book of mantras, would not reach, pronounce or recite what she has in mind. To explain: how can a person reach the place she has in mind without a reflexive awareness, whose essential aspect are unification and separation, and consists of the knowledge of the place, the will to proceed, the actual proceeding, the awareness of the movement, the unification of another purpose, the desire to leave, the knowledge of a different place, the desire to proceed towards it and so forth? The same applies to reading quickly, speaking etc. where, specifically, there is a union between places and organs of articulation etc. Since here one does not experience a gross conceptual cognition as following the immediate one, there is quickness. Therefore, there must be a subtle reflexive-awareness consisting of verbal potentiality in a contracted form, because one gets a gross conceptual cognition when a verbal potentiality becomes manifest by expansion.²⁰

If we combine the information we have gathered so far, the influence of Bhartṛhari's conceptual scheme on Utpaladeva is evident and hard to overstate:

- 1 For the Pratyabhijñā, mental states or cognitions (*prakāśa*) are conscious insofar as they are the content of higher-order representations (*vimarśa/pratyavamarśa/parāmarśa*). As in Bhartṛhari's view, these mental representations are presumably produced at the same time of cognitions. This is why Abhinavagupta is able to say that consciousness consists in an act of "reflexive awareness characterized by self-savouring" and that "is not at all established that reflexive awareness is one thing and non-reflexive awareness is another".
- 2 Higher-order representations have a linguistic nature. This is why Abhinavagupta says: "Reflexive awareness's essential nature is 'languageing', consisting in inner speech. This 'languageing' is independent from any linguistic convention and is an uninterrupted spontaneous savouring. It is like an internal nodding of the head; it is the life of the conventional sounds existing at the Māyā level, such as 'a' etc., because it is the internal support of reflexive awareness such as 'this is blue' or 'I am Caitra' and so on. Since speech denotes, conveys, all things through reflexive awareness, consciousness is said to be the 'word'".
- 3 Action entails a conceptualization, a coordination of cognitions, a mental function the Śaivas call *anusamdhāna* (or *pratisamdhāna*), which is by the way the very same word Bhartṛhari uses in the *Vṛtti* on 1.132.²¹ Thus, Abhinavagupta affirms that "if it were not so [i.e. if there was no reflexive awareness in the case of immediate cognitions], then a person proceeding rapidly with a specific purpose, or reciting letters quickly, or reading fast a book of mantras, would not reach, pronounce or recite what she has in mind. To explain: how can a person reach the place she has in mind without a reflexive awareness, whose essential aspect are unification and separation, and consists of the knowledge of the place, the will to proceed, the actual proceeding, the awareness of the movement, the unification of another purpose, the desire to leave, the knowledge of a different place, the desire to proceed towards it, and so forth?"

I think all this is sufficient to show how deep was the impact on Pratyabhijñā's philosophy of the doctrines elaborated by Bhartṛhari. One can even go as far as to ask what the Śaiva thinkers added to Bhartṛhari's picture. Leaving aside their theological consideration, I think they supplemented this basic scheme with two main contributions: the first and by far most important is the stress on the apparently mysterious notion that *vimarśa*, that is, higher-order representations, have a savouring. The Śaivas are referring with it to the fact that conscious experience has a subjective, phenomenal, 'what it is like to be' dimension—a 'savouring' in their words—which is difficult to account for in terms of mental representations and which can be addressed only metaphorically, an aspect that in Bhartṛhari does not seem to emerge. The second point is the Śaivas' tendency to espouse a much more radical version of non-dualism, developing the ideas that cognitions always

entail an awareness of the knowing subject and that external objects have the same nature as mind or consciousness. We analyze all these questions thoroughly in the following chapters.

Notes

- 1 *nāhantādiaparāmarśabhedād asyānyatātmanah / ahaṁmrśyataivāsyā srṣṭes tiṁvāc-yakarmavat // (ĪPK 1.5.17)*. “From the existence of notions of ‘I’ etc., one should not imply a differentiation in the nature of self, because this is produced in so far as it is the content of the reflexive awareness ‘I’. Exactly in the same way, a verbal action is expressed by personal endings”. With the last remark, Utpaladeva points out that just like the notion of ‘I’ is the concrete manifestation of pure subjectivity; similarly, in a linguistic utterance, the action expressed by the verb is manifested by the use of personal endings. In the ĪPV, in the same verse, Abhinavagupta comments: *aham ityevaṁsvarūpo yaḥ parāmarśo yaś ca īśvaraḥ pramātā ātmā śiva ityādiḥ anantaprakāraḥ parāmarśaḥ, tasya yady api bhedo ’nyonyarūpatā, tathāpi tadbhedāt hetoḥ asyātmano nirmātrūpasya ahaṁparāmarśamayasya nirmeyarūpasya ca īśvarādiaparāmarśāspadasya yo bhedah saṅkitaḥ sa na yuktaḥ. yata īśvara ityapi yaḥ parāmarśaḥ, sa īśanaśīle jñātrtvakartṛtvatattve viśrāmyati, jñātrtvādi ca jñānādaḥ svātantryam ananyamukhaprekṣitvam avicchinnajñānayogaḥ avicchedaś ca jñāmi karomi iti asmadarthaviśrāntiḥ iti asya īśvarasya ātmanah srṣṭeḥ srjyamānasya ahaṁvimarśanīyatvam eva*. “The reflexive awareness which consists in the ‘I’ assumes the forms of ‘knower’, ‘self’, ‘Śiva and so forth. Although this appears as having a mutual differentiation, it is nonetheless wrong to suppose that on the basis of that differentiation there is a difference between the self, which is the cause, the creator, and whose nature consists in subjective reflexive awareness, and the notions of Īśvara etc. For even the notion of Īśvara reposes on that which has the nature of the Lord, and whose essence is knowing and doing. Being a knower etc. means freedom, independence from others, capacity of unrestricted knowledge; this unrestrictedness reposes on the awareness of ‘I’, as ‘I know’ and ‘I do’. Hence this self is produced, emitted as the content of subjective reflexive awareness”.
- 2 See Dignāga’s PS 1.7: *bhrāntisaṁvṛtisajjñānam anumānānumānikam / smārtā-bhilāṣikaṁ ceti pratyakṣābhaṁ sataimiram*. “Erroneous cognition, cognition of empirical reality, inference, its result, recollection, and desire are not true perceptions and are accompanied by obscurity (*sataimira*)”. The verse is commented as follows in the *Vṛtti*: *smārtābhilāṣikaṁ ceti pratyakṣābhaṁ sataimiram | tatra bhrāntijñānam mṛgaṭrṣṇādiṣu toyādikalpanāpravṛttatvāt pratyakṣābhāsam saṁvṛtisatsu arthāntarādhyāropāt tadrūpakalpanāpravṛttatvāt. anumānatatphalādiññānam pūrvānubhūtakalpanayeti na pratyakṣam*. “Erroneous cognition (*bhrānti—jnānā*) is not a true perception because it arises conceptually constructing, for example, water, etc., out of such things as vapor floating over sand. Cognition of empirical reality (*saṁvṛti—saj—jñāna*) is not a true perception because it superimposes something extraneous upon things which are only empirically true (*saṁvṛti—sat*), and thus functions through the conceptualization of forms of these [extraneous things]. Inference and [the cognition which is] its result, etc., are not perceptions because they arise through the conceptualization of what formerly has been perceived”. As translated by Hattori (1968, p. 28).
- 3 Mīmāṃsā’s opinion is that there is an aspect of the cognition which is purely perceptual, and it is perceived as being such; old Nyāya, on the other hand, claims that the perceptual, immediate aspect of the cognition is never perceived. It is rather inferred from the fact that to cognize a determinate cognition, we must beforehand perceive its bare elements.
- 4 *na so ’sti pratyayo loke yaḥ śabdānugamād rte / anuviddham iva jñānam sarvaṁ śabdena bhāśate // (VP 1.131)*.

- 5 The verb *anugam* literally means ‘to follow, to go after’, but it also expresses the notion of ‘penetration’. See the entry *anugama* in Böthlingk and Roth (1855, p. 201). *anuviddhā* is glossed as *vyāptā* by Bhāskara in his commentary on Abhinavagupta’s *ĪPV*. See *ĪPV*, vol. 2, p. 297.
- 6 Indian philosophers have also often debated whether a cognition is inherently true or if one needs another cognition to prove the veridicality of the first one. The two positions, normally indicated with the Sanskrit terms *svataḥprāmānya* and *parataḥprāmānya*, are respectively associated to Mīmāṃsā and Nyāya. See Taber (1992).
- 7 However, different positions have recently emerged also in Western epistemology. The most notable is that of Timothy Williamson (2000), who suggests that knowledge is a mental state; not to mention the problem posed to the traditional stance by the so-called Gettier cases, in which one has justified true beliefs without having correct knowledge.
- 8 ‘Mental state’ and ‘mental representation’ are strictly related terms. Representational theories of mind define mental states as relations to mental representations. This means that the intentionality of the mental state is explained in terms of the semantic properties of mental representations. Consider for example the mental state (more specifically, a belief) ‘Elvis is dead’. This mental state is appropriately related to a mental representation whose propositional content is ‘Elvis is dead’. See Pitt (2000).
- 9 *Vṛtti* on VP 1.159: *paraiḥ saṃvedyaṃ yasyāḥ śrotraviśayatvena pratiniyataṃ śrutirūpaṃ sā vaikhari. śliṣṭā vyaktavarṇasamuccāraṇā prasiddhasādhubhāvā bhraṣṭasamskārā ca. tathā yā ‘kṣe yā dundubhau yā venau yā viṇāyām ity aparimāṇabhedā. madhyamā tv antaḥsaṃniveśinī parigrhītakrameva buddhimātropādānā. sā tu sūksmaprāṇavṛtṭyanugatā kramasaṃhārabhāve ‘pi vyaktaprāṇaparigrahaiva keśāñcit. pratisaṃhṛtakramā saty apy abhede samāviṣṭakramaśaktiḥ paśyanī. sā calācalā pratilabdhasamādhānā cāvṛtā ca viśuddhā ca, sanniviṣṭajñeyākārā pratilīnākārā nirākārā ca, paricchinnārthapratyavabhāśa saṃsrṣṭārthapratyavabhāśa praśāntasarvārthapratyavabhāśa cety aparimāṇabhedā.*
- 10 See in particular Dharmakīrti’s *Pramāṇavārttika* 2.1–6.
- 11 Bhartṛhari basically discusses three means of knowledge—perception (*pratyakṣa*), inference (*anumāna*), and verbal testimony (*śabda*)—but he also believes that the common systematization of the process of knowledge in terms of *pramāṇas* is only conventional. If knowledge is always imbued with language, splitting it into perception, inference, verbal testimony, and so on may be practically convenient but ultimately misleading. In this regard, it is interesting to note that Abhinavagupta in the TĀ assumes a similar stance: *prakāśo nāma yaś cāyam sarvatraiva prakāśate / anapahnnavaniyāt kiṃ tasmin mānakalpanaiḥ* // (TĀ 1.54).
apahnnavau sādhanē vā vastūnām ādyaṃ īdṛśam / yat tatra ke pramāṇānām upapattyupayogite // (TĀ 1.57).
 “This light in question shines everywhere, and being impossible to deny it, what is the use of means of knowledge? Both in negating and establishing things, since there is always that original [reality], what are the reason and the use of means of knowledge?” See Aklujkar (1989a, 1989b, 2000, 2002); Akamatsu (1999); Todeschini (2010); Ferrante (2017a).
- 12 *Vṛtti* on 1.131: *yathāsyā saṃhṛtarūpā śabdabhāvanā tathā jñeyesv arthesūtpannenāpy avikalpena jñānena kāryaṃ na kriyate.*
- 13 *iti kartavyatā loke sarvā śabdavyapāśrayā / yām pūrvāhitasaṃskāro bālo ‘pi pratipadyate* // (VP 1.129).
- 14 *arthakriyāsu vāk sarvān samīhayati dehinaḥ / tadutkrāntau viśaṃjño ‘yaṃ drśyate kāṣṭhakudyavat* // (VpVṛ on 1.135).
- 15 *vāgrūpatāyāṃ cāsatyām utpanno ‘pi prakāśaḥ pararūpam anagīkurvan prakāśana-kriyāsādhana-rūpatāyāṃ na vyavatiṣṭhate. bhinnarūpāṇām cānupakārinām ātmātārānātmanām itaretarasya vastumātrājñāne pratyavabhāsamāne yad uttarakālam anu-saṃdhānam pratyavamarśa ekārthakāritvam avibhāgena śaktisaṃsargayogopagrahah tad vāgrūpatāyāṃ baddham* (VpVṛ on 1.132).

- 16 *tadyathā tvaritaṃ gacchataḥ tṛṇaloṣṭādisamsparśāt saty api jñāne*. . . . “For instance, even if somebody walking fast has knowledge from the contact with grass and lumps of earth. . . .” (VpVṛ on 1.131).
- 17 VP 1.131 is partially quoted by Somānanda in ŚD 2.9 and by Abhinavagupta in both the ĪPV (Vol. 2, p. 265) and the ĪPVV (Vol. 2, p. 206). VP 1.132 is quoted by Utpaladeva in his commentary on ŚD 2.2 and by Abhinavagupta in both the ĪPV (Vol. 2, p. 265) and the ĪPVV (Vol. 2, p. 206). VP 1.134 is quoted by Abhinavagupta in both the ĪPV (Vol. 2, p. 265) and the ĪPVV (Vol. 3, p. 380). VP 1.135 is quoted by Abhinavagupta in the ĪPVV (Vol. 1, p. 100). VP 1.159, which states the tripartition of language, is not quoted *verbatim*, but the levels of speech are frequently mentioned and debated by all three main thinkers of the Pratyabhijñā.
- 18 *cetayati ity atra yā citiḥ citikriyā tasyāḥ pratyavamarśaḥ svātmacamatkāralakṣaṇa ātmā svabhāvaḥ. tathā hi ghaṭena svātmani na camatkriyate, svātmā na parāmrśyate, nā svātmani tena prakāśyate, na aparicchinntatayā bhāsyate, tato na cetyata iti ucyate. caitreṇa tu svātmani aham iti saṃrambhodyogollāsavibhūtiyogāt camatkriyate, svātmā parāmrśyate, svātmany eva prakāśyate, idam iti yaḥ pariccheda etāvadrūpatayā tadvilakṣaṇābhāvena nīlapītasukhādūḥkhatacchūnyatādyasamkhyābābhāsayogena avabhāsyate, tataḥ caitreṇa cetyata iti ucyate. evaṃ ca vimarśaḥ svātmani avimarśo ‘pi svātmani ity asiddham etat. vimarśo hi sarvaṃśahaḥ param api ātmīkaroti, ātmanaṃ ca parīkaroti, ubhayam ekīkaroti, ekīkṛtaṃ dvayam api nyagbhāvyayati ity evaṃsvabhāvaḥ. pratyavamarśaḥ ca āntarābhilāpātmaśābdana svabhāvaḥ, tac ca śabdanaṃ saṃketanirapekṣam eva avicchinnacamatkāratmakam antarmukhaśironirdeśaprakhyam akārādimāyīyasamketikaśābdajīvitabhūtam. nīlam idam caitro ‘haṃ ityādi pratyavamarśāntarabhittibhūtatvāt, pūrṇatvāt parā, vakti viśvam abhilapati pratyavamarśena iti ca vāk, ata eva sā svarasena cidrūpatayā svātmaviśrāntivapuṣā uditā sadānastamitā nityā aham ity eva. etad eva paramātmāno mukhyaṃ svāntarya aiśvaryam īśīrtvam ananyāpekṣitam ucyate (ĪPV on 1.5.13).*
- 19 *iha tāvat caitanasya ātmabhūto ‘ṅgulinirdeśādiprakhyo ‘bhilāpayogaḥ, anyathā bālasya prathamam vyavahāre drśyamāne vyutpattir eva na syāt. nirvikalpakajñānaparamparayā hi taṃ śabdaṃ śṛṇoti, tataḥ taṃ arthaṃ puraḥ paśyati, punas tadviviktaṃ bhūtaṃ paśyati iti ghaṭam ānaya naya iti vyavahārāt katham asya ayam artha iti hr̥di parisphureta, idam ghaṭa iti, idam ānaya iti, idam naya iti, itiyojanāprāṇo hi ayam arthaḥ yojanā ca vikalpavyāpārāḥ (ĪPV 1.5.19).*
- 20 *bhavadu vā kṣaṇamātrasvabhāva sāṅśātkāraḥ, tatrāpi asti vimarśaḥ. avaśyam caitat. katham anyathā iti. yadi sa na syāt tat ekābhisamdhānena javāt gacchan, tvaritaṃ varṇān paṭhan, drutaṃ ca mantrapustakaṃ vācayan, na abhimatam eva gacchet, uccārayet vā, vācayet vā. tathā hi tasmin deśe jñānam—ācikramiṣā—ākramaṇam—ākṛāntatājñānam—prayojanāntarānusamdhānam—tityakṣā—deśāntarānusamdhīḥ, tatrāpi ācikramiṣā ity ādinā yojanāviyojanarūpeṇa pratyavamarśena vinābhimatadeśāvāptiḥ katham bhavet. evaṃ tvaritodgrahāṇavācānādaḥ mantavyam. tatra viśeṣataḥ sthānakaraṇākramaṇādiyogaḥ. atra ca yataḥ paścāt bhāviṣṭhūlavikalpakaḥ na saṃvedyate, tata eva tvaritatvaṃ iti sūkṣmeṇa pratyavamarśena saṃvartitaśābdabhāvanāmayena bhāvyam eva. saṃvartitā hi śābdabhāvanā prasāraṇena vivartyamānā sthūlo vikalpaḥ (ĪPV 1.5.19).*
- 21 See ĪPK 1.3.6 and ĪPKVṛ on 1.5.19.

6 Subjectivity and first-person stance

We have seen so far that the Pratyabhijñā authors conceive consciousness in higher-order terms. In their view, ‘to be conscious’ comes down to being able to have a reflexive awareness of the first-order cognitions acquired through the senses. The Śaivas also contend that this reflexive awareness must necessarily depend on language, for without a syntactical arrangement—a synthesis—of mental states, it would be impossible to entertain reflexive thought and to perform any successful activity. We have also emphasized that this theory is so heavily indebted to Bhartṛhari’s conceptions that one may even question whether the Śaiva authors added something original to the picture. In this chapter, we are going to positively answer this question. The Pratyabhijñā intellectuals not only added something new, but they also indeed added something important, for they maintained that consciousness has a component that differs from the representational activity of higher-order thought. Different from Bhartṛhari, who does not seem to be aware of this fact,¹ Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta were explicitly saying that consciousness has a purely private, phenomenal dimension. This dimension is only first-person knowable, as only the owner of the experience is capable of accessing it. Utpaladeva’s awareness of this aspect is no doubt striking, and it shows how advanced the Śaivas’ conceptions were. In Euro-American philosophy, the focus on the phenomenal side of consciousness is a rather recent development, with some philosophers even arguing that this is the fundamental component of consciousness and the hardest to account for (Chalmers, 1996). I think it is therefore useful, before returning to Pratyabhijñā’s discussion, to have a look at how contemporary philosophers of mind have framed the question of the subjective dimension of consciousness.

Qualia: the subjective dimension of experience

Although the discussions on the nature of mind are traceable to ancient Greek philosophers, the modern reflection on the issue largely stems from the work of Descartes, in particular from his analysis of the relationship that exists between mind and body. The problem Descartes was facing is indeed simple to state: since we are all aware that mind has an effect on the body and the body affects the mind, how do we explain their relationship? How does this interaction work?

Unfortunately, the answer is not at all simple, and after centuries, the question remains challenging. Descartes held the view that mind (*res cogitans*) and body (*res extensa*) are two radically different types of substance—a position today categorized as substance dualism—but he notoriously failed to explain the crucial point, that is, how the two substances interact. The question fell out of fashion for some time but resurged in the past decades with an altogether different outlook. Almost all contemporary mind theorists believe that Descartes is wrong. Most are in fact reductionist and monist, thus claiming that there is just one substance in the universe—matter (which would correspond to Descartes's *res extensa*)—and that mental activity is eventually to be explained in terms of it. This position takes various shapes. The most extreme view is that of 'physicalism', according to which all that exists, from rocks and chairs to animals and minds, is eventually reducible to the basic categories of modern physics. The motto of physicalism is that mental states *are* states of the brain, which are in turn explained physiologically, that is, as the firings of neurons caused by molecular and atomic activity. A milder view is that of 'naturalism', which heavily relies on the idea of 'supervenience', a concept we have briefly touched upon in Chapter 5. Something supervenes on something else if there cannot be a difference in a micro state without having a difference in the macro one. Accordingly, naturalism maintains that mental states supervene on purely physical states and that the former must be described as modifications of the latter. The motto of naturalism is that mental states *depend* on brain states. Both versions of materialism are evidently influenced by the successful paradigm of modern science. Materialists of all sorts believe that even if we are unable to lay out the details of how a mental state relates to the physical world, it is just a matter of time. Sooner or later (neuro-)science will be able to provide us with a clear picture of all features of mind, including consciousness. The current most successful versions of materialism are essentially two: functionalism and computationalism. In the first case, the mind is not analyzed in terms of what it *is* but in terms of what it *does*. In this view, a mental state, say *x*, is defined functionally and is determined by three related factors: (1) the cause of *x*, (2) the effect of *x* on other mental states, and (3) the effects *x* has on behaviour. This functionalist approach has expectedly evolved towards a computational theory of mind. In this view, probably at the moment the most popular explanation of consciousness, the mind is compared to a Turing machine. Roughly speaking, a Turing machine is a computational device that transforms inputs into outputs on the basis of an algorithm. Accordingly, the mind is seen as encoding its inputs (the sensory data) into a system of representations (usually instances of some kind of LoT), which interprets them according to a systematic set of rules, to produce the expected outputs (behaviours).

Despite its popularity among contemporary theorists, the materialist stance has been questioned on the basis of several arguments. If in the contemporary debate Cartesian, substantial dualism is hardly defended, there are several philosophers who keep believing that mind and matter have actually different qualities. The idea here, often labelled 'property dualism', is that there is only one substance in the universe, which can however assume physical or mental properties. Also

in this conception, the notion of supervenience plays a critical role, since mental properties are supposed to supervene on physical ones. But unlike naturalists, property dualists believe that the mental is ontologically different from the physical and irreducible to it. Non-reductionist philosophers have come up with a series of arguments to question the standard materialist view.² Most of them point out that conscious experience has a subjective, first-person aspect that cannot be reduced to physical matter or, differently put, cannot be naturalized. In their opinion, there is an explanatory gap between what is going on in the brain, at the neural level, and what we experience in our phenomenal consciousness. They indicate the phenomenal aspects of experience with the term *qualia* (singular *quale*), a name which is meant to convey the kind of subjective experience one possesses in a given mental state. Using an expression made famous by Thomas Nagel (1974), there is “something that is like to be” in a certain mental state. According to non-reductionist philosophers, this ‘what-it-is likeness’ cannot be fully described by a materialist, third-person stance and requires an altogether different approach.

The Pratyabhijñā’s *qualia*: *camatkāra*

My point is that the Pratyabhijñā authors had a concept that is strikingly similar to that of *qualia*. They express the idea that consciousness has a private, phenomenal dimension using a very peculiar expression, *camatkāra*, we have already encountered in the previous chapter. The word has traditionally been interpreted as connected to the onomatopoeic Sanskrit interjection *camat*, which expresses a sense of surprise. Therefore, the primary meanings of *camatkāra* are ‘astonishment’ and ‘wonder’. As V. Raghavan has influentially put it: “Originally the word *camatkāra* was an onomatopoeic word referring to the clicking sound we make with our tongue when we taste something snappy, and in the course of its semantic enlargements, *camatkāra* came to mean a sudden fillip relating to any feeling of a pleasurable time” (Raghavan, 1942, p. 269). Still, the expression became central to the aesthetic theories that developed in India throughout the first millennium CE and in particular to those refined in Kashmir during Pratyabhijñā’s high time (Shulman, 2010). Abhinavagupta himself was a towering figure in aesthetics, giving seminal contributions to the field. Given this context, it is hardly surprising that many contemporary interpreters have sought to explain the *camatkāra* appearing in the Pratyabhijñā works in the light of the meaning the term has in the works of literary theorists. In this latter case, ‘wonder’ generally refers to a state of sheer bliss one undergoes during aesthetic experiences, typically a theatrical performance. This state is clearly regarded as a transcendent condition, plunging the subject of experience in a reality that is radically different from the ordinary. Given this background, I argue that although the two interpretations might be connected (in a way that we are going to see later), in the Pratyabhijñā works, *camatkāra* is first of all a philosophical notion, which is used to indicate the purely phenomenal aspect of consciousness. Utpaladeva was the first to use this concept technically. Abhinavagupta inherited the notion and perhaps adapted it to fit into the context of his aesthetic doctrines. To show this, it is worth having

a quick look at the most important occurrences of the term in the Pratyabhijñā's literature.

The first instance of *camatkāra* to take into consideration occurs in Utpaladeva's commentary on the ŚD. In ŚD 1.7cd-8, Somānanda discusses metaphysical matters. Specifically, he tries to get out of the predicament of non-dualism: how can a unitary consciousness, which in this passage is identified with Śiva, produce the multiplicity of things and events we are used to encounter in common experience? With regard to this, Somānanda affirms that the tension the unitary consciousness has towards the production of multiplicity coincides with its will, in particular with the very first moment of will.³ This tension, the author goes on, is caused by the unfolding of a sense of joy, which is a power that characterizes consciousness and Śiva himself. This already prompts something to reflect upon, for if to convey the notion of 'joy' Somānanda uses the word *āmoda*, Utpaladeva glosses it with *camatkāra*. Still more interesting is a subsequent remark of the commentary, in which Utpaladeva defines *camatkāra* as that which "consists in the reflexive awareness of its own nature as it is".⁴ Utpaladeva is already introducing here the idea that reflexive awareness (*vimarśa*, *parāmarśa*), that is, the representational capacity of high-order thought, is related to the notion of *camatkāra*: if one removes from the concept of *vimarśa* its representational or intentional side, what remains is a purely phenomenal and subjective aspect that corresponds to mental state's "own nature as it is".

In the ĪPK, *camatkāra/camatkṛti* is not attested, but it appears three times in the ĪPVr. The most informative instance occurs in the commentary on ĪPK 1.5.11.⁵ Utpaladeva is putting forward here one of his most crucial tenets, namely that one's reflexive awareness is the essential property of knowledge and that which makes knowledge what it is. Without it, he goes on, a cognition, even if capable of being coloured by its content, would be actually inert, just like a crystal or a mirror. The reason Utpaladeva gives to explain the difference between an inert object and a conscious one is precisely that the latter possesses *camatkāra/camatkṛti*. Without reflexive awareness, he says, a cognition would be transparent—thus able to be affected by the object—but not at all conscious. To be conscious, a cognition must possess savouring, that is to say, *camatkāra*.

In his works, Abhinavagupta also offers insightful remarks on *camatkāra*. The first, and possibly the oldest, is to be found in a non-Pratyabhijñā context, in the *Abhinavabharati* (ABh), Abhinavagupta's commentary on classical India's seminal text on performing arts, the *Nāṭyaśāstra*. In it Abhinavagupta says that "*camatkāra* is the mental activity of the subject of enjoyment who is immersed in the vibration of a marvellous enjoyment". It is worth noting that Raniero Gnoli favoured a different reading of the passage, leading to a rather diverging interpretation. For him, the expression *ca manahkaraṇam* is to be emended to *camataḥ karaṇa*. Consequently, the translation becomes: "The word *camatkāra*, indeed, properly means the action being done by a tasting subject (*camataḥ karaṇam*), in other words, by the enjoying subject who is immersed in the vibration of a marvellous enjoyment".⁶ In both versions of the text, the emphasis on the pure enjoyment of experience—on experience *per se*—is evident. Still, Gnoli's reconstruction,

though disputed,⁷ moves more explicitly towards this connotation because it takes away from *camatkāra* the problematic connotation of ‘wonder’ and shows that the term is actually used to convey the purely phenomenal aspect of any experience. The ĪPVV contains other definitions of *camatkāra* to take into account. In a passage, Abhinavagupta affirms that “*camatkṛti* is the action of a person savouring, that is, the bliss consisting in the full achievement of fruition”.⁸ In a previous section of the work, the author delves into a more philosophical explanation of the concept, again connecting the notion to consciousness and subjectivity. He says: “Because they share the same nature, *camatkāra* is the reflexive awareness that we call the ‘I’, in its accomplished state when [contents such as] blue and so on are contracted. It is the supreme fruition consisting in bliss”.⁹ Again, it is worth stressing how Abhinavagupta relates the concept to the notion of fruition, that is, to experience as it is, in its purely phenomenal aspect.

Coming to the ĪPV, the most important section in which *camatkāra* is discussed is the one we have analyzed at length in Chapter 5, which is worth reconsidering here, too:

The word *citi*, derived from *cetayati*, “to make conscious”, indicates the activity of consciousness, whose essential nature, its essence, is a reflexive awareness characterized by self-savouring. To explain: a pot does not have savouring with respect to itself; it does not have a reflective awareness as a self, it does not cognize with respect to itself, nor it shines as having an uninterrupted nature. This is why it is said to be unconscious. On the other hand, a person named Caitra has savouring with respect to himself, for he has the power to produce an effort towards a raised state, that is the “I”; he has reflexive awareness as a self and cognizes precisely with respect to himself.¹⁰

Abhinavagupta states here that *camatkāra* is the essential feature of reflexive awareness; it is that which characterizes conscious beings, hence lacking in what is inert. A few lines on, he gives a further connotation to the concept by connecting it to the idea that language is necessary to consciousness:

Furthermore, reflexive awareness’s essential nature is “languageing”, consisting in inner speech. This “languageing” is independent from any linguistic convention and is an uninterrupted spontaneous savouring. It is like an internal nodding of the head; it is the life of the conventional sounds existing at the Māyā level, such as “a” etc., because it is the internal support of a reflexive awareness such as “this is blue” or “I am Caitra” and so on. Since speech denotes, conveys, all things through reflexive awareness, consciousness is said to be the “word”.¹¹

By judging from these two last passages, the Pratyabhijñā authors seem to hold a quite interesting view: the very fact that one possesses a higher-order thought, which is inherently linguistic, is the cause of the phenomenal dimension of consciousness. The point is to understand whether this affirmation is philosophically

tenable, since it seems to suggest that is possible to combine a higher-order theory of consciousness with the belief that consciousness has also a subjective dimension.

Higher-order thought and *qualia*

We have so far established that the Pratyabhijñā thinkers conceive consciousness in terms of high-order thought, but at the same time—and in this they differ from Bhartṛhari—they point out that consciousness has also a subjective, phenomenal side, indicated with the term ‘savouring’, *camatkāra*. If this makes their analysis refined and compelling, it nonetheless raises a further problem, for it remains to be explained how the belief in *qualia* (*camatkāra*) can coexist with a higher-order theory of consciousness (*vimarśa*). To argue for their coexistence is in fact no easy task, and in contemporary philosophy of mind, the two notions are often seen as mutually exclusive explanations of consciousness. To have a plausible answer, let us reflect on the relationship that exists between the four elements in which the Pratyabhijñā classifies human cognitive activity: first-order cognitions (*prakāśa*), higher-order metacognitions (*vimarśa*), *qualia* (*camatkāra*), and personhood (*ātma*). If we return to a passage we have already quoted, we can sense that Abhinavagupta is putting forward a sort of hierarchy of these components when he says:

A pot does not have savouring with respect to itself; it does not have a reflective awareness as a self, it does not cognize with respect to itself, nor it shines as having an uninterrupted nature. This is why it is said to be unconscious.¹²

If we start reading the sequence from the last element, the author is saying that a person (somebody whose nature is uninterrupted, meaning somebody whose existence is temporally continuous, a self, *ātma*) is an individual who is aware of one’s own surroundings, hence she has first-order cognitions (*prakāśa*) of the external reality. These cognitions are conscious because they are the content of higher-order representations (reflexive awareness, *vimarśa*) and because they have a first-person subjective feeling (savouring, *camatkāra*). If the passage from external contents to *prakāśa* and *vimarśa* is accounted for resorting to a higher-order theory, how to reconcile the *vimarśa* and *camatkāra* aspects of consciousness? We have indeed considered passages in which the two notions are explicitly connected. In the commentary on the ŚD, Utpaladeva states that *camatkāra* “consists in the reflexive awareness of its own nature as it is”. In another excerpt we have quoted, Abhinavagupta adds that *camatkāra* and *vimarśa* have the same nature. Although these short affirmations are far from being a comprehensive examination of the problem, they are more informative than they might appear at first sight. I think that Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta are in fact suggesting a specific solution of the question at stake, insofar as they are clearly affirming that the subjective, *qualia* dimension of consciousness is inherent in the representational one. Using the Pratyabhijñā’s jargon, their conclusion is that whenever

there is *vimarśa*, there is also *camatkāra*. But what do they really mean? Again, it may turn out useful to look whether contemporary philosophers have argued for similar positions.

As recognized by one of its most prominent supporters (Gennaro, 2005), a higher-order theory of consciousness (HOT) can be attacked from two sides. In the first place, it can be argued that if a mental state became conscious in force of a metacognition directed at it, then one would grant consciousness to a lot of things. As Alvin Goldman objected, if HOT was correct, even a rock would become conscious, the only requirement being having a belief about it (Goldman, 1993). Therefore, from this point of view, a HOT is too broad. But in the second place, a HOT must also explain the ‘hard problem’ of consciousness, the fact that experience has an intrinsic phenomenal dimension. If it is not able to do so, a HOT is actually too narrow, for it will not be capable to account for all possible aspects of consciousness. The first objection is chiefly met by noticing that a metacognition operates on mental states and not on external, non-psychological objects like rocks (Lycan, 1996, p. 24). The second objection, which is the one relevant to us, requires more argumentative effort. Rocco J. Gennaro has elaborated a particularly interesting reply to the objection, though some features of his argument are traceable to the work of David Rosenthal. The solution is based on the idea that even phenomenal, subjective consciousness requires the presence of concepts, that is, of thought (and language, we could add). Gennaro claims that phenomenal consciousness arises because the concepts we use are already presupposed in our conscious experience. He conceives the process in a quasi-Kantian way: we passively receive data through the senses, and then some of this information is raised to the level of unconscious mental states. But these mental states do not become conscious until they become the content of higher-order thought, that is, of concepts. Gennaro is thus arguing that concepts are deeply intertwined with the process of data acquisition, namely with the sensory stimuli. The crucial idea to support his case is that concepts affect the way in which we experience conscious states, even phenomenally. In this regard, highly suggestive is Rosenthal’s example of wine tasting: “Learning new concepts for our experiences of the gustatory and olfactory properties of wines typically leads to our being conscious of more fine-grained differences among the qualities of our sensory states. Similarly with other sensory modalities . . . new concepts appear to generate new conscious sensory qualities” (Rosenthal, 2002, p. 413). Another way Rosenthal puts it is that if we remove concepts from conscious experience, what we get in the end is no consciousness at all. We could summarize the position by saying that if there are no concepts, there is no consciousness. In Rosenthal’s words: “It is plausible that peeling away that weakest HOT would result, finally, in its no longer being like anything at all to have that sensation” (Rosenthal, 2002, p. 414). It is clear then that in both Gennaro’s and Rosenthal’s views, to be phenomenally conscious comes down to the faculty of having higher-order concepts. As for the question of *why*, we have a subjective experience in association with concepts—that is the hard problem of consciousness—Gennaro’s reply is that the question itself is inappropriate. In his view, a HOT is sufficient to explain how a mental state is

conscious. To ask for more implies the desire to go beyond the “rock bottom brute fact about the way conscious mind works”. In other words, Gennaro believes that “the chain of explanation has already come to an end” (Gennaro, 2005, p. 11).

Is all this relevant to the way in which the Pratyabhijñā thinks of the relationship between *vimarśa* and *camatkāra*? I believe so. Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta are clearly moving along the same line. They see the two notions in question as the two sides of the same coin and argue that the conceptual, linguistic nature of *vimarśa* is actually what gives to conscious experience that subjective, phenomenal character they call *camatkāra*. There remains one last point to address. Even if all this has made clear that the Śaivas elaborated a quite refined conception of consciousness, the main purpose of Utpaladeva’s work, the defence of the notion of self and personhood has not been achieved yet. The final question to examine is whether and how the notion of consciousness we have been considering so far can be used to justify the existence of an entity we are used to call self and which, by definition, must have certain characteristics.

Notes

- 1 Bhartṛhari does not seem to be aware of the idea that mental states always involve a phenomenal side, but his commentator Helārāja appears to hinting at the notion. In commenting on Bhartṛhari’s statement that a ‘cognition of an object’ is different from ‘the cognition of a cognition of an object’, Helārāja says: “A cognition is determined by another on the basis of a certain linguistic expression, such as ‘he had the cognition of a pot’, but this knowledge of another cognition is not manifested for others as it is for oneself, hence the [cognition of the cognition of a pot] is different from the cognition of a pot and does not determine it”. What does all this mean? Helārāja is here saying essentially two things: first, to know an object and to be conscious of knowing it are two different things. Second, to know an object (i.e. to have an experience of whatever kind) has a subjective feeling that is inevitably private and first-person knowable. See the appendix for a translation of the entire passage.
- 2 Non-reductionist philosophers have criticized the materialist model adopting various arguments. One is the so-called inverted spectrum argument. The idea is that is possible to imagine a world where the vocabulary two persons use to describe colours remains the same even if what one person actually sees is constantly different from what the other one sees. For instance, when the two persons looks at a banana, they both say it is yellow. But the *quale* associated with the sensation of one person is the one the second person instead associates with a tomato. If this is conceivable, then the way we are conscious is not totally explained by physical process. A second argument is that of the philosophical zombie. Since it is possible to conceive a person who is functionally similar to normal humans but who lacks the phenomenal dimension of consciousness (i.e. a zombie), then consciousness must be something over and above the physical states of brain. A third argument is the so-called knowledge argument, or ‘Mary’s room’ argument, first introduced by the philosopher Frank Jackson. The argument is about a brilliant neuroscientist, Mary, who is imagined to have lived secluded in a laboratory for her entire life. She knows all the theoretical details of colour perception, but she has never directly experienced what is like to see a red object. One day Mary leaves the laboratory and sees a red rose. The question is: does this experience add something new to Mary’s knowledge? If the answer is positive, as Jackson suggests, then to be conscious is again an experience that includes a phenomenal component, and it cannot be entirely reduced to the physical.

- 3 ŚD 1.7cd-8: *yadā tu tasyaciddharmavibhavāmodajṛmbhayā // vicitraracanānānākār yasr̥ṣṭipravartane / bhavaty unmukhitā cittā secchāyāḥ prathamā tuṭiḥ* // See Nemec (2011, p. 283).
- 4 *tathāsvārūpaparāmarāriṇa*. See Nemec (2011, p. 283).
- 5 *svabhāvam avabhāśasya vimarśam vidur anyathā / prakāśo 'rthoparakto 'pi sphatikādijadopamā* // (ĪPK 1.5.11). Utpaladeva also mentions *camatkāra/camatkṛiti* in ĪPVṛ 4.1 and 4.6.
- 6 *bhuñjānasyādbhūtabhogaspandāviṣṭasya ca manahkaraṇam camatkāra iti* (ABh I, p. 278). Gnoli's reading is as follows: *bhuñjānasyādbhūtabhogaspandāviṣṭasya ca camataḥ karaṇam camatkāra iti*. See Gnoli (1968, pp. 58–59).
- 7 The passage is discussed by Bansat-Boudon (2011, pp. 320–321).
- 8 *camatkṛtir hi bhuñjānasya yā kriyā bhogasamāpattimayānandāḥ* (ĪPVV II, p. 177).
- 9 *pūrṇa iti nīlādyasaṃkocito yo 'haṃbhāvākhyo vimarśas tatsvabhāve yaś camatkāra ānandātmā paramo bhogaḥ, tasya yā āpattiḥ prāptiḥ* (ĪPVV I, p. 85).
- 10 *cetayati ity atra yā citiḥ citikriyā tasyāḥ pratyavamarśaḥ svātmacamatkāralakṣaṇa ātmā svabhāvaḥ. tathā hi ghaṭena svātmani na camatkriyate, svātmā na parāmr̥syate, nā svātmani tena prakāśyate, na aparicchinnatayā bhāsyate, tato na cetyata iti ucyate. caitreṇa tu svātmani aham iti saṃrambhodyogollāsavibhūtiyogāt camatkriyate, svātmā parāmr̥syate, svātmāny eva prakāśyate.*
- 11 *pratyavamarśaś ca āntarābhilāpātmakaśabdanasvabhāvaḥ, tac ca śabdānam saṃketanirapekṣam eva avicchinnacamatkāratmakam antarmukhaśironirdeśaprakhyam akārādīmāyīyasāṃketikaśabdajīvitabhūtam. nīlam idaṃ caitro 'haṃ ityādipratyavam arśāntarabhittibhūtatvāt, pūrṇatvāt parā, vakti viśvam abhilapati pratyavamarśena iti ca vāk.*
- 12 ĪPK on 1.5.13.

7 Self

The previous discussion has led us to the conclusion that the Pratyabhijñā authors have a conception of consciousness that aims to combine a higher-order component with a phenomenal, first-person perspective. Once accepted that these two features characterize consciousness, it remains to specify what kind of relationship obtains between it and self. In other words, we need to examine the question of whether a theory of consciousness of the sort we have reconstructed so far is enough to justify the existence of an entity, the self, which has by definition specific qualities.¹ To better appraise the problem at stake, it is useful to recall an influential classification of consciousness introduced by David Rosenthal (1986). According to this model, a mental state can exist in three different conditions. It can be simply conscious, which is the condition Rosenthal calls *state consciousness*; it can be conscious of a content, that is, it can be in a condition called *transitive consciousness*; or, finally, a mental state can belong to persons that are in a conscious state, a situation named *creature consciousness*. This typology allows us to recast the debate we have been analyzing so far as follows: the Śaiva are accusing the Buddhists of conceiving self-consciousness only in a transitive way, that is, intentionally. For their part, they believe that the defining feature of consciousness is *state consciousness*. Nevertheless, if they want to defend the notion of a fully fledged self, they need to explain the relationship that exists between state or transitive consciousness and creature consciousness.

Does consciousness implies self-consciousness?

A first strategy to corroborate the Pratyabhijñā's thesis is to argue that state consciousness necessarily implies creature consciousness. In other words, one could claim that 'consciousness of an object *x*' always involve 'self-consciousness', in which 'self-consciousness' indicates here the awareness of oneself as the subject of experience. The idea is that consciousness and self-consciousness, though different, are positively correlated. Now, such an affirmation is quite contentious, at least for two reasons. First, it has a strong idealistic flavour,² and, second, it implies a conflation of consciousness and self-consciousness, which are concepts a good number of contemporary philosophers prefer to keep distinguished. Most would in fact argue that 'to be conscious of an event or a thing' does not imply 'to

be self-conscious of it'. The fact that I am aware of the book in front of me does not entail that I am automatically aware of having that awareness. Being aware of the awareness would require a further effort of the mind, which must be directed at itself. But normally, the argument goes on, cognitions do not work that way. I usually perceive the book in front of me without being conscious of having the perception. Therefore, consciousness and self-consciousness should be regarded as independent phenomena.³ Still, the Pratyabhijñā argues precisely for the opposite thesis. Utpaladeva claims that a state of awareness, a cognition, always implies self-awareness, as well as the notion of 'I'. He would say that when I am conscious of the book in front of me, I am also conscious of myself having the cognition, at least to some degree. At first glance, the position looks like indefensible. Yet a contemporary philosopher, Uriah Kriegel (2004), has supported a similar notion. It is therefore worth considering his arguments and evaluate whether they are helpful to understand what the Pratyabhijñā philosophers intended.

According to Kriegel, consciousness is an ambiguous concept, for it possesses both *intrinsic* and *relational* modes. The sentence 'Caitra is conscious' is an example of the intrinsic mode. In it there is an intrinsic property attributed to a person.⁴ Kriegel defines this condition *intransitive consciousness*. The sentence 'Caitra is conscious of a pot' is, on the contrary, an example of the relational mode. In it we detect a relational property whereby a subject takes something as an object. Such a condition is defined *transitive consciousness*. In addition, adopting Rosenthal's scheme, Kriegel distinguishes between consciousness belonging to individuals, *creature consciousness*, and consciousness belonging to mental states, *state consciousness*. He then combines these different aspects, thus arriving at the following fourfold classification of consciousness:

- 1 *intransitive creature consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra is conscious'
- 2 *transitive creature consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra is conscious of his new pot'
- 3 *transitive state consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra's thought is conscious of his new pot'
- 4 *intransitive state consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra's thought that his pot is new is conscious'

Kriegel's next move is to show that creature consciousness ultimately depends on state consciousness. The main reason he gives is that to be conscious, an individual must at least have one conscious mental state. If this is true, to possess mental states is a requirement for being conscious as individuals. The second step of the argumentation consists of proving that in the case of state consciousness, all transitive mental states depend on intransitive ones. As to this, Kriegel argues that to 'be conscious of' one must be 'conscious' beforehand. If that were not the case, we would get stuck in the irritating condition in which one can be conscious of something, say a chair, both consciously and unconsciously—an affirmation that sounds quite counterfactual. Therefore, a preliminary conclusion is that the first three kinds of consciousness all depend on the fourth one. That is to say, all types of consciousness entail *intransitive state consciousness*.

Kriegel then aims to demonstrate that intransitive state consciousness depends on some form of self-consciousness. If this is proved to be true, the conclusion will be that all kinds of consciousness depend on self-consciousness. First, Kriegel recognizes that the very same fourfold classification of consciousness applies to self-consciousness too. So we have:

- 5 *intransitive creature self-consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra is self-conscious'
- 6 *transitive creature self-consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra is self-conscious of his new pot'
- 7 *transitive state self-consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra's thought is self-conscious of his new pot'
- 8 *intransitive state self-consciousness*, e.g. 'Caitra's thought that his pot is new is self-conscious'

Now Kriegel's crucial claim is that affirmations 7 and 8 describe different states of affairs. In 7, the mental state of a given individual is conscious of possessing a certain awareness. Hence, self-consciousness here consists in being conscious of another consciousness. The latter is the content of the former, and this is why we talk about a mental state having a transitive property. By contrast, in affirmation 8, self-consciousness does not take consciousness as its content but modifies it in a self-conscious manner. Affirmation 8 can be recast in a more conspicuous way by saying that 'Caitra's thought self-consciously thinks to his new pot'.

In justifying the difference between the transitive and intransitive types of self-consciousness, Kriegel adopts the widely accepted distinction between *foveal* and *peripheral* attention. If we return to the case of consciousness, one is in transitive state consciousness when she is focally, or foveally, attending to her own mental states. By contrast, one is in intransitive state consciousness when she is attending something else and is only peripherally aware of the mental state she is in. Peripheral awareness is the condition in which we focus our sensory attention on one thing, yet we are not totally unaware of other phenomena. Think, for instance, to the case of reading a book. Our foveal attention is on the page, but at the same time we are also peripherally aware of other objects in our field of vision, like the glass on the table, the sounds coming from the streets, or the heating from the fire. The question is whether the distinction between foveal and peripheral awareness, which seems so evident in the case of sensory perceptions, is also valid for conceptual contents. Kriegel argues that it is so, by appealing to the example of a truck driver who, though focused on the road, has meanwhile myriad thoughts of which she is only peripherally aware. Then if the distinction between foveal and peripheral attention is legitimate for both sensory and mental experiences the point is whether we should make an exception for just one thing, that is, the cognition of self. Probably not. Hence, it is legitimate to differentiate between foveal or transitive self-consciousness and peripheral or intransitive one.

As anticipated, Kriegel's final aim is to show that all forms of consciousness depend on intransitive state self-consciousness. In this regard, he puts forward two arguments. The first is essentially negative. It is true, he argues, that when

we look at the sunrise, we are not necessarily conscious of ourselves looking but only of the content of our sensory awareness, the sunrise. Yet this affirmation is valid only if we restrict our notion of self-consciousness to the transitive type. In fact, if we conceive self-consciousness in intransitive terms, self-consciousness is always at work, acting as a modifier of all types of consciousness, that is, of all cognitions. The second argument Kriegel advances is based on the idea that a mental state must be first-person knowable in order to be conscious. Still, first-person experiences are always those we have self-consciously. Hence, conscious states, that is, the ones produced by cognitions, are intransitively self-conscious. Finally, we must also distinguish between *particular* mental states and *type* mental states. Particular mental states cannot be thought of without including their subject in the picture, since they always involve an awareness of ourselves as the subjects of those mental states. One could make the hypothesis that it is possible to make an abstraction by thinking in terms of *type* mental states. For instance, we can imagine the mental state another person has when she is watching the sunrise. Nevertheless, this is precisely an abstraction, and normally cognitions do not work this way. We can certainly make an effort and imagine what the mental state a person has when she is watching the sunrise, but we cannot ever know ‘what it is like to be’ watching the sunrise for others. This is in fact a particular experience that entails intransitive consciousness. Eventually, Kriegel’s conclusion is that consciousness presupposes self-consciousness, more specifically a certain kind of it, the intransitive state type.

It goes without saying that Kriegel’s model cannot be applied *tout court* to the Pratyabhijñā’s case, but I believe his arguments are helpful to clarify some key points of the Śaivas’ view. One of them is precisely the thesis that any cognition involves an awareness of the knowing subject. Kriegel’s arguments show that notion is rationally defensible, and it does not necessarily call for an idealistic viewpoint. In this view, the subjective aspect of consciousness always affects and modifies the way in which a cognition takes place.

A second aspect concerns the idea on which the Śaivas (and this book) insist repeatedly, namely that a cognition cannot be objectified.⁵ The notion becomes evident if thought in terms of *intransitive* and *transitive self-consciousness*. All mental states possess both an intransitive and a transitive (or intentional) mode, which occur at the same time. The Pratyabhijñā thinkers emphasize that the intransitive aspect of a mental state can never be the content of another, as it is absolutely subjective. But this does not mean that a mental state cannot *transitively* have another one as its content.⁶

A final point concerns the distinction between *state* and *creature* self-consciousness, which greatly helps to understand Pratyabhijñā’s conception of subjectivity. We have seen that for the Śaiva authors, any given mental state possesses an ineliminable, subjective dimension, which they indicate with the expression *camatkāra*, a concept that reminds Kriegel’s *intransitive state consciousness*. This primary seed of subjectivity is then progressively engrossed into the concepts of self and personhood, that is, into *creature consciousness*. The picture is clearly detectable in a stanza we have already quoted, ĪPK 1.5.17, where Utpaladeva distinguishes between the nature of the self (intransitive state consciousness,

camatkāra) and the notion of ‘I’ (creature consciousness, *ātma*), with the latter presupposing the former. In the end, it is only because there is an underlying subjective feeling of the experience that one can come up with the notion of ‘I’.⁷

That said, it remains somewhat unclear how the passage from state to creature consciousness takes place. A Buddhist would in fact point out that the move is unwarranted. The Pratyabhijñā thinkers, on the one hand, would reply that the existence of a self is proved by an analysis of how memory works. More specifically, by the necessity to explain the existence of coordinated, higher-order cognitions which are unthinkable without positing the notion of personhood. Still, they would also argue that the difference between state and creature consciousness is just supposed, because they are essentially the same thing, an affirmation that will be clearer later in this chapter after the discussion of the notion that for the Pratyabhijñā consciousness is in the end ubiquitous.

What is a self? Indian views

In a brilliant book devoted to question of self in classical Indian philosophy, Jonardon Ganeri (2012) introduced an ingenious taxonomy of the ways the notion was dealt with by Indian schools and thinkers and has interpreted their positions in the light of the contemporary analytic debate. Ganeri builds his classification upon a preliminary distinction between the owner or the ‘place’ of experience and the ontological realizers of this ownership, the ‘base’ of experience. The two concepts are traced back to the Sanskrit distinction between *ādhāra* and *āśraya*. Against this background, Ganeri enlists eleven modes of conceiving the notion of self, each grounded on different interpretations of what place and base are. He groups the first three models together, labelling them as the ‘One-Dimensional Views’. In all these views, place and base are not distinguished. The first One-Dimensional View is the Cartesian one, in which the self is both the owner of the experience and the base for its realization. The second is the Materialist stance in which the body is both place and base of experience. Finally comes the Reductionist position according to which a stream of mental contents is both the place and the base of experience (a position defended for instance in Parfit, 1986). The next item in Ganeri’s taxonomy are the ‘Real-Self Views’. These views regard the self as real but distinguish between place and base. The first type is the ‘Ownership View’, whereby the self is the place of experience and the body is the ontological base. The second is the ‘Phenomenal View’, according to which the self is the place and the stream of mental items its base. Finally, there is a ‘Pure-Consciousness View’, in which the self is the place but there is no base. Then comes another group of three labelled as ‘No-Place Views’. They are all characterized by the rejection of the idea of place, that is, of somebody owning experience, and by conceiving the base differently. The first view claims that the base is the body; the second one that it is the stream of mental items; the third and most extreme one claims that there is no base at all. Finally come two positions which Ganeri calls the “Flame View” and the “Tornado View”. They are both versions of emergentism. The idea at the basis of both views is that a dynamical system, when it reaches a sufficient level of complexity, displays properties that are absent at the micro level and which

emerge only on the macro one. In the Flame View, the micro states are fused and transformed into something else so that they are not any longer exhibited at the macro level. The simile is precisely the flame. In a fire, the fuel produces the flames, the macro state, by a process of fusion and transformation. In the Tornado View, conversely, the macro state still exhibits the basic elements of the micro state, though it retains its autonomy. In a hurricane, the components of the micro state, molecules of air and water, are still present at the macro level. Both models, the Flame View and the Tornado View, can be applied to the emergence of mental contents starting from material items. In the Tornado View, the stream of mental contents is place, and the body is regarded as base. In the Flame View, the stream is place, but there is no base.

Now much of Ganeri's efforts are directed at showing that many of these different understanding of self are displayed in the works of Indian philosophers. Some of them are quite evident. The No-Place Views corresponds to the way Buddhism has dealt with the question over time. All Buddhists deny the existence of place and therefore the possibility that someone or something can own experience. Still, they differ as to the ontological base of mental contents. The first view, according to which the base is the body, is that of the Abhidharma, whose basic contention is that subjectivity can eventually be traced back to the five *skandhas*. The second, which claims that the base is the stream, is the standard Yogācāra position. The third, which negates the existence of a base too, corresponds to the Madhyamaka's tenets. Less evident but convincingly argued is the ascription to the Pudgalavādins of a Flame View, to the Nyāya of an Ownership View and to the Cārvāka of a Materialist View. Finally, the Pure Consciousness View is attributed to Indian idealists. Ganeri mentions explicitly the cases of Advaita Vedānta and the Kashmiri Śaivas, a term he uses to indicate both the Pratyabhijñā and the Śaiva-Siddhānta's philosophy of Rāmakaṇṭha. Ganeri is generally not sympathetic with these views, for they are open to a couple of serious objections. The first is that idealists uphold a notion of self that is strongly attenuated. In other words, they maintain a notion of self that is so basic and 'thin' that it becomes scarcely recognizable as self. Normally, the answer to the attenuation problem is to conceive the self as an entity that enjoys some level of embodiment. The second issue raised by Ganeri is that a Pure-Consciousness View, in which no ontological base grounds the notion of self, is inadequate to explain the existence of other minds and therefore falls into the trap of solipsism. Let us consider whether these objections can be overcome and whether, in the end, the Pratyabhijñā's position can really be categorized as a Pure-Consciousness View.

The problem of attenuation

The problem of attenuation is indeed a critical one. Its original formulation is due to Peter Strawson, who wrote:

From within our actual conceptual scheme, each of us can quite intelligibly conceive of his or her individual survival of bodily death. . . . One has simply to think of oneself as having thoughts and memories as at present, visual

and auditory experiences largely as at present, even, perhaps—though this involves certain complications—some quasi-tactual and organic sensations as at present, whilst (a) having no perceptions of a body related to one's experience as one's own body is, and (b) having no power of initiating changes in the physical condition of the world. . . . Condition (a) must be expanded by adding that no one else exhibits reactions indicating that he perceives a body at the point which one's body would be occupying if one were seeing and hearing in an embodied state from the point from which one is seeing and hearing in a disembodied state. One could, of course, imagine condition (a) being fulfilled, in both its parts, without condition (b) being fulfilled. This would be a rather vulgar fancy, in the class of the table-tapping spirits with familiar voices. But suppose we take disembodiment strictly in the sense that we imagine both (a) and (b) fulfilled. Then two consequences follow. . . . The first is that the strictly disembodied individual is strictly solitary, and it must remain for him indeed an utterly empty, though not meaningless, speculation, as to whether *there* are any other members of his class. The other, and less commonly noticed point, is that in order to retain his idea of himself as an individual, he must always think of himself as disembodied, as a former person. . . . At the limit of attenuation there is, *from the point of view of his survival as an individual*, no difference between the continuance of experience and its cessation.

(Strawson, 1963, pp. 115–116, emphasis in original)

Strawson's argument is clear: thinking of pure consciousness as a disembodied phenomenon does not account for the notion of personhood. If brought to extremes, the idea of pure-consciousness leads to the counterintuitive position that there is no difference at all between being alive and being dead. But, apparently, the Pratyabhijñā philosophers are defending precisely this kind of view. They identify the self with a basic, atomic spark of consciousness, which is claimed to be extended to all phenomena of reality. The point is whether this atomic self is really the entity we usually mean with the word 'self'. For when we normally use this expression, we do not mean an extremely rarefied version of consciousness but rather something with a good number of specific functions and capacities. It is hard to find a better list of what a self is supposed to do—at least for Indian authors—than the one Ganeri has put together. A self, if really exists, must be something which has:

- The capacity to ascribe to oneself mental and physical attributes, that is, to think thoughts that are expressed in first-person present tense ascriptions of psychological state: "I am happy". "I am thinking about going out" [*ahaṃ—pratyaya*].
 - The capacity to be reflexively self-aware, that is for one's thoughts to be aware of themselves as well as their intentional objects [*svasaṃvedana*]. The content of reflexive awareness is held by some to be non-conceptual.

- The capacity to reidentify objects both over time and across sensory modalities, that is to think thoughts that are expressed as “This object which I now am touching is the same as this object which I am now looking at” [*anusaṃdhana*] and “This object which I am now looking at is the same as that object which I saw yesterday” [*pratyabhijñā*].
- The capacity to have occurrent thoughts with intentional content, including those associated with perception, reason and linguistic understanding [*jñāna*].
- The capacity to have occurrent memories [*smṛti*].
- The capacity to have occurrent desires, dreads, pleasure, and pains [*icchā, dveṣa, sukha, duḥkha*].
- The capacity to anticipate the future, to imagine how it might be, to make resolution [*saṃkalpa*].
- The capacity to have dispositional traces, such as those associated with long-term non-occurrent memory [*saṃskāra, bhāvanā*].
- The capacity to *feel* emotion such as love, hate, regret, and sorrow; the feeling of the emotion being distinct from the emotion itself [*vedanā*].
- The capacity to sense proprioceptively one’s body [*rūpaṇa*].
- The capacity selectively to attend to objects in one’s surroundings or to own’s one mental states [*viññāna, manas*].

(Ganeri, 2012, pp. 103–104)

Now, is a basic, atomic self capable of performing all these functions? Clearly it is not, so at first sight, it seems that the charge of attenuation holds. Before returning to the question, let us consider first the other problem Pure-Consciousness Views face.

Solipsism and the existence of other minds

If a Pure-Consciousness view is valid, how can one account for the existence of other minds? If all that exists is a single, universal consciousness, how to explain the fact that in ordinary experience, we encounter entities that look like us, that is, persons having a mental life? It seems that there are just two ways to tackle the question. But both imply unpleasant consequences for the idealist. One might choose not to accept the existence of other minds, deeming their appearance as a pure illusion. But then it remains to be explained how this illusion comes about and how an intersubjective reality obtains. The other path consists in allowing the existence of other minds. But, by doing so, the claim that exists a single, ‘pure’ consciousness would evidently receive a fatal blow.

The Pratyabhijñā philosophers were exactly in this unfortunate position, but at the least they were aware of it and they tried to come up with a solution. The question has thoroughly been studied by Isabelle Ratié, who has spelled out the strategy of Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta and shown their effort to distance their position on the issue from those of Buddhists idealists (Ratié, 2007). Philosophically speaking, it is doubtful whether this strategy is effective in rejecting the charge of solipsism, but it is nonetheless essential to situate the Pratyabhijñā’s

efforts within the coeval debate. Moreover, Ratié's article contains more than one hint at a possible solution to the problem of solipsism, a solution that we are going to discuss in the next section.

The issue of 'otherness' is largely discussed at the beginning of the fifth chapter of the *ĪPK*'s 'Chapter on Knowledge'. In it both Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta recast the debate on the nature of external objects that occurred between Buddhist thinkers of different persuasions. On the one side, the Sautrantikas externalists defended a form of indirect realism. They believed that objects are known through mental representations and never directly accessed by the knower; otherwise, one would slip into a form of naive realism which is a position open to a good number of counterarguments. Still, the Sautrantikas recognized that there must be a cause of the mental representations we experience. And this cause, they concluded, can be nothing but the external object, the existence of which cannot be perceived but is inferred. Radically different is the approach of the Yogācārins, who, as we have already seen, maintain that all that we cognize can be reduced to mental representations, and there is therefore no need to postulate the existence of anything external to consciousness. Pratyabhijñā's position on the question is clearly closer to the Yogācārins'. Still, in the way reconstructed by Ratié, the Śaivas make shrewdly use of the externalists' objections against the Yogācāra so as to signal the difference between their own conceptions and those of the Buddhist idealists. Let us consider schematically the Sautrantikas' objections:

- 1 The first argument of the externalists is that consciousness cannot be itself the cause of mental representations, for consciousness is by definition unitary and undifferentiated, whereas phenomena are multiple and determined. The Yogācāra's reply that the variety of phenomena is explained on the basis of the mental traces any cognition leaves in one's mental stream is not satisfactory, for one could further ask what is the cause of these mental traces.
- 2 The Yogācāra believes that the existence of other minds is caused by an externalization of consciousness. Other minds are not cognized as having bodily aspects but rather as a stream of cognitions related to these aspects. To this position, the Sautrantikas would object that it is actually always the same consciousness we are concerned with. If this is true, these different minds are only apparently different from the single, unitary consciousness. The idealist seems therefore left with just two options: if she admits that there is no substantial difference between internal and externalized consciousness—in other words if it is true that when I cognize others' mental streams I am actually cognizing myself—then she is plainly negating the existence of other minds. On the other hand, if she admits that one's mental stream can cognize that of others, then others' mental streams would end up being objectified, which is not only contradictory in itself, but it would also blur the distinction between perceiving conscious and unconscious things. What would be, in the end, the difference between cognizing a pot and cognizing Devadatta?
- 3 Now a thinker close to the Yogācāra positions such as Dharmakīrti would tend to favour the first option. He would argue that others can never be known

directly, but their existence can be inferred from the fact that they act. The concrete example he gives is the following: if my speaking is always preceded by the intention to speak, whenever I observe somebody else speaking, I must surmise that she had an intention to speak. Since this intention is not present in my mental stream, it must belong to the stream of someone else. Now this explanation does not explicitly negate the existence of others, but it is something close. The reason should be familiar. In the ontological and epistemological views of the Pramāṇavādins, whenever inference is at play, we are dealing with a second-rate means of knowledge that is useful for practical purposes but is eventually unable to grasp reality as it is. To further complicate the Yogācārin's position, the externalists portrayed by Abhinavagupta in the *ĪPV* also point out that the Dharmakīrti's argument is circular: the invariable concomitance between the desire to speak and the act of speaking is valid for myself, but it cannot be extended to others unless one does not beforehand accept their existence, which is actually what the argument is trying to prove.

- 4 According to the Sautrantikas' view, an idealist is unable to account for the existence of intersubjective reality because her position is founded on the idea that there are only streams of consciousness that are mutually inaccessible. Dharmakīrti justifies the fact that we perceive an intersubjective reality, that is, the fact the different persons seem to act in the same environment and cognize the same objects as a mere coincidence, more specifically, as people suffering of the same 'eye disease'.
- 5 At this point, the Pratyabhijñā enters the debate and specifies the extent to which their view differs from both Buddhist externalists and idealists. At first sight, their position looks like quite similar to the Yogācāra. They believe that nothing is actually external to consciousness. And they also agree that the existence of other persons cannot be directly perceived or inferred, because that would infringe the axiom of non-objectification of cognitions. Still, Utpaladeva tries to overcome the problem by saying that the existence of other minds is not known (i.e. it is not either perceived or inferred) but 'guessed'. Abhinavagupta elaborates on the notion by resorting to a distinction between two types of inference introduced by Dharmakīrti some centuries earlier: there is an inference (called *tadutpatti-anumāna*) which is based on a cause–effect relationship between the *probandum* (*sādhya*) and the *probans* (*liṅga or hetu*). The classical Nyāya example of smoke and fire is precisely an instance of this type of inference. I know that there is a fire on the hill because there is smoke, and I know that between the two, there is an invariable concomitance because the former is the cause of the latter. The second type of inference (called *tādātmya-anumāna*) is different and is based on the essential nature (*svabhāva*) of entities. The example in this case is the relation that obtains between the birch and the tree. Whenever I see a birch, I know that what I see is a tree: between the two there is an invariable concomitance, the birch being by nature a tree. Now, the Pratyabhijñā's solution to the problem of other minds is based on this

distinction. Whenever we see actions produced by other bodies, we surmise the existence of other subjects not on the basis of an inference of the first type. In that case, the axiom of non-objectification would be infringed. It is rather an instance of a *svabhāva* inference, whereby the relation is established between things that belong to the same kind. The original idea is precisely this: the act of myself cognizing the actions of seemingly other persons is no different in nature by the action themselves. Abhinavagupta is returning to the crucial idea that we have discussed at length in Chapter 3 whereby the fundamental nature of a cognition consists in its self-reflexive awareness. This self-reflexive awareness is a high-order phenomenon, but it is also, crucially, an action. The Pratyabhijñā thinkers therefore argue that there is no substantial difference between acting and knowing: the visible actions of other bodies are just the final stage (*paryanta*) of the process of concretization of consciousness.

Is all this enough to reject the charge of solipsism? Probably not. No matter how one puts the question, the idea that in a purely idealistic view, whenever one cognizes another person, she is in the end cognizing her own mental content remains difficult to disprove. Ratié has convincingly shown how the Pratyabhijñā tries to justify the perception of other persons adopting a top-down approach. By doing so, one attempts to describe the conscious nature of all phenomena starting from the conscious nature of the individual subject. Nevertheless, one might also attempt to follow the opposite path, thus using a bottom-up approach. In this perspective, the individual subject is conscious because all phenomena are in some way conscious. I explore this point of view in the next section with the hope to further clarify the Pratyabhijñā's position.

Pratyabhijñā and panpsychism

As Ratié writes in the article, we have just discussed, the Pratyabhijñā's philosophical endeavours can be looked at either "from the point of view of the universal consciousness constantly engaged in creating the world or from the phenomenological point of view of any ordinary conscious phenomenon" (Ratié, 2007, p. 349). The first approach is apparent. The subject is identified with a universal consciousness that is instantiated in all aspects of reality. Still, this aspect often overshadows the other, the one whereby all ordinary phenomena are actually conscious. Now I think that a more in-depth exploration of this aspect can tell us something important about the worldview the Pratyabhijñā philosophers were defending.

Concerning this, Utpaladeva explicitly says that consciousness is instantiated in all reality, and by all reality, he really means everything. In his view, even a material thing, like a pot or rock, contains in itself a conscious component: "The external manifestation of things existing in the present is possible only if they reside within". The verse is shortly commented as follows in the *Vṛtti*: "Even in direct perception it is correct to say that there is a manifestation of things as

differentiated only if [these things] are absorbed in the internal knower ”.⁸ In the ĪPV, Abhinavagupta expands on this by saying:

A manifestation of objects that have the nature of “this” in a clear and direct way, has an external nature caused by their separated existence from the individual knower, which begins with Śunya and ends with the body, all products of Māyā. These objects are separated and distinguished from the knower because of the power of Māyā, but are present within the real knower, which is pure consciousness. And it is possible, i.e. it is logically tenable, to say that these objects do not lose their identity with the knower. On the basis of all this, it is correct to say that the power of knowledge of the Lord consists in manifesting the existence of separated objects, whose identity which consciousness is thus retained, but which exist separately due to the fact that they depend on the limited subject.⁹

Epistemologically speaking, the Pratyabhijñā authors claim that the existence of external reality depends on the mental activity of the knower. At first sight, it seems a rather explicit endorsement of an idealistic point of view, whereby all things exist as mental content. Nevertheless, the ensuing stanza, ĪPK 1.5.2, says something more gripping, as it explicitly states that, from an ontological perspective, all things have a mental component: “Without having light as its nature, an object would remain a non-light as before. Light is not different from the object. The essential nature of an object consists in its being light”.¹⁰ Abhinavagupta comments:

An object is, for instance, a patch of blue etc. If the essential nature of a patch of blue etc., were not its being light, if it were something else, and if the essential nature of light were independent from the physical dimension of the object, then it can be said, as a mere possibility, that a patch of blue would be manifest to all, or to none, or that a patch of blue would remain confined in itself. For it is logically untenable that an (independent) entity depend on another one. Or it may not be either blue or not—blue in itself, because that would be something impossible to establish without the assistance of light. The same applies to the “manifestedness” of this [patch of blue]: it can be for all, none or confined in itself. Or even not confined in itself. All universe would be blindness.¹¹

From these passages, it emerges rather clearly that the Pratyabhijñā philosophers are not only defending the view that consciousness is pervasive and ultimately identified with a universal subject. They also claim quite vigorously that the conscious component of experience is not limited to the mental dimension. It is actually ubiquitous and present in every aspect of reality, even in material things. This side of Utpaladeva’s philosophy is often overlooked, but if properly considered, it has some consequences on the way we understand the philosophy of the Recognition. A first consequence of this interpretation is that Ganeri’s

classification of the Pratyabhijñā as a Pure-Consciousness View becomes difficult to defend. In Ganeri's nomenclature, Pure-Consciousness Views are characterized by the fact that they regard the self as the owner of experience (*ādhāra*), whereas nothing functions as its ontological base (*āśraya*). All that exists is consciousness in the form of mental representations. Such a definition may work for the Advaita Vedānta, but I believe it is ill-suited to describe the Pratyabhijñā's conceptions. Actually, in the Śaivas' view, the base is absolutely existent, and it coincides with everything. In other words, Utpaladeva is claiming that the conscious component of experience is realized—in Ganeri's jargon has its *āśraya*—in all aspects of reality. The second hermeneutical consequence is that I suspect that the best way to interpret the Śaiva philosophy is to regard it not as a form of idealism but as something close to panpsychism. Let me consider this hypothesis more in detail.

Panpsychism is the view that mentality is ubiquitous in the world (Goff, Seager, and Allen-Hermanson, 2017; Brüntrup and Jaskolla, 2017). Despite being a position having a long history in Euro-American thought, panpsychism has received much attention in contemporary philosophy of mind. The current appeal of panpsychism rests on the difficulties faced by the two standard approaches to the problem of consciousness. If physicalism fails to explain the phenomenal, first-person dimension of consciousness, dualism, especially in the property version which is nowadays mostly defended, is unable to solve the problem of interaction of mind and body, as well as that of how to deal with the principle that the physical domain must be causally closed. In short, this means that the causes of physical events must be physical themselves: if one allows non-physical items (like the mind) having effect on matter, one is going to open up an avenue to a myriad of non-physical causes that would be reasonable to keep out of the picture. Panpsychism is appealing because looks like a middle way between the two options. In agreement with physicalism, it affirms that the universe is homogeneous and can be explained on the basis of a single, basic element. In accordance with dualism, it claims that the mind is causally effective. More specifically, the panpsychist's solution consists in hypothesizing that consciousness is fundamental and instantiated anywhere. Just like many contemporary theorists of various persuasions, a panpsychist believes that fundamental things exist at the micro level and that the macro one is in some way dependent on micro states. In most cases, a proponent of panpsychism is backing some sort of pan-experientialism. In other words, she believes that the fundamental entities of the universe have a conscious component. This component then develops into fully fledged forms of subjectivity on the basis of the laws of physics and biology.

Panpsychists are roughly divided into two main camps. Some espouse a version of the theory called 'constitutive panpsychism'. Here the critical idea is that facts about human consciousness and subjective experience are not fundamental. They are rather constituted by facts which occur at the micro level. The upholders of this view believe that conscious micro-level items, if appropriately combined, produce the notions of self and subjectivity that are exhibited at the macro level. The other option, 'non-constitutive panpsychism', is instead based on the idea that conscious minds arise as the causal result of micro-level subjects. Different

from the previous view, here the subjects of experience are conceived as already existing at the micro level. There is a further distinction to make with regard to non-constitutive panpsychism. Some philosophers think that fully fledged human minds coexist with those micro-level conscious subjects that give rise to them and sustain them over time ('layered panpsychism'). Others maintain that when the micro-level conscious subjects are combined, they cease to be detectable as they melt in the macro-level mind ('fusionism').

The contemporary proponents of panpsychism think that their model has an edge over dualism and various forms of physicalism at least in three respects. In the first place, their theory is better equipped to deal with the so-called Anti-Emergence Argument. The main problem for emergentism is to explain how macro-level consciousness develops from micro states that are unconscious. Among others, both Nagel (1979) and Strawson (2006) have argued against emergentism and claimed that the only way to explain macro-level consciousness is to suppose that it derives from more basic forms of consciousness: "For any feature *y* of anything that is correctly considered to be emergent from *x*, there must be something about *x* and *x* alone in virtue of which *y* emerges, and which is sufficient for *y*" (Strawson 2006). In the second place, panpsychism looks like promising in dealing with the issue of the intrinsic nature of the universe. Here the premise is that natural sciences, physics in particular, are unable to give a complete account of the material world. They describe fairly well the behaviour of matter but are unable to tell us what matter is. The idea is that the vocabulary of science is by definition relational and extrinsic, and it does not say much about the intrinsic nature of things. A panpsychist believes that this intrinsic nature can be explained by admitting the existence of mentality at the micro level of reality. The third important argument in favour panpsychism is the genetic one. Panpsychists hold that the biological evolution of consciousness can be better accounted for by their model, as far as it offers a seamless account of the phenomenon. Different from a physicalist, a panpsychist needs not explain the sudden emergence of conscious properties from material ones and needs not specify the cause of the emergence, nor at which point in time it occurred.

It goes without saying that panpsychism has attracted also considerable criticism. A first of objection is the so-called incredulous stare. To many, the idea that matter, even though in its least observable parts, possesses some sort of mentality sounds deeply counterintuitive. And even if a panpsychist is ready to specify that mental properties are realized in matter only at the micro level, panpsychism is often caricatured as attributing consciousness to rocks and electrons. That said, the 'incredulous stare' remains a weak objection, since there are countless examples showing that the nature of things is often in contrast with commonsensical views about it. A much more serious threat to panpsychism is the so-called combination problem. The question boils down to explaining how the combination of micro-conscious entities can produce macro-state consciousness. Or, in the case of non-constitutive panpsychism, how micro subjects can be compounded to form macro ones. According to some authors (Coleman, 2014), this view is inherently contradictory for it looks like impossible to conceive a macro subject encompassing all

the micro ones. The rationale is that a subject has by definition a singular and specific point of view on reality, a point of view that excludes those of others. If this is true, how can one conceive a human subject as the sum of micro subjects operating at the smallest level? Contemporary theorists have repeatedly dealt with the combination problem, spelled out the several ways in which it can occur (Chalmers, 2015), and proposed various solutions, even though the issue remains a most serious one for panpsychism. That being said, it is not our purpose to explore possible solutions or to defend panpsychism as a theory of consciousness but rather to see whether the Pratyabhijñā philosophers had something similar in mind.

Abhinavagupta's passage commenting on ĪPK 1.5.2 that quoted earlier is extremely telling in this regard, because it states a couple of fundamental facts of Pratyabhijñā's view of reality. In the first place, Abhinavagupta claims that between light (which in the Pratyabhijñā's jargon indicates cognition and consciousness) and objects, there is no essential difference; otherwise, we would get two independent realities that cannot interact. In its own way, this looks like a restatement of the well-known interaction problem that besets Euro-American philosophy of mind since the time of Descartes. In the second place, Abhinavagupta is also explicitly arguing in favour of monism. It remains then to see whether he prefers to compound his rejection of dualism with a form of physicalism, idealism, or with something in between. The first option, physicalism, is obviously not contemplated. But I think that also 'pure' idealism is not the best explanation of what the Śaiva philosophers had in mind. This becomes clear if we consider the second key remark Abhinavagupta makes in the passage in question. If consciousness were absolutely incompatible with the bodily, physical dimension of its content, it would be a totally useless consciousness, for it would be contained in itself and looking like a sort of amorphous consciousness that could belong in principle to anybody, to none, or even be totally inaccessible—a prospect which sounds untenable (and horrible!). It seems therefore plausible to conclude that the Pratyabhijñā thinkers were endorsing a form of panpsychism, whereby the spark of consciousness is operating at all level, even the most material ones. Once this is accepted—and we have seen that the position is controversial—the passage from pan-experientialism to a proper notion of self, thus to an entity able to perform the functions Ganeri enlisted, is explained in terms of an ever-growing complexity in the arrangement of the micro-level conscious items. In a rock, this arrangement is less complex than the one we find in animals, which is in turn less complex than the that of a human subject. A similar view is put forward by the Śaiva when they introduce in their nomenclature of reality (the so-called 36 principles, or *tattvas*) the *kañcukas*, the cuirasses, which are the factors that progressively hamper and obfuscate the mental and conscious dimension of experience. If all this sounds reasonable, the oft-quoted sentence of Abhinavagupta whereby there is only a single, universal subject of experience it must be taken with a pinch of salt, I think.¹² The author was probably meaning that the cognitive, conscious aspect of reality must be regarded as the *file rouge* that binds together all phenomena. Not that the Pratyabhijñā thinkers were negating the existence of other minds.

It remains to consider one last point. The idea that panpsychism is the best interpretation of how Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta conceive the world seems to clash with the notion that I have thoroughly defended in this book, the one according to which a state is conscious when is the content of a higher-order state that is also language informed. In fact, a crucial requirement for higher-order theories is to suppose that some mental states can be unconscious. And this, at first sight, seems to conflict with the notion that everything possess a mental component. A first answer to this question has been given indirectly in Chapter 5, where I argued that the Śaiva authors defend the idea that a mental state possess inherently its higher-order counterpart. To this we can also add that some contemporary theorists defend a peculiar version of panpsychism that includes elements of higher-order theories. The particular form of panpsychism involved here is dubbed ‘pan-protopsyichism’, according to which the basic, mental features of reality are proto-phenomenal properties. These proto-phenomenal properties are able to *transparently* account for phenomenal (i.e. macro-state) ones. Here ‘transparently’ means that one can in principle deduce the phenomenal, subjective qualities of a human subject starting from the proto-phenomenal ones (Chalmers, 2015). One of the most influential versions of pan-protopsyichism is *panquali-tyism*. In this perspective, the fundamental notion is that the ubiquitous mental components of reality are *unexperienced qualities*. These unexperienced qualities come to be experienced due to contingent factors. And one of the ways to explain the passage from unexperienced qualities to experienced ones is precisely to suppose the existence of higher-order thought doing the job. A position that is defended, for instance, by Sam Coleman (2017).

In conclusion, I believe that we will do a better justice to the doctrines of the Pratyabhijñā if we interpret the philosophy of the school as a form of panpsychism instead of idealism. Such an outlook will provide us with a more accurate explanation of the difference between the stance of the Śaivas and pure, or illusory idealism, as well as of the idea that for the Pratyabhijñā thinkers experience has a ‘dynamic character’. In the end, this dynamic character comes down to nothing but the notion that consciousness and mentality operate across all levels of reality.

Notes

- 1 The nature of personal identity has been discussed at length in Euro-American philosophy. Historically speaking, the first position to emerge is the Platonic conception that the self or soul is a simple, immaterial substance that survives the death of the body. This was the dominant view for centuries and it continues to be very influential to the commonsensical notion of self most people have. A second phase in the reflection on the nature of personhood was opened by the work of the seventeenth-century philosopher John Locke. During this phase, the conception of self as immaterial substance progressively dwindled, and personal identity came to be seen as an ever-changing process of psychological and physical elements that are appropriately (which most of the time meant causally) connected. Finally, there is a third phase that started quite recently, in the 1960s, and it is still ongoing. This phase presents three main developments. In the first place, it displays a tendency to refine the Lockean position. For example, Locke held an ‘intrinsic relations’ view of personal identity. In this

model, what makes today's person the same as yesterday's is the way in which the two moments are psychologically and physically related to each other. This view is nowadays almost often replaced by an 'extrinsic relations' view. According to this position, the fact that a person at one time is the same as another person at another time is not determined only by the psychological or physical relation linking the two persons but by the way in which they are related to everybody else. An example may be of help: in Locke's intrinsic view, I know that I am the same person I was yesterday if I remember having done things that yesterday's person did. In the extrinsic view, I myself am no longer sufficient. I am the same person that existed yesterday if everybody else remembers having experienced things that person yesterday did. The second development of the contemporary phase concerns the stress on the question whether personal identity is crucial or not for survival. The third regards the challenge modern theorists have posed to the traditional three-dimensional view of persons, whereby one is wholly present at any given moment. It has been argued that we actually have a fourth dimension, a sort of person-stage, that exists only for short periods of time. See Olson (2017).

- 2 The rejection of idealism in analytic philosophy is still largely based on the work of Moore (1903) and Russell (1912).
- 3 An example from Searle: "Finally, consciousness should not be confused with self-consciousness. There are indeed certain types of animals, such as humans, that are capable of extremely complicated forms of self-referential consciousness which would normally be described as self-consciousness. For example, I think conscious feelings of shame require that the agent be conscious of himself or herself. But seeing an object or hearing a sound, for example, does not require self-consciousness. And it is not generally the case that all conscious states are also self-conscious" (Searle, 2002, p. 8).
- 4 In Kriegel's paper, the examples are different. He talks of 'Mr Smith' and 'cars'. I have adapted his examples to the Indian context by using Indian names.
- 5 *vārtamānapramāṭṛbhāve nāhaṃpratyavamrśyasya prameyatvenedantā* (ĪPKVṛ 1.5.17). "When it exists as a present cognizing subject, the object of reflexive awareness 'I' does not have the nature of 'this', a nature it should have as a content of knowledge".
- 6 If we claim that all our cognitions imply the knowledge of their subject, that is, of ourselves, the conclusion is that all that we know is actually our own mind, which is a problematic philosophical position known as solipsism. For Kriegel, this risk is avoided by restricting the notion of self-consciousness to the intransitive type. See the discussion later in this chapter.
- 7 *nāhantādiaparāmāśabhedād asyānyatātmanaḥ / ahaṃmrśyataivāsyā sṛṣtes tiñvācyakarmavat* // (ĪPK 1.5.17). "From the existence of notions of 'I' etc., one should not imply a differentiation in the nature of self, because this is produced in so far as it the content of the reflexive awareness 'I'. Exactly in the same way a verbal action is expressed by personal endings".
- 8 *vartamānāvabhāsānām bhāvānām avabhāsanam/antaḥsthitavatām ghaṭate bahir ātmanā* // (ĪPK 1.5.1).
ĪPVṛ: *pratyakṣe 'pi yāvad arthānām bhedenāvabhāsaḥ pramātrantarlīnānām eva satām yuktaḥ*.
- 9 *vartamānatvena sphuṭatayā avabhāsanam idamity evamākāraṃ yeṣām teṣām, yad etat bahirātmanā kalpitamāyīyaśūnyādiśarīrāntapramāṭṛprthagbhāvena hetunā, bhinnānām tato māyāpramāṭuḥ vicchinānām avabhāsanam tat paramārthapramāṭari śuddhacinnamāyā antaḥsthitavatām tena saha aikāntmyam anujjhitavatām eva ghaṭate pramāṇena upapadyate, tena anujjhitasaṃvidabhedasya bhāvasya kalpitapramātrapekṣayā bhedenā prakāśanam bhagavato jñānaśaktir ity uktaṃ bhavati*.
- 10 *prāḡ ivārtho 'prakāśaḥ syāt prakāśātmatayā vinā / na ca prakāśo bhinnāḥ syād ātmārthasya prakāśatā* // (ĪPK 1.5.2).

- 11 *artha nīlādīḥ, tasya nīlādirūpataiva yadi prakāśamānatā na punaḥ sāparā kācit arthaśarīrotīrṇā prakāśātmatā tarhi yathā sarvān prati nīlam eva tatsaṃbhāvanayā bhanyate, na kiṃcit vā prati, vastuto vā svātmany eva tata nīlam parasya paraniṣṭhatvānupapatteḥ, svātmani vā nīlaṃ na anīlaṃ prakāśānugraheṇa vinā vyavasthānāyogāt. tathā prakāśamānatāpi asya sarvān prati na kaṃcit vā prati api svātmany eva, svātmany api vā na syāt it andhatā jagataḥ (ĪPV on ĪPK 1.5.2).*
- 12 *viśvaḥ pramātrvargaḥ paramārthataḥ ekaḥ pramātā, sa eva ca asti.* See Ganeri (2012, p. 217).

Epilogue

To conclude this work, it is worthwhile to recall its three major purposes, which we have identified in the Introduction. It is now clear that the first two aims—the explanatory and the comparative ones—are deeply intertwined. My first basic preoccupation was to make clear the essential features of Pratyabhijñā's philosophy of consciousness, trying to separate the theological implications—which are certainly present and are important in their own way—from the philosophical arguments the school offers to justify its views. Accordingly, I have tried to evaluate whether what Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta claim is rationally sound or not. The method I have used is a comparative one, consisting of presenting the Pratyabhijñā's tenets in relation to those held by contemporary thinkers, trying to highlight the affinities as well as the differences. Pratyabhijñā's overall conception of reality, permeated as it is by a panpsychist approach and an equally strong religious overtone, is obviously far from the sensibility of a contemporary philosopher not to mention that of the twenty-first century man in the street. Still, I hope I have been able to show that once one gets into the details of the arguments these thinkers deploy, the feeling that one is dealing with a plausible if not convincing theory starts to emerge.

In this book, we have broadly focused on two aspects of Pratyabhijñā's philosophy, which are strictly related. The first is somewhat the *pars destruens* of Pratyabhijñā's thought, consisting in the rejection of the Buddhist notion of 'non-self'. The task is carried out by bringing to extremes the notion that a cognitive episode (mental state, mental representation, and cognition are all apt synonyms) is inherently self-aware. As we have seen, the notion is far from being innovative or exclusive to the Pratyabhijñā's milieu. Still, what makes a difference is Utpaladeva's highly original and strict application of the concept. His strategy reveals that cognition's self-luminous nature is actually to be intended in two different ways. There is an aspect in self-awareness that is intentional and which consists in the capacity of a mental state to be about an object and, at the same time, to be intentionally directed at itself. Still, there is another, more crucial aspect to take into consideration. Here consciousness's fundamental characteristic consists in sentiency itself, which is a purely subjective, phenomenal, first-person quality. As such, this latter aspect of consciousness cannot be treated as a content, for it is always intention free. Pratyabhijñā's rejection of the Buddhist construal of

subjectivity depends almost totally on this very aspect. The Śaiva thinkers contend that to imagine a situation in which the notion of real self, *ātma*, is replaced by a series of mental representations linked one another by a cause–effect relationship is mistaken. These representations, these impressions or traces (*samskāras*) left in the mental continuum, are in fact nothing but cognitions, and to believe in their mutual interaction entails that one is accessing the content of another. This might have been a defensible position if cognitions have had only an intentional self-reflexivity. But the Pratyabhijñā is precisely arguing that once the subjective aspect of consciousness is correctly taken into account, the Buddhist position becomes untenable. Put another way, it would amount to holding that consciousness is reducible to a mirror or a crystal, which just reflects passively what stands in front of it, or using a quite telling contemporary example, it would be similar to a zombie. It goes without saying that it is precisely this second, purely subjective aspect of consciousness that Utpaladeva deems to be absolutely non-objectifiable and the component at the very basis of the idea of self.

Despite the compelling interpretation they give to the notion of *svasamvedana*, the Pratyabhijñā authors would have been much less philosophically interesting without the strong *pars construens* of their thought. Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta do not simply argue against the Buddhist standpoint, but they also provide us with a rather precise picture of what consciousness is. They claim that ‘to be conscious’ involves two different yet related stages. The first is that of a mental state which is directed at a content or an event, which is grasped through the senses. They refer to stage in various ways, but *prakāśa*, ‘light’, is the term most commonly used. Still, this stage would not be conscious at all without a higher-order activity of the mind that operates on first-order cognitions. Again, the Śaivas refer to this stage with different names (*pratyavamarśa*, *parāmarśa*, *vimarśa*), all of them connected with the Sanskrit verbal root *mṛś*, whose basic figurative meaning is ‘to reflect’, ‘to consider’. This already suggests that the relationship between first- and higher-order representations is not perceptual. Reflexive awareness does not perceive the cognitions generated by the sensory stimuli; it rather conceptualizes them. This leads to the conclusion that *vimarśa* is a conceptual form of reflexive knowledge that involves language. We have seen in detail that the idea that language is required for higher-order representations can be argued for in several ways. One can bring in the notions of LoT, that of reportability or, to appeal to an assumption common to most Indian philosophers, according to which conceptuality always implies language. To use a contemporary designation, the picture just summarized is a ‘higher-order theory’ of consciousness. With regard to this, one can object whether an interpretation of Pratyabhijñā’s conception of consciousness in higher-order terms does not conflict with the fact that, according to the school, a mental representation can never objectified by another. The doubt is certainly justified but the objection can be rejected. Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta are explicit enough, I believe, in emphasizing that what is not objectifiable is the purely subjective dimension of consciousness, not a mental state in itself. The fact that the Śaivas have been able to identify such an aspect, which they have indicated it with the term *camatkāra*, is one of the most original contributions to the

debate on consciousness in premodern South Asia. The Śaivas were clearly aware that there is a ‘what is like to be’ aspect in consciousness that is totally intention free. The point, as we have seen in Chapter 6, is how to reconcile a higher-order theory with the notion of phenomenal consciousness. The most effective solution seems to be maintaining that mental states are self-representational. This comes down to say that first-order cognitions are always accompanied by a higher-order, linguistic thought that makes them conscious. Put another way, perceptions and concepts seem to proceed hand in hand, so that the phenomenal and the intentional sides of consciousness feed constantly each other. In addition to all this, the Śaiva thinkers also put a strong emphasis on the idea that mentality and consciousness are ubiquitous components of reality, thus embracing a form of panpsychism. In a nutshell, their philosophical position on consciousness can be summarized as a higher-order theory compounded with a panpsychist slant.

The third purpose of this book is to make fully explicit the impact of the thought of Bhartṛhari on Pratyabhijñā’s theory of consciousness. As mentioned in Chapter 1, the relationship between the two sides is a recognized fact. Already in the 1938 edition of the *ĪPVV*, M.K. Kaul detected a good number of stanzas Abhinavagupta quoted from the *VP*. The connection has been discussed at various levels of depth by several scholars. On the whole it is rather difficult to downplay the importance of the work of the grammarian for the Pratyabhijñā authors, and scholars have focused on different aspect of Bhartṛhari’s legacy. Consider, for instance, this passage from an article by N. Rastogi:

The idea of word as the creative principle, unity of thought and speech, world of experience constituted by the powers of the word as the ultimate principle, speech as the basis and constitutive of the empirical world of purposeful activities, *vimarśa* and *anusandhāna* (unification), not only in participating in apprehending and communicating but also in ordering and coordinating our universe of discourse (*vyavasthā*), language in its transcendental aspect transfiguring into religious language par excellence, soteriology of language leading to self-realization and language being the root of our literary, cultural and aesthetic pursuits, all have been taken from BH [Bhartṛhari].

(Rastogi, 2009, p. 325)

The passage is pretty telling of how far-reaching the influence of Bhartṛhari on the Śaivas can be interpreted. Nonetheless, these affirmations remain fairly generic. In this book, I have tried to follow a different approach by considering a specific case of influence, that is, the notion of higher-order theory, which is, I think, the most enduring legacy Bhartṛhari left within the philosophy of the Kashmiri Śaivas. One can finally ask why Bhartṛhari has become so important for the development of the Pratyabhijñā’s philosophy. In principle, I tend to avoid the question because it is easy to slide into the realm of guesses. And I also think that is more instructive trying to understand *how* Bhartṛhari affected Utpaladeva’s thought rather than speculating *why*. The reason is that we do not have decisive, textual information that can settle the question, not at the moment at least.

Nevertheless, scholars have tried to explain the grammarian's impact on the Śaivas in several ways, which are indeed all plausible. There is little doubt that Bhartṛhari was well-known as an authoritative grammarian in the tenth c. Kashmir. Furthermore, as we have seen in Chapter 1, there is also the possibility that the VP's commentator Helārāja was somehow in contact with the Pratyabhijñā's milieu, in particular during Abhinavagupta's life. Still, these considerations remain far from being a proper explanation. In articulating the reason why Bhartṛhari was so influential to the Pratyabhijñā thinkers, the best strategy probably remains the one explored by Torella (2008), consisting in focusing on the change of attitude the Śaiva intellectuals had towards Bhartṛhari in the generation intervening between Somānanda and Utpaladeva. The shift in dealing with Bhartṛhari's philosophy was almost certainly caused by the different purposes the works of the two thinkers had. As already mentioned, Utpaladeva's rehabilitation of Bhartṛhari's after Somānanda had poured scorn on him in the ŚD was related to the necessity to counter the Buddhist ideas on argumentative grounds. Probably, Utpaladeva realized that the VP could provide him with a series of arguments he could profitably use to disprove the ideas the Buddhists held on the nature of consciousness, subjectivity, and knowledge. In Torella's words:

In order to undermine the discontinuous universe of the Buddhists he [Utpaladeva] decides to avail himself precisely of the latter doctrine, the language-imbued nature of knowledge, which is meant to demolish its main foundation-stone, the unsurpassable gulf between the moment of sensation and that of conceptual elaboration, representing, as it were, the very archetype of the Buddhist segmented reality.

(Torella, 2008, pp. 520–521)

In a way, this book tries to qualify Torella's statement by showing that the notion that knowledge is "language-imbued" is built upon a specific theory of consciousness, which the Pratyabhijñā thinkers largely inherit from Bhartṛhari. It is only by reconstructing all the argumentative steps that make up this theory that the idea of a 'linguistic nature of consciousness' becomes plausible.

In the end, are Pratyabhijñā's argumentations sound? It really depends on one's own philosophical stance. If one is willing to accept that consciousness's phenomenal quality cannot be explained by falling back on a mechanistic (i.e. physicalist) account, much of Utpaladeva's claims, though not incontrovertibly flawless, represent a serious challenge to the way in which the Buddhists conceived subjectivity and self. Likewise, Pratyabhijñā's huge emphasis on the ubiquity of consciousness implies the endorsement of a panpsychist view that can be attacked in various ways but which at the moment looks also like as a promising explanation of the questions we have discussed throughout the book. Therefore, the final judgement is somewhat reserved. As it happens with most of the contemporary theories of consciousness, the Pratyabhijñā's one is also waiting for the jury to reach a verdict.

Appendix: translations

*Vākyapadīya 1.131–135 with Vṛtti*¹

In the world there is no cognition without the pervasion of language.
All knowledge shines as if pierced by language.

(VP 1.131)

[VPVṛ] Just like one has a verbal potentiality in a subtle form, in the same way indeterminate knowledge does not produce any effect, even if it arises in relation to objects that are already known. To explain: even if somebody running has a cognition produced by the touching of grass, earth, etc., that is actually an indeterminate cognitive state. When in that cognitive state the seeds of verbal potentiality becomes predominant and when the semantic powers that are fixed for every meanings are revealed—being such words explainable or not and grasping the content—then the essence of the object, being comprehended and given shape by a kind of knowledge which conforms to the semantic powers, and being pervaded by language, it becomes a content of knowledge, and it is cognized as having a manifested nature. That is to say, it becomes denoted. And this object, if the linguistic seeds become manifested due to another reason, causes memory. According to some teachers, the series of cognitive states of a sleeping person is similar to that of one who is awake. But [in that former case] the seeds of verbal potentiality enjoy a subtle state. This is why they say that this state is obscure, meaning that it is in a condition of darkness. Therefore, consciousness (*saṃjñāna*) constantly experiences manifestation and obscuration because of the existence of transformations in that original nature which is linguistic.

If the eternal linguistic nature of cognitions were to cease, a cognition would not shine, for linguistic nature comes down to self-apprehension.

(VP 1.132)

[VPVṛ] Just as illumination is the essential nature of fire, or consciousness the essential nature of self, in the same way language is inherent in all knowledge. Even in inert conditions, there is a subtle presence of a linguistic factor. The initial cognition, falling on external objects, manifests the objects' essential nature without grasping its features, but it does so in an indeterminate way, as

‘this’ or ‘that’. Also at the moment of recollection—when a verse etc. is to be remembered because the seeds of the original cognition are manifested—a vague notion (*ārūpam*), which simply follows the original cognition, revolves in the mind having the form: “I heard this hymn or that verse”. If a cognition were not by nature linguistic, the vague cognition that has been produced, being unable to contribute to another [cognition], it would not function as a means to the realization of the action of knowing. In fact, once there is a cognition of a bare object, whose different parts are not functional to each other and are mutually independent, immediately after comes a unification, a synthesis, the production of a unitary content, that is, the grasping of conjoined capacities as undifferentiated; all this is connected to the linguistic nature of cognitions. Even in the case of a cognition producing a purposeful action and specified by all qualifications, the linguistic nature of cognitions does not cease to consist in the conjunction of different parts [only] because one makes an abstraction of its capacities.

It is that which ties together all sciences, arts and crafts. It is because of it that all existing reality is differentiated.

(VP 1.133)

[VPVr] Human activity, as far as Vedic and worldly matters are concerned, is generally linked to sciences, arts, and crafts. The activities of all other living beings, moving and unmoving, depend on humans. Sciences depend on an intellect whose essential nature is linguistic. In the making of a pot etc., the effort and the instructions of those who produce something that is to be produced proceed in agreement with the linguistic nature of cognitions.

The linguistic nature of cognitions is the consciousness of all living beings; it exists internally and externally. In no categories of existence consciousness transgresses that [linguistic nature].

(VP 1.134)

[VPVr] On the basis of the fact that a linguistic nature permeates cognitions, one can put forward a distinction between conscious and unconscious. He says:

It is the word which impels living beings towards purposeful actions. If that were to cease all this would be perceived as unconscious, like a piece of wood or a wall.

(VP 1.135)

[VPVr] Those whose have consciousness directed inwards have the awareness of pleasure and pain, as long as there is the presence of language. The worldly activity of those whose consciousness is directed outwards is based on that [language]. Should it be absent, worldly activity will crumble. For there is no category of existence that is not pervaded by consciousness, and in all of them awareness, either of oneself or something else, is never devoid of an association with language. Therefore, there is no cognitive activity in which the power of words is

not encompassed. Some think that the cognitive activity indeed corresponds to its linguistic nature. It has been said:

The word, that encompasses all forms, by manifesting itself in different forms and which is handed down in all sciences, it is the supreme cause of all.

The differentiations of language like cow etc. that never transgress unity, that are brought to the mind through language and are based on it, manifest themselves as differentiated.

Those who worship language as having six doors, six bases, six cognitions, and six eternal overcome death.

Vākyapadīya 3.1.105–106; 109–110 with Helārāja's commentary, Prakīrṇaprakāśa

The universal resides only in the content of a cognition and is subsidiary to cognitions. A cognition is never represented by another form, differently from what happens in the case of its content.

(VP 3.1.105)

[Helārāja] While the content of a cognition is represented, i.e. appears, in the form of a distinct universal, this is not the case for a cognition, which is never represented in the form of a distinct universal, because it is always accompanied by self-consciousness. In fact, the distinguishing mark of the content of a cognition is that its representation takes place through another form, whereas a cognition is dependent on the content but never becomes a content. Still, since a cognition is restricted by its content, we must also accept that there is an ascertainment of identity between them, for the universal which resides in the content of a cognition is not different from cognitions, because the latter are grounded on contents. Now, being unacceptable that cognitions by nature possess differentiation—for they are dependent, insofar as they are determined by something external—such a differentiation must take place on the basis of an external, unitary cause. For example, in the representation of a pot such as ‘this is a pot’, there is an external cause; so even if there is difference [between the cognition and the content], it is right to say that there is a universal contained in that [cognition].

Why then does a cognition not become a content and is it not represented through another form? [Bhartṛhari] explains:

Just as a light is never illuminated by another light, similarly, what has the form of a cognition cannot be apprehended by another cognition.

(VP 3.1.106)

[Helārāja] Just as a lamp that illuminates a pot etc. does not require another lamp to illuminate itself, similarly, a cognition illuminating a content does not require a different cognition to illuminate itself, for its self-luminosity is established. If a cognition were illuminated, it would acquire the nature of an inert thing, for its nature of being an illuminator is what distinguishes it from an inert thing. Furthermore, if at the moment of the cognition of a content the illuminating cognition were lightless, there would be no apprehension of the object at all: if a cognition

were not sentient, the content connected with that cognition could not be established. And [if the cognition is not perceived at the same time of its content] what would be the use of a cognition occurring later in time? In fact, when a manifestation takes place, one could not have a knowledge directed at oneself such as ‘this object has been manifest to me’, since at that very moment, the cognition directed at oneself would be insentient. Therefore, a cognition is self-luminous, and it is not grasped by another cognition, because the property of being a cognizor is absent in a thing that is cognized by something else. Now, since there is no representation of a cognition through another form, the cause of the unitary nature of this [cognition] is the undivided universal that resides in the content only. And it is precisely because of this [universal] that one grasps an identity between an apprehended representation and another cognition. On the contrary, if the appearance of an identity between cognitions were to be explained on the basis of a universal inhering in them, then the notion of an external universal would be really groundless; [but] in fact, the appearance of such an identity is to be explained differently. Being the contents of cognitions different from one another, [in their case] a unitary universal is justified. While in the case of cognitions it is correct to say that they do not have a common feature other than themselves. There is no parallelism with the objects because it has been proven that also this [feature] common to [cognitions] derives from the fact the cognitions are differentiated, insofar as they are determined by their content. So there is no place for universals in the realm of cognitions, because it has been established that the ascertainment of an identity between cognitions depends only on the common form present in the mental representations: so it is [eventually] proven that cognitions have a unitary form, are self-illuminating and do not possess universals. Although the Vaiśeṣikās, too, claim that a universal resides in objects only and is subsidiary to cognitions, they do not hold that cognitions have a unitary form, nor that they are self-illuminating. Nevertheless, we grammarians have another opinion. And, in any case, the view that is put forth here has been acquired through a reliable means of knowledge.

Now one may further object: just as in a cognition such as ‘this is a pot’ one ascertains the pot, in the same way in the cognition ‘this is the cognition of the pot’, a pot is ascertained as well. What is then the difference here? [The difference is that] if a knowledge consisting of the cognition of an object were not perceived, it would not be denoted by language either, because linguistic denotation is preceded by perception. Moreover, a cognition is not able to perceive itself through itself, because this would contradict its own function. But let us suppose that a cognition, because of its conscious nature, illuminate spontaneously the object even if it is unknown. Let us admit that there is a difference to such an extent between this [cognition] and external objects. [In this case the point is that] to know that cognition, another cognition is required. But a series of cognitions is inappropriate as well because ordinary activity is absolutely based on a firm discrimination between cognitions and contents of cognitions and because another cognition is irrelevant. With regard to this, [Bhartrhari] says:

The cognition “this is the cognition of a pot” is different from the cognition of the pot. The cognition of the pot comes down to the external object.

(VP 3.1.109)

[Helārāja] The cognition “this is the cognition of the pot” is a cognition that has the form of a pot and so forth. When it is grasped by another cognition, as when one says: “I had this cognition”, the cognition that is grasping another—namely, that which has a cognition as its object—has features that differ from those of the cognition of a given pot, because it does not arise directly from the object. For only cognitions that are themselves content of a further cognition derive from the object, not the others, which are [in turn] founded on cognitions. The reason is that there is an intervention [of a cognition] between the two. A relationship of ‘apprehender’ and ‘apprehended’ is established due to the force of a similarity. But the cognition of a pot appears in the other [i.e. second-order] cognition as having different properties. Hence, it is not grasped [by the second-order cognition]. Now it might be objected that, due to the continuity (*anusamdhāna*) of the element ‘pot’, the [apprehending] cognition is similar to the [apprehended] one. But then the author says that also “the cognition of the cognition of the pot comes down to the external object”, meaning that it does not come down to cognitions. Therefore, a cognition is never the support of another, for it always shines by itself. This is the meaning of the verse.

Others explain: the cognition that consists in ‘knowing the pot’ is different from the cognition of the pot whose object is the external thing: a cognition which is not engaged with an object and is confined to itself is not conscious. Since the cognition consisting in an object like a pot—which is distinct from the former one and arises from the apprehended thing—is totally subordinated to the apprehended thing and refers to the external object. For if there is no illumination of an object, the existence of a cognition will be groundless. So, even if one thinks in terms of ‘cognition of cognitions’ because there is no difference [between the two cognitions] in terms of awareness, it is nonetheless correct to say that the content of ‘the cognition of a cognition’ is always the external object.

Others explain ‘the cognition of the cognition of a pot’ by saying that its object is not the ‘cognition of a pot’ but that it has a different nature and is devoid of form. For the consciousness-nature of a cognition is not reflected in what is imagined to be its cognition. The relation between apprehender and apprehended is based on similarity. If that were not the case, since there is no distinction in terms of awareness, there would be no rule to determine what is the perception of what. But a cognition, whose content is an external object like a pot, conforms itself to that very object and assumes its form.

Or again [Bhartṛhari] says: “The cognition ‘this is the cognition of the pot’ is different from the cognition of the pot”. What is again the difference between the two? The author says: “The cognition of the pot comes down to the external object”. Even if this cognition is formless, it nonetheless conforms itself to, determines, and ascertains the object in terms of ‘this has such a form’. But the cognition ‘this is the cognition of the pot’ does not conform itself to the nature of the cognition [‘this is a pot’]. In fact, by ascertaining the ‘cognition of the pot’ as a content, [the cognition of the cognition of the pot] can at most ascertain that [the cognition of the pot] is some form of knowledge; yet the conscious nature of [the cognition of the pot] is not reflected in [the cognition of the cognition of the pot], as it happens in the case of the cognition of another person. A cognition is determined by another on the basis of a certain linguistic expression, such as ‘he had the cognition of a pot’, but

this knowledge of another cognition is not manifested for others as it is for oneself, hence the [cognition of the cognition of a pot] is different from the cognition of a pot and does not determine it. Having an apprehending nature, a cognition is manifested by itself and is therefore said to be self-cognizing. It does not illuminate itself as if it were an object, and it is never the object of its own activity.

Now, one may object that an apprehended object is not different from the cognition, and it is apprehended on the basis of a cognition such as ‘this is the knowledge of a pot’. In this way, it is precisely the cognition which is cognized. To remove this doubt, Bhartṛhari says:

For what has the nature of a cognition is not apprehended as having that of an object. Cognition’s own nature is not grasped separately from the object.

(VP 3.1.110)

[Bhartṛhari’s] refutation is valid also if one supports the theory that a cognition is devoid of objects (*nirākāravāda*), for also in that case, there is a cognition that represents another cognition in the form of a content, such as ‘this is the cognition of a pot’. This cognition does not determine the proper nature of the first one in separation from it. Moreover, the manifestation in the form of an apprehended content is not the proper nature of a cognition; it is rather a temporary qualification, just like the colours blue etc. are for a crystal. In addition to this, the subjective aspect of a cognition is not cognized by another cognition as distinct from the objective aspect: due to the pureness of cognition, another cognition is not admissible. Hence, due to the impossibility of having a cognition, if the content is not cognized, even what is supposed to be the ‘cognition of a cognition’ depends on the content. The content exists as the representation, and is established as different from that [representation], just as when one says: ‘this object is known’; this is also the case of a cognition like ‘this is the cognition of blue’ since [that cognition] is rooted in a blue [thing]: a cognition is apprehended as arising from a content.

Things being so—since one cannot grasp the conscious nature [of a cognition] through another cognition—an analysis [of cognitions] in terms of universals different [from cognitions] does not hold. On the contrary, since there is no distinction between the objective aspect [of a cognition] and a cognition, the cause of the comprehension [of the cognition] must be the unitary universal present in the object. Therefore, when there is an objective aspect of a cognition that is identical to the cognition, positing another universal is useless, because this [objective aspect] is grasped by another cognition precisely so [i.e. on the basis of the universal present in the object]. Nor is there a fallacy of mutual dependency: there is in fact a difference of activity, since the universal contained in the object produces a unitary cognition, and the unitary cognition expresses the universal in the object. This is unquestionable. If cognitions are determined as identical without the postulation of a universal, the same does not apply for the objects, since cognitions are indeed determined as identical on the basis of a universal [but] in the way we have just described. One may object: if the cognition aspect is not regarded as different from the objective aspect, [the cognition aspect] cannot be established by itself. This is true: the objective aspect is always experienced in concomitance

with the cognition aspect. Nevertheless, there are [also] objects of pleasures to be enjoyed, which follow (standard cognitions?), which are perceived as having the nature of the seat of the sense of the I, and which have qualities different from those (standard) objects of knowledge that are on the contrary detached from the seat of the sense of the I. On this basis, cognitions are regarded as having a nature distinguished from that of the object: cognitions such as pleasure etc., even when they are grasped through another cognition, they are never cognized. This experience is established, and we have dealt with it more than diffusely. So the universal is established on the basis of a reliable means of knowledge, and when denoted by language, it is capable of accomplishing a linguistic usage that deals with both visible and invisible things. Hence, the existence of the category of universal is proven.²

ĪPK 1.5.11–1.5.19 with Abhinavagupta's ĪPV

They say that the essential nature of a manifestation is reflexive awareness; otherwise light, though coloured by the object, would be an insentient entity, like a mirror and so forth.

(ĪPK 1.5.11)

[Abhinavagupta] If one were to object that in ordinary experience (*iha*), there is an inherent difference between a manifestation which consists of light, and a non-manifestation, which consists of non-light, like a pot etc., because they mutually exclude each other, then it would be very difficult to tell 'this is conscious' and 'this is unconscious', with regard to a pot and a cloth. But if you say that a manifestation is what relates to a content and is therefore conscious, one could reply that even the clay in a pot would count as conscious, it being in relation with the pot. If you say that a manifestation does not consist only in the relation, but it is an illumination of a content, then the conclusion would be that light has the nature of content. But it is not tenable that what illuminates something has a nature that is different from that which it is illuminating. If a pot, though having a different nature, is the cause of the manifestation, then the manifestation too is the cause of the pot, and the pot should be conscious as well. But if you object that the pot, even if it exists independently from the manifestation, [first] generates a reflection which resembles the manifestation, [then] this manifestation assumes that reflection and is said to belong to the pot, thus concluding that the pot is conscious, in that case also a crystal, the water, a mirror, etc. must be conscious, because they are precisely so (i.e. they present a reflected image). But if a pot etc. and a mirror etc. are not able to have a reflexive awareness of themselves as having that nature (i.e. as being affected by the reflection), then they are unconscious. The very essence of consciousness is indeed a reflexive awareness of that kind, in which internal and external senses are unfettered, which is spontaneous, which rests in itself and gaze upon nothing else. When the reflexive awareness 'I alone, as essentially light, shine' arises, then one's own consciousness thinks of itself as the subject, the content and the means of knowledge etc., and does not require anything else. A mirror etc., on the other hand, even when a reflection is present on it, requires a different knower to establish that it possess such a nature; therefore, since it does not have a reflexive awareness, it is

unconscious. Actually, it is always the case that what precedes and follows the [time of external] manifestation is conscious, because it rests on the reflexive awareness of the I, which corresponds to the essential nature of the knowing subject as having self-reflexivity. It has been said: “The attainment of a distinct reflexive awareness ‘this’ is a reflexive awareness that rests on its own very nature, that is, ‘I am that’”. But the realm of *Māyā*, the transmigrating state of unwise people, is precisely that intermediate condition which consists of objectivity and in which what is beyond its extremes is not apprehended. It is therefore established that reflexive awareness is the chief characteristic of the Blessed one. That consciousness primarily consists of reflexive awareness is not only said by us but by other sacred sources too. Utpaladeva shows it with the following verse:

Therefore self is consciousness; it is the activity of being conscious, in the sense of being the subject of such activity; it is because of it that the self is different from an inert entity.

(ĪPK 1.5.12)

Reflexive awareness is indeed the chief characteristic of the self. With the intention to show that that chief characteristic has the nature of a cause, of a motive, the self, though a substance and a property bearer, is put in the same case of the word ‘consciousness’, which expresses a property. It has been taught by the Blessed one in the *Śivasūtra*: “The Self is Consciousness”.

The word ‘consciousness’ indicates a word that expresses the (chief) property of self. The teacher has put the word ‘self’ in the same case of the word expressing a property in the *sūtras*: “the power of consciousness is unchanging”, “that is the ultimate detachment of consciousness”, and “the subject is nothing more than consciousness”. For it is called substance that on which all entities rest and shine and which it is desired for the sake of causal efficiency. And if you do not get angry, all categories, elements, worlds, and transmigrating condition exists as such insofar as they rest on the universal consciousness. And the proper nature of different categories that are themselves the substratum of properties like quality and action rests on the essential nature of that primary substance, universal consciousness, which is the substance [par excellence].

It has been eminently shown that the word *caitanya* expresses the basic property of that universal consciousness, which is the background surface on which the mass of innumerable qualities rest. The word is formed by adding an affix expressing an abstract and indicating relation [to the word *cetana*], formed by adding a *kṛdanta* affix, expressive of agency. Since [a relation] is perceived as resting on two elements and since the nature of substance has been expressed by the base, a different aspect is brought to light by the affix *ṣyañ*, which indicates the basic feature of the word *cetana*, that is, its consisting in the activity of consciousness. And activity in consciousness corresponds to the activity of the subject, to his freedom, which consists of unifying, separating, and coordinating. It consists in not being confined to itself, like an unconscious object, in having as its essential nature unlimited light, in being indifferent to others. And this activity

of consciousness is what distinguishes the self from an unconscious entity, which lacks the freedom to unify, separate, etc. Having that in mind as the supreme and most prominent aspect [of the self, Utpaladeva] could have said: “the self is conscious”, but to play down the other attributes [of self] and to give prominence to the aspect of reflexive awareness, he has said: “self is consciousness”. In the *kārikā*, the expression *citkriyācitikarṭṛtātātparyeṇa* is a single compound. For, the convention whereby the word connecting two half-verses must be contained in a single quarter is valid for poetry but not for technical literature. Otherwise, they may be read separately as follows: “the activity of consciousness and being the subject of this activity are said to be the self”. But this reading is not found anywhere.

Still one may object that ‘light’ and ‘non-light’ are confined to themselves, and therefore it cannot be said that by using the word ‘light’, one indicates something different from the unconscious. In the same way, also ‘reflexive awareness’ and ‘non-reflexive awareness’ are confined to themselves. So, how can there be a distinction between what is conscious and what is unconscious? Having this objection in mind, [Utpaladeva] says:

Consciousness is reflexive awareness, it is the supreme word that arises freely. It is the primary freedom, the sovereignty of the supreme self.

(IPK 1.5.13)

The word *citi* ‘consciousness’ derives from the verbal root *citi* in the expression *cetayati*, ‘to make conscious’; its essential nature is a reflexive awareness characterized by self-savouring. To explain: a pot does not have a self-savouring; it does not have a reflective awareness, and for this reason it does not shine independently; nor is it manifested as having an uninterrupted nature. This is why it is said that [a pot] is unconscious. In contrast, [a person named] Caitra has self-savouring, for he has the power to manifest a tension towards an elevated state, that is, the ‘I’; he possesses reflexive awareness and shines by itself. A limited manifestation—appearing as ‘this’—appears in such a form that it is different from the ‘I’, for it is affected by innumerable [limited] manifestations like blue, yellow, pleasure, pain, their absence, etc. Therefore, it is said that Caitra is conscious. Thus, that both reflexive awareness and non-reflexive awareness are confined to themselves is not at all established, for reflexive awareness is capable of everything: it makes what is different from itself identical and itself a different thing; it brings together both difference and identity and demotes both of them, which were [previously] unified. This is its essential nature. Reflexive awareness’s essential nature is a subtle verbalizing, consisting in inner speech. This ‘subtle verbalizing’ is an uninterrupted spontaneous savouring and is independent from linguistic convention. It is like an internal nodding of the head; it is the life of the conventional sounds that exist at the Māyā level, such as ‘a’ etc., because it is the internal background of self-reflexive cognitions such as ‘this is blue’, ‘I am Caitra’, and so on. Since speech denotes all things through reflexive awareness, [consciousness] is said to be the ‘word’ (*vāc*). [The word] is supreme because of its completeness. Hence,

having a conscious nature and resting on itself, it arises freely, it never declines, it exists permanently as the 'I'. This primary freedom of the supreme self is defined as its freedom, its sovereignty, its supremacy, and its independence from others.

But this [word] exists as supreme and non-supreme [also], at the stage of *paśyantī*, at the level of Sadāśiva. In fact, even if a reflexive awareness existing in terms of 'this' and lacking the knowledge of the self gradually arises, this rests nevertheless on the 'I'. Still, this [word] exists also as non-supreme. Those who are within the realm of Māyā and for which the dimension 'this' is predominant—such as Viṣṇu, Viriñca, and Indra—they gain their sovereignty from the grace of the supreme Lord. Therefore, supreme beatitude, sovereignty, freedom, and consciousness are tantamount to independence from others. Hence, it has been said: "it is different from what is inert". All this has been put forth also in the most eminent scriptures, hence [Utpaladeva] explains:

Consciousness has the nature of luminous vibration, it is the great being, is not qualified by space and time. It is said that this very one is in its essence the heart of the supreme self.

(IPK 1.5. 14)

In ordinary experience, we ask, "Why does a pot exist whereas a sky-flower does not?" People reply, "The pot is evident to me; the other thing is not". Now, if the very nature of a pot comes down to its being manifested, to its being associated with manifestation, then it should be manifest to anybody all the time or to none. Therefore, what is the meaning of 'a pot is evident to me'? It means the pot has entered my luminous vibration, my quivering (*sphurana*). Now vibration is a minimal movement, and here minimality consists in the fact that it appears to move while it is actually motionless, for the essential nature of light does not to change at all but appears to be changing. It is indeed motionless but shines as if it were connected with a variety of manifestations. It has been said that: "The very self, which is essentially consciousness in a state of lysis, when vibrates in all entities, is Siva, whose will flows unimpeded and whose powers of knowledge and action are in operation". And that: "Being extremely angry, or extremely happy, or reflecting on what to do, or running, one could reach that state in which vibration takes place" (Sp. Kā 22). And that "in order to grasp the nature of the vibration" (Sp. Kā 20). And that "the emanations of vibration like the *guṇas* etc." (Sp. Kā 19). In ordinary experience, too, something is said to be like a vibration because of its numerous varieties.

[In the *kārikā*] the word *sattā*, 'being', indicates the essential nature of the subject in the act of being, which is freedom in all actions. Such being is great, since it pervades even the sky-flower. It emits time and space as well as the colour blue etc., and it is therefore not qualified by them. For it can be qualified only by that which shines as equal to it, as bracelets qualify Caitra. Space and time do not shine at the same level of reflexive awareness, for it is untenable that in the case of a cognition, there is equality between space and time on the one hand and reflexive awareness on the other. For the former have the nature of 'this', while the

latter has that of 'I'. Thus, being unaffected by space and time, it is all-pervading and eternal. Still, it is also in contact with all times and places because it creates them. Hence, it permeates everything and is eternal. It has been said: "The great being, the great goddess, is the life of all".

What [in the *kārikā*] is called *sāra*, essence, is that aspect that is not trifle and is indeed the power of reflexive awareness. This power of reflexive awareness illuminates the variety of things which are different from light but also that aspect of subjects and contents of knowledge that consists of light, as it is made clear in the treatise on the blessed essence (i.e. the *Mālinīvijaya*): "The essence of this world is Mālinī, the supreme power".

The expression "this very one" (*saiṣa*) is meant to indicate the recognition of this power. The term *hṛdaya*, heart, means 'resting place' or 'abode'. According to an aforementioned doctrine, the heart is the consciousness of conscious beings because consciousness consists of light, and light has the power of reflexive awareness. In the various authoritative sources in which the heart is said to be of the nature of reflexive awareness and consisting of the supreme mantra, there it is regarded as the abode of the whole universe as it exists at the supreme level. The heart of all things is indeed the mantra, and the mantra is essentially reflexive awareness; the action of reflexive awareness consists in the power of the supreme word. Hence, it has been said in the sacred scriptures: "Without mantras, there is no word, no meaning, and no conscious awareness" and "Those who have attained the state of the Māṭṛika . . .". Also the honourable Bhartṛhari has said: "In the world, there is no cognition without the pervasion of language. All knowledge is acquired as if pierced by language" and "If the eternal linguistic nature of cognition were to cease, a cognition would not shine, for linguistic nature consists of reflexive awareness", and again: "The linguistic nature of cognitions is the consciousness of living beings, it exists internally and externally. If it were to disappear, all this world would be unconscious like a piece of wood or a wall", etc. On this basis, the use of the expression "they say" (in 1.5.11) is finally justified. This interpretation is almost accepted by the Buddhists, too, who claim that the truth of a cognition depends on mental determination. For a mental apprehension consists in language.

One can object: why so much importance is given to this power of reflexive awareness, if Paramaśiva is embellished with a multitude of uncountable powers? To answer this objection, the author says:

Therefore he becomes an object of knowledge, but one which has no independent existence from him. If he only tended towards it, his freedom would be lost.

(ĪPK 1.5.15)

The Lord, having fabricated out of his freedom consisting in non-duality a self that is not devoid of that freedom, through notions like that of Īśa etc., brings ordinary reality into being.

(ĪPK 1.5.16)

All powers amount to the power of agency, whose essential nature is sovereignty. The response is given with the intention to affirm that the power of agency consists in reflexive awareness, whose importance is hence justified. This is the meaning of the words [of the stanza]: the Lord, who is essentially light, transforms himself into a content of knowledge, even if it is not really so, insofar he is a knower and nothing else. This is possible because it has been proved on the basis of a solid inference that another cause is untenable. This is because of the power of agency characterized by reflexive awareness. Since he is reflexive aware and contains all things, he manifests himself so, as the colour blue, etc. One may object: how is it possible that [the supreme self] transforms itself into a content of knowledge? The reply is that an existence which is external and independent from light does not exist as the content of knowledge. The particle *tu* in the stanza expresses emphasis. In this regard, reasons have been already stated. Now the authors provides more reasons. If the content of knowledge existed independently, that is, as detached from the self of the knower, that tension toward the object which is commonly experienced and which is self-evident would not be possible. For if this tension is applied to a content of knowledge that is different from the subject, then the latter would rely on another thing and hence would be dependent. But being dependent is opposed to being free. Freedom, which is the essential nature of the self, consists in not looking at anyone else. Therefore, a self who tended towards a content which is different from itself would be no self at all. The unwanted consequence of this is that an unconscious non-self would not be able to have any tension towards a content of knowledge. Therefore, from the opposite conclusion, the following is obtained: the self, being free and tending towards something which is not detached from itself, actually renders himself as a content of knowledge.

Contents of knowledge are not just the colour blue, etc. Having created a limited self which is not devoid of freedom and whose nature of subject is preserved, [supreme consciousness] endows it with ordinary capacities like those of meditating, worshipping, praising, teaching, etc. This is brought into being on the basis of what has been said in the previous verse. One may object: this limited self is free but at the same time is created; is that not contradictory? The answer is that the objection is unsound because of the freedom of the unitary consciousness which “consists in non-duality”. What appears really difficult to achieve at the level of Māyā, it is something an unobstructed freedom is actually capable to realize; this is shown by the use of the word ‘freedom’ in the verse. The word ‘therefore’ (*ata eva*) indicates the nature of the power of reflexive awareness, so it is not repeated [without reason]. Alternatively, one can read the expression as “because of this very freedom”, being thus in connection with both verses and having the same reference. In this regard, the author gives the following example. The creation of a self which is not devoid of freedom is not established in ordinary reality, as it is that of the colour blue, etc. Still, since to those who know, worship, or meditate on the fact that Īśvara is the blessed Lord, the self, eternal, all-pervading, and free, the content of knowledge, worship, or meditation appears as undifferentiated. It is therefore created but not as different from Īśvara. For if it were so, volition,

meditation, etc., directed to Īśvara and non-Īśvara, were the same. But they are not the same because [from the volitions, meditation, etc. on Īśvara and non-Īśvara] one gets different results. Hence, Parameśvara manifests itself as both types of contents of knowledge: shining as devoid of freedom and shining as endowed with it. This is due to the power of reflexive awareness which is therefore the most important among powers of the Lord.

One can raise the following objection: the existence of objects that are mutually distinguished is due to light, and light is in essence reflexive awareness. Since there is no difference between light and reflexive awareness, it is right to say that this 'reflexive awareness is that light'. But the reflective awareness of what is created as in the case of notions like the 'lord is the self, etc.', has an objective nature, while freedom consists in subjective reflexive awareness. Then if what is fabricated lacks the nature of subjective reflexive awareness, how can it be "not devoid of freedom"? To refute this objection, [Utpaladeva] says:

The existence of various notions like that of "I" etc., does not imply differentiation in the nature of self, because this is produced in so far as it the content of the reflexive awareness "I". Just like verbal action is expressed by personal endings.

(ĪPK 1.5.17)

The abstract suffix [in the word *ahantā*] indicates its essential nature. The word "etc." stands for the notions of 'self', 'lord' and so on. The expression "personal endings" alludes to the affixes that convey verbal action. The word "action" alludes to what has the nature of power and it is not a substance. The meaning of the verse is the following: the reflexive awareness which consists in the 'I' assumes the forms of 'knower', 'self', 'Śiva', and so forth. Although this appears as having a mutual differentiation, it is nonetheless wrong to suppose that on the basis of that differentiation, there is a difference between the self—which is the cause, the creator, and whose nature consists in subjective reflexive awareness, and the notions of Īśvara, etc. For even the notion of Īśvara reposes on that which has the nature of the Lord and whose essence is knowing and doing. Being a knower etc. means freedom, independence from others, capacity of unrestricted knowledge; this un-restrictedness reposes on the awareness of the 'I', as [in the sentences] 'I know' and 'I do'. Hence, this self is produced, emitted as the content of subjective reflexive awareness. Or in the stanza the word *sṛṣteḥ*, 'produced', can be taken as an ablative of cause, meaning that this Lord produces what is capable of subjective reflexive awareness also in the forms of Īśvara etc. In the word *mṛśya*, the affix *ya* conveys the notion of fitness.³ The meanings of notions like 'action', 'factor of action', 'coordination', 'option', etc. are understood through the use of personal endings, instrumental case, and particles like *ca* and *vā*. Even when a noun form is attributed to them, as in the case of words like 'cooking', 'doer', 'coordination', and 'option', they nevertheless repose on a fundamental awareness that correspond to expressions like 'he cooks', Caitra, *ca*, and *vā*. If it were not so, these would not be understood. This is what we have said: the

word 'reflexive awareness' indicates the place of repose. This culminating place is truly real and consists in the 'I'. The intermediate place of repose is, on the other hand, like the root of a tree when one is proceeding towards a village; it is said to arise in dependence to that [culminating place], so where is the contradiction? All this shows that even if in regard to blue things, the expression 'this is blue' is an intermediate type of awareness, it is indeed equal to the fundamental awareness, because both repose on the 'I'. For the awareness 'I know a blue object' is tantamount to 'I shine', as it has been said "of the consciousness 'this', etc. However, since a confused person is illusorily satisfied when the awareness of 'blue', etc. has a practical utility, it has been said that blue, etc. are devoid of freedom. But as far as the self, etc. are concerned, even a confused person does not believe he can attain completion and practical utility without reposing in that fundamental awareness. And for this very reason, the freedom of self is not diminished even if it is created.

One may put forth the following objection: if the nature of the Lord consists in reposing in a unitary, pure awareness of all cognitions, how can one say that he has the powers of knowledge, memory, etc., that knowledge is differentiated into doubt, ascertainment, etc. and that there is variety of objects like blue, etc.? To overcome the objection, [Utpaladeva] says:

Due to that power of Māyā that belongs to the Lord, this [consciousness] enters the realm of cognizable, differentiated objects and it is called by the names of cognition, volition, determination etc.

(ĪPK 1.5.18)

We define Māyā as a manifestation that cannot be accounted for rationally. Māyā is therefore the entire spectrum of manifestations that differ from light. In this regard, the power of Māyā is the freedom that pertains only to the one who is by nature conscious. The realm, the place of repose of a consciousness that is essentially reflexive awareness, whose nature is that of the supreme word, and which is said to be 'cognition', 'volition', or 'determination', that realm is that of [objects] that are cognized as reciprocally separated and separated from the knower and that which that is cognized through senses that are different from their content, from the knower and from one another. In the stanza, the word "etc." indicates doubt, memory, etc. To explain: perception is consciousness limited by the sense grasping what is there and by a tangible external object; imagination is consciousness limited by the mind and by a content which is not tangible; determination or ascertainment is consciousness limited by the intellect and by the object in its entirety. The differentiation between the content and the external and internal senses is unjustified because there is no difference in the light revealing them, so the differentiation is manifested by consciousness. Now, since unity reposes in differentiation but differentiation does not repose in unity, as in the case of Īśvara, Sadāśiva, etc., the various notions of cognition, imagination, etc. are said to be the power of that coordinator, whose essence is consciousness and whose unitary essential nature never fails. This implies different notions

like that of doubt, etc. and a variety of objects like ‘blue’, etc. All this cannot be dismissed.

One might put forward the following objection: let us admit that consciousness’s self-awareness is present in the case of those capacities [of the Self] such as will, memory, etc., which are conceptual. But in that power [that we call] perception, which is defined by immediacy and has a non-conceptual nature, how can self-awareness be present? For reflexive awareness consists in the usage of a specific linguistic expression, and such a usage requires the recollection of a linguistic convention. This recollection is based on the reawakening of mental traces, and this, in turn, on similar [previous] cognitions. So, how can a linguistic expression be applied at the first moment [of cognition]?

There is self-awareness even in the case of immediate cognitions, otherwise how can running etc. be possible, if [these activities] are conceived as lacking a dynamic unification?

(ĪPK 1.5.19)

[Abhinavagupta] To begin with, in this world, the association with language is the chief characteristic of consciousness, in a way that is comparable to the indication of something with a finger, etc. Otherwise a child would not develop a linguistic usage when he sees a human activity for the first time. In fact, a child first hears the word in the form of a series of non-conceptual cognitions, then he sees the object [of the word] before his eyes, and after that he sees a surface in which the object is no more present. On hearing linguistic expressions such as “bring the pot” or “carry the pot”, how can in the heart of the child shine the idea “this is the meaning of that”, namely this is the meaning of the word “pot”, this is the meaning of the word “bring” and of the word “carry”? Because to say that this object is the meaning [of that word] is essentially an act of unification, and unification is a conceptual activity. If one were to object that the unification is due to the fact that a child recalls the linguistic convention she acquired in previous lives, we reply that this word at the time of the [acquisition] of the convention, after having abandoned the differentiation that derives from the word being thought as an object, as ‘this’, then it rests on the intellect shining. It is only when it exists as such that the word becomes expressive. If the essential nature of the intellect is that on which the word rests, then the intellect itself consists of ‘languageing’. Just as an object is not intrinsically pleasant but the intellect shines as consisting of pleasure, in the same way, we maintain that a form etc. is not intrinsically linguistic but that the intellect will shine as ‘languageing’.

Still here, in this system, we also believe that the object itself is actually ‘languageing’, because it is of the nature of self-awareness. If conditions like stillness, etc. did not consist in reflexive awareness, then their existence would be tantamount to a curse, because there would be no conceptual activity of the subject with regard to them and no memory of it as well; for if a conceptual activity were to arise directed at ascertaining the form [in stillness etc.], what else can we say except that there is no ‘stillness’, because conceptualization binds

together all things? Therefore, even in the case of ‘stillness’, there is an internal self-awareness. Objects support languageing by means of all words, but at the moment of convention, one associates an object with a specific word. To explain: a child has an innate reflexive awareness of an object in front of it either in terms of identity, as the “I” or in terms of difference, as “this”. On top [of these two cognitions] words such as ‘pale’ or ‘cow’ are imposed. Also, this word becomes, through repeated usage, one with the knowing subject; then, on top of the words “pale” and “cow”, the words “white” and “bull” are respectively imposed. This is the essential nature of linguistic convention. Therefore, reflexive awareness is present in the case of immediate cognitions. The word “also”, used above, has this meaning: an immediate cognition truly finds its completion in an act of conceptualization like the one conveyed by the expression “I see”. For even others think that conceptual knowledge is a function of perception. And it is not right to distinguish a function from that which possesses that very function, for they have the same nature. Even admitting that an immediate cognition has a momentary nature, in that, too, there is reflexive awareness. This is necessary and is the reason why Utpaladeva says “how otherwise”? In fact, if it were not so [i.e. if there were no reflexive awareness in the case of immediate cognitions], then a person proceeding rapidly with a specific purpose, or reciting letters quickly, or reading fast a book of mantras, would not reach, pronounce, or recite what she has in mind. To explain: how can one reach the place she has in mind without a reflexive awareness, whose essential aspect are unification and separation, and consists in the knowledge of the place, the will to proceed, the actual proceeding, the awareness of the movement, the unification of another purpose, the desire to leave, the knowledge of a different place, the desire to proceed towards it, and so forth? The same applies to reading quickly, speaking, etc. Specifically, in these cases, there is a union between places and organs of articulation etc. Since [here] one does not experience a gross conceptual cognition, there is quickness. Therefore, there must be a subtle reflexive awareness consisting in the verbal potentiality in its contracted form, because a gross conceptual cognition is precisely a verbal potentiality that has become visible by expansion, for example, the expansion of “this” is “pot”, “white”, etc. The expansion of a pot is “having the form of a big belly” or “permeated by the quality white which is connected with the universal “whiteness”. The root *dhāv* may mean both ‘to clean’ and ‘to go’ but here means ‘to go quickly’ because of its own expressive power.⁴

Notes

- 1 *na so 'sti pratyayo loke yaḥ śabdānugamād rte / anuviddham iva jñānaṃ sarvaṃ śabdeṇa bhāsate* // (1.131).

[VPVṛ] *yathāsya saṃhṛtarūpā śabdabhāvanā tathā jñeyeṣv artheṣūtpannenāpy avikalpena jñānena kāryaṃ na kriyate. tad yathā tvaritaṃ gacchataḥ tṛṇaloṣṭādisaṃsparśāt saty apī jñāne kācid eva sā jñānāvasthā, yasyām abhimukhībhiḥśabdabhāvanābījā yām āvirbhūtāsv arthopagrāhiṇām ākhyeyarūpāṇām anākhyeyarūpāṇām ca śabdānām pratyarthaniyatāsu śaktiṣu śabdānuviddhena śaktyanupātina jñānenākriyamāṇa upagrhyamāṇo vastv ātmā jñānānugato vyaktarūpapratyavabhāso jñāyata ity abhidhiyate.*

sa ca nimittāntarād āvirbhavātsu śrutibhīṣu smṛtihetur bhavati. tathaikeṣāṃ ācāryāṇāṃ suptasyāpi jāgradvṛtityā sadṛśo jñānavṛttiprabandhaḥ. kevalaṃ tu śabdabhāvanābhījāni tadā sūkṣmāṃ vṛttim pratilabhante. tasmāt tāmasīm ceti tāmavasthām āhuḥ. tadetat saṃjñānaṃ śabdaprakṛtīvikārabhāvenāvirbhāvatirobhāvāv ajasraṃ pratyānubhavati.

vāgrūpatā ced utkrāmed avabodhasya śāśvatī / na prakāśaḥ prakāśeta sā hi pratyavamarśinī // (VP 1.132).

[VPVṛ] yathā prakāśakatvam agneḥ svarūpaṃ caitanyaṃ vāntaryāmiṇaḥ, tathā jñānaṃ api sarvaṃ vāgrūpamātrānugatam. yāpy asañcetitāvasthā tasyām api sūkṣmo vāgdharmānugamo 'bhyāvartate. yo 'pi prathamopanipātī bāhyeṣv artheṣu prakāśaḥ sa nimittānāṃ aparigraheṇa vastusvarūpamātram idaṃ tadityavyapadeśayā vṛtityā pratyavabhāsayati. smṛtikāle 'pi tādrśānāṃ upalabdhibhījānāṃ ābhimukhye smartavyeṣu ślokaḍiṣu prakāśānugamamātrarūpam iva buddhau viparivartate. ko 'py asāv anuvākaḥ śloko vā yo 'yaṃ mayā śrutimātreṇa prakrānta iti. vāgrūpatāyām cāsatyām utpanno 'pi prakāśaḥ pararūpam anaṅgīkurvan prakāśanakriyāsadhanarūpatāyām na vyavatiṣṭhate. bhinnarūpānāṃ cānupakāriṇāṃ ātmāntarānatmanāṃ itaretarasya vastumātrājñāne pratyavabhāsamāne yad uttarakālam anusamdhānaṃ pratyavamarśa ekārthakāritvavibhāgena śaktisaṃsargayogopagrahaḥ, tadā vāgrūpatāyām baddham. sā hy anusamdhānā pratyavamarśantī ca sarvaviśeṣaṇaviśiṣṭe 'pyarthakriyākāriṇī pratyaye śaktyapoddhārakalpanayā bhedasamṣargamātrām na vijahāti.

sā sarvavidyāśilpānāṃ kalānāṃ copabandhanī / tadvaśād abhiniṣpannaṃ sarvaṃ vastu vibhajyate (VP 1.133).

vidyāśilpakalādibhir laukikeṣu vaidikeṣu cārtheṣu manuṣyāṇāṃ prāyeṇa vyavahāraḥ pratibaddhaḥ. manuṣyādhiṇāś cetarasya bhūtagrāmasya sthāvarajaṅgamasya pratrityaḥ. vidyādayaś ca vāgrūpāyām buddhau nibaddhāḥ. ghaṭādīnāṃ cābhiniṣpādane prayojyaprayojakānāṃ upadeśasamīhādi sarvaṃ vāgrūpatānusāreṇa prakalpate.

saiśā saṃsāriṇāṃ saṃjñā bahirantaśca vartate / tanmātrāmapyatīkrāntaṃ caitanyaṃ sarvajātiṣu // (VP 1.134).

yo 'yaṃ caitanye vāgrūpatānugamas tena loka sasamjño visamjña iti vyapadeśaḥ kriyate / evaṃ hy āha.

arthakriyāsu vāk sarvān samīhayati dehinaḥ / tadutkrāntau visamjño 'yaṃ drśyate kākṣṭhakuḍyavat // (VP 1.135).

antahsaṃjñānāṃ api sukhaduḥkhasaṃvinmātrā yāvad vāgrūpatānuvṛttis tāvad eva bhavati. bahiḥsaṃjñeṣu tannibandhano lokavyavahāras tadabhāvān niyatam utsīdet. na hī sā cetanyenānāviṣṭā jātir asti, yasyām svaparasambodho yo vācā nānugamyate. tasmāc citikriyārūpam alabdhavākśaktiparigrahaṃ na

vidyate. vāktatvarūpam eva citikriyārūpam ity anye. tathāha:

bhedodgrāhavivartena labdhākāraparigrahā /

āmnātā sarvavidyāsu vāg eva prakṛtiḥ parā //

ekatvam anatikrāntā vānnetrā vānnibandhanāḥ /

prthak pratyavabhāśante vāgvibāgā gavādayaḥ //

śaḍdvārām śaḍadhiṣṭhānām śaṭprabodhām śaḍavyayām /

te mṛtyum ativartante ye vai vācam upāsate //

- 2 jñeyastham eva sāmānyam jñānānāṃ upakārakam / na jātu jñeyavaj jñānaṃ pararūpeṇa rūpyate // (VP 3.1.105).

[Helārāja] yathā jñeyam vyatiriktasāmānyarūpeṇa rūpyate, rūpavat kriyate, naivaṃ jñānaṃ saṃvidātmasamavetena vyatiriktasāmānyarūpeṇa rūpyate. jñeyadharmāḥ kilāyaṃ yat pararūpeṇa rūpaṇam. jñānaṃ tu [a*]svatantraṃ jñeyam eva na bhavati. jñeyaniṣṭhatayā hi jñānānāṃ jñeyasthasya sāmānyasyābhedenā tadabhedāvasāyaḥ pratyarthaniyatatve 'py upapadyate. bāhyaparavaśatvenāsvādhīnatvāj jñānānāṃ svata eva vaikalkaṇyānupapatteḥ bahir abhinnena nimittena tatra bhāvyam. tadyathā ghaṭo ghaṭa iti ghaṭākāre bāhyaṃ nimittaṃ tathā bhede 'pi tadgataṃ sāmānyam iti yuktam.

katham pūrvajñānaṃ jñeyam na bhavatīti pararūpeṇa na rūpyata ity āh:

yathā jyotiḥ prakāśena nānyenābhiprakāśyate / jñānākāras tathānyena na jñānenopagṛhyate // (VP 3.1.106).

[Helārāja] *yathā ghaṭādīnām dīpaḥ prakāśakah svaprakāśe dīpāntaram nāpekṣate tathārthasya prakāśakaṃ jñānam ātmaprakāśanāya prakāśāntarānapekṣam iti svaprakāśakaṃ siddham. jaḍavailakṣaṇyaṃ hi prakāśakatvam iti tasyāpi prakāśyatve jaḍatāpattiḥ. arthaprakāśakāle ca prakāśakasyāprakāśe 'rthasaṃvedanam eva na syāt. prakāśasañcetanā tallagnārthasañcetanāsiddheḥ. uttarakālaṃ tu vedanaṃ kvopayogi. utpannāyāṃ ca prakāṭatāyāṃ ātmasamavetasya tadānīm jñānasyāsañcetanān mama prakāṭito 'rtha ity ātmagāmi saṃvedanaṃ na syāt. tasmāi [Iyer: tasyāj*] jñānāntareṇa svaprakāśakaṃ jñānam na grhyate paraprakāśyatve prakāśakatvābhāvād iti tadākārasya pareṇa rūpeṇābhāvāj jñeyastham evābhinnam sāmānyam asyābhedanimittam. tadvaśād asya grāhyākārasya jñānāntareṇābhedagrahaṇāt. svasamavetasāmanyavaśena tv abhedapratibhāse bahiḥ sāmānyaparikalpo niribandhana eva syāt. anyathaivābhed apratibhāśasyopapattē. arthānām tu vyatiriktatvād abhinnaṃ sāmānyam upapadyate. jñānānām tu sāmānyākāro na vyatirikta iti nābhinna upapadyate. pratyarthaniyatatvena teṣāṃ bhedāt tadabhinnaṃ tasyāpi tathātvopapatter iti nārthaiḥ sāmyam asti. buddhyākārāṇām ākārasāmyād eva ca jñānānām abhedāvasāyasiddher na saṃvedanabhāge 'pi sāmānyayoga iti sākārāḥ svaprakāśāḥ niḥsāmānyā buddhayaḥ siddhāḥ. yady api ca vaiśeṣikā jñeyastham eva sāmānyam jñānānām upakārakam icchanto na sākāram nāpi svaprakāśam vijñānam icchanti, tathāpi na vyaṃ darśanāntaraprakriyāṃ brūmah. api tu yatpramāṇopapannam itīdam atra darśanam upakṣiptam.*

nanu ca yathā ghaṭo 'yam iti jñāne ghaṭo 'vasīyate tathā ghaṭajñānam etad iti jñāne ghaṭajñānam. ko hy atra viśeṣa? yadi tu viśayasaṃvedanarupā buddhir nānubhūyeta śabdenāpi tathā nābhidhīyeta, anubhavapūrvakatvād abhidhānasya. na cātmanā ātmānam anubhavati buddhiḥ, svātmāni vyāpāravirodhāt. bodharūpatvāt tu svayam ajñātaivārtham avabhāsayatu. etāvān asya bāhyād viśeṣo 'stu. tadbubhutsāyāṃ tu buddhyantaram evāpekṣyam. jñānajñeyasiddhimātrāniṣṭhatvāc ca vyavahārasya pratyayāntarānapekṣaṇād buddhimālāpi nānuśajyata ityāha:

ghaṭajñānam iti jñānam ghaṭajñānavilakṣaṇam / ghaṭa ity api yaj jñānam viśayopanipāti tat // (VP 3.1.109).

[Helārāja] *ghaṭajñānam iti jñānam ghaṭādyākāram jñānam yadā jñānāntareṇa parāmṛśyate evaṃ mamātrānubhavo bhūta iti pratyaya viśayaṃ yat parāmārsājñānam tad ghaṭajñānād bhinnalakṣaṇam sāksād viśayenājñānitatvāt. anukāryapratyayā eva hi viśayena janyante nānye jñānālambanāḥ, vyavadhānāt, sārūpyabālena ca grāhyagrāhakabhāvaḥ [Iyer: *bhāvena]. vaidharmyena na ca ghaṭajñānam jñānāntare pratibhāśate. ato na tad grhyate. athocyate, sarūpam eva tajñānam ghaṭa ity evaṃ anusaṃdhānād ity āha, ghāta ity api yaj jñānam viśayopanipāti tat. na tu jñāne upanipatati. ato na buddhir buddhim ālambate, svayam eva tu prakāśata ity arthaḥ. anye vyācakṣate, ghaṭajñānād bāhyaviśayāt ghaṭajñānam iti evaṃ jñānam bhinnam na viśayāpraviṣṭam [Iyer: viśayapraṣṭam] svātmavyavasthitam jñānam sañcetyate, yasmād ghaṭa ityevamākāram yad vicchinnaṃ grāhyaprasṛtaṃ tad api viśayam anupatati grāhyaparavaśam. viśayāprakāśena jñānastitāyā evānibandhanatvāt. evaṃ ca bodhatvāviśeṣāt yady api jñānajñānam iti mataṃ tad api bāhyaviśayam evety uktam bhavati. anye tu vyācakṣate ghaṭajñānam iti jñānam viśayo yasya tad ghaṭajñānavilakṣaṇam, anevaṃsarūpam [Iyer: evaṃsarūpam] anākāram. na hi sāmavidākāras tajñānābhimate pratibimbībhavati. sārūpyavaśena grāhyagrāhakabhāvaḥ. anyathā jñānatvāviśeṣād idam asya saṃvedanam iti pratinīyamo na syāt. ghaṭo iti tu yad etad bāhyaviśayaṃ jñānam tad viśayopanipāti viśayākāram upādatte. atha vā ghaṭajñānam iti jñānam ghaṭajñānavilakṣaṇam. kim tadvailakṣaṇyaṃ ity āha ghaṭa ity api yaj jñānam viśayopanipāti tat. nirākāram api tad viśayam anupatati paricchinatti nirūpayaty evaṃrūpo 'yam artha ity. ghaṭajñānam iti tu jñānam na jñānarūpānupāti, yato ghaṭajñānagatam viśayam nirūpya, jñānarūpam kim api tad ity etāvad yadi paraṃ nirūpayitum śaknoti, na tu sā tadīyā bodharūpatā tasya pratibhāśate, parasamvedana iva. pareṇa hi ghaṭajñānam asyotpannam iti kayācid yuktyā jñānam paricchidyate, na tu svavatparasya pratibhāśate iti tato vilakṣaṇam*

na tasya paricchedakam. upalambhātmakatvāt svayaṃ prakāśata iti svasaṃvedanaṃ jñānam ucyate. na tv ātmānam artham iva prakāśayātīti na svātmāny asya kaścīd vyāpārah.

nanu jñānasya grāhyākāro na vyatiriktaḥ, sa ca ghaṭajñānam iti jñānena saṃvedyata iti buddhir eva saṃveditā bhavātīty āśaṅkyāha:

yato viśayarūpeṇa jñānarūpaṃ na grhyate / artharūpaviviktaṃ ca svarūpaṃ nāvadhāryate // (VP 3.1.110).

[Helārāja] nirākāravāde 'py ayam parihāro lagati, yatas tatrāpi ghaṭajñānam etad iti grāhyasvabhāvena jñānam jñānantaram upalakṣayati, na tadrāhitam ātmattvaṃ tasyāvadhārayati. na ca grāhyākāro jñānasvarūpaṃ, aupādhikatvāt. yathā sphaṭikasya nīlādi. na ca grāhyākāraviviktaṃ grāhakarūpaṃ jñānantareṇopalakṣyate śuddhabuddhyanukāreṇa buddhyantarānupapatteḥ. evaṃ ca viśayāprakāśane jñānatvāyogāt jñānajñānābhimatam api viśayaniśiṣṭham eva. tathā copasarjanena viśaya eva tena viśiṣṭo 'vasthāpyate jñāto 'yam artha iti. nīlajñānam ity etad api nīlanīśiṣṭatayā viśayaprabhavaṃ jñānam parāmrśyate. evaṃ ca kṛtvā saṃvidākkāryasya jñānantareṇāgrahaṇān na vyatiriktasāmānyarūpeṇa nirūpaṇam. grāhyākāryasya tu jñānantareṇābhedenā grahaṇam jñeyastābhinnasāmānyanimittam, tena tasya grāhyākāryāvīlakṣaṇasya janane tathaiva buddhyantareṇa grahaṇād iti na tatra sāmānyāntaram upayujyate. nāpītaretarāśrayadoṣaḥ. jñeyasāmānyasyābhinnajñānaj anakatvenābhinnajñānasya ca jñeyatāpratipādakatvena vyāpārabhedāt. tenaitad aco-dyam. yathā vinaiva sāmānyam abhedāvasāyo buddhīnām evam arthānām api [na?] bhaviṣyātīti buddhīnām api sāmānyavaśenaivoktaprakāreṇābhedāvasāyāt iti. nanu yadi jñānarūpaṃ artharūpaviviktaṃ nāvadhāryate svato 'py asya siddhir na syāt? satyam. sarvadaiva grāhyākāraḥ sahabhāvyanubhūyate 'sya, kiṃ tu tatprsthābhāvino hlādanīyaprakrāmā ahaṃkāraśpadavicchinna-grāhyākāravīdharmāṇa uttararūpā ahaṃkāraśpadatayā saṃcetyanta iti svatas tadviviktārūpāvadhāraṇam asti buddhīnām. jñānantareṇa tu hlādādayo grhyamānā api tathā na saṃvedyanta iti anubhavasiddham etad anapahnavaṇīyam ity alam ativistareṇa.

3 See A 3.3.169 arhe kṛtyatṛaśca.

4 svabhāvam avabhāśasya vimarśam vidur anyathā / prakāśo 'arthoparakto 'pi sphaṭi-kādiyaḍopamaḥ // (ĪPK 1.5.11).

[Abhinavagupta] iha avabhāśasya prakāśasya, anavabhāśasya ca aprakāśasya ghaṭādēḥ parāsparparāhāreṇa dvayoḥ svātmāni cet vyavasthānam, tat ghaṭapaṭayoḥ iva idam ajaḍam idaṃ jaḍam iti durupapādam vailakṣyaṇam. atha avabhāso yato 'rthasya saṃbandhī, tato na jadaḥ, tarhi saṃbandhamātreṇa mṛt api ghaṭasya iti ajaḍā syāt. atha na svasaṃbandhamātram api tu avabhāso 'rthasya prakāśaḥ, tarhi arthātmanā sa prakāśa iti samāpatitam. na ca anyātmanā anyasya prakāśa upapannaḥ. atha anyasvabhāvo 'pi ghaṭo 'vabhāśasya kāraṇam, tarhi avabhāso 'pi ghaṭasya kāraṇam iti ghaṭo 'pi ajaḍaḥ syāt. atha anyena satāpi ghaṭena yato 'vabhāśasya pratibimbarūpā cchāyā dattā, tām asau avabhāso bibhṛat ghaṭasya iti ucyate, tatas ca ajaḍaḥ, tarhi sphaṭikasalilamakurādiḥ api evambhūta eva iti ajaḍa eva syāt. atha tathābhūtam api ātmānam taṃ ca ghaṭādikam sphaṭikādiḥ na parāmrāṣṭum samartha iti jaḍaḥ, tathāparāmarśanam eva ajāḍyajīvitam antarbahīṣkaraṇasvātantrīyarūpaṃ svābhāvīkam avabhāśasya svātmaviśrāntīlakṣaṇam ananyamukhaprekṣitvaṃ nāma. aham evaṃ prakāśātmā prakāśe iti hi vimarśodaye svasaṃvid eva pramāṭṛprameyapramāṇādi kṛtārtham abhimanyate na tu atiriktaṃ kāṅkṣati, sphaṭikādi hi grhītapratibimbam api tathābhāvena siddhau pramātrantaram apekṣate iti nirvimarśatvāt jaḍam. sar-vatra vastuto vimarśātmaka—pramāṭṛ—svabhāva—tādātmyāhaṃparāmarśaviśrāntēḥ ajaḍatvam eva pūrvāparakoṭyoḥ. yad uktam: 'idam ity asya vicchinnavimarśasya kṛtārthatā / yā svasvarūpe viśrāntir vimarśaḥ so 'ham ity ayam iti //'.
madhyāvasaṭhaiva tu idantāvimṛśyamānapūrvāparakoṭiḥ vimūḍhānām māyāpadaṃ saṃsārāḥ iti vimarśa eva pradhānam bhagavata iti sthitam.

na kevalam saṃvit tattvasya asmābhiḥ eva vimarśapradhānyam uktaṃ yāvat āgamāntarair api iti darśayati.

ātmāta eva caitanyam citikriyācitikartṛtā / tātparityeṇoditastena jaḍāt sa hi vilakṣaṇaḥ // (ĪPK 1.5.12).

[Abhinavagupta] yato vimarśa eva pradhānam ātmano rūpam amum eva hetum prayojanarūpam uddiśya ātmā dharmisvabhāvo dravyabhūto 'pi, caitanyam iti dharmavācinā śabdena sāmānādhikaranyam

āśṛitya uditāḥ kathitāḥ, bhagavatā śivasūtreṣu 'caitanyam ātmā' iti paṭhitam. caitanyam iti hi dharmavācākopalakṣaṇam, 'citiśaktir aparīṇāmini' '... taddṛṣeḥ kaivalyam'. 'draṣṭā dṛṣimātraḥ'... 'ityāḍau api hi dharmāśabdena sāmānādhikaranyam ātmano darśitam guruṇā anantena. dravyam hi tat ucyate yadvīśrāntaḥ padārthavargaḥ sarvo bhāti ca arthyate ca arthakriyāyai, tad yadi na kupyate tat sakalo 'yaṁ

tattvabhūtabhāvabhuvanasaṁbhāraḥ saṁvidi vīśrāntaḥ tathā bhavati iti sa eva guṇa karmādidharmāśrayabhūtapadārthāntarasvabhāvaḥ tām eva

mukhyadravyasvarūpām āśrayate iti saiva dravyam. tat anantadharmāśīviśr amabhittibhūtyāḥ tasyāḥ sa eva dharmāḥ caitanyam iti kartṛkṛdantāt utpannena bhāvapratyayena

saṁbandhābhidhāyiniāpi prādhānyena darśitāḥ. tathā hi saṁbandhivīśrāntasya pratīteḥ, dravyarūpasya ca saṁbandhinaḥ prakṛtyā uktatvāt citikriyārūpam dharmam saṁbaddham avagamayatā śyañā niṣkṛṣṭāmsaḥ pratyāyito bhavati. citikriyā ca citau kartṛtā, svātantryam saṁyojanaviyojanānusaṁdhānādirūpam

ātmamātrātāyām eva jaḍavat aviśrāntatvam aparicchinnaprakāśasāratvam ananyamukhāprekṣitvam iti. tad eva anātmārūpāt jaḍāt saṁyojanaviyojanādisvātantrya vikalāt vilakṣaṇyādāyī iti. tad evaṁ paratvena pradhānatayā abhisaṁdhāya ātmā cetana iti vaktavye dharmāntarādhārīkaraṇāya vimarśadharmoddhurīkaraṇāya ca 'ātmā caitanyam' ity uktam. citikriyācitikartṛtātātparityeṇa iti samāsaḥ. ardhayuk pādaviśrāntiḥ iti hi kāvyē samayaḥ, na śāstre. yadi vā citikriyā ātmā uditāḥ citikartṛtā ca iti prthag eva. evaṁ tu na kvacit paṭhitam.

nanu yathā prakāśo 'prakāśaś ca iti ubhayam api svātmani, tataś ca prakāśa ity ukte jaḍāt na vilakṣaṇyam uditam syāt, tadvat vimarśo 'pi avimarśo 'pi ca svātmani, iti tenāpi katham vilakṣaṇyam jaḍājaḍayoḥ ityāśaṅkyāha.

citiḥ pratyavamarśātmā parā vāksvarasoditā / svātantryam etan mukhyam tadaiśvryam paramātmanaḥ // (ĪPK 1.5.13).

[Abhinavagupta] cetayati ity atra yā citiḥ citikriyā tasyāḥ pratyavamarśaḥ svātmacamatkāralakṣaṇa ātmā svabhāvaḥ. tathā hi, ghaṭena svātmani na camatkriyate, svātmā na parāmṛśyate, na svātmani tena prakāśyate, na aparicchinnatayā

bhāsyate, tato na cetayata iti ucyate. caitreṇa tu svātmani aham iti saṁrambhodyogollāsavibhūtiyogāt camatkriyate, svātmā parāmṛśyate, svātmany eva prakāśyate, idam iti yaḥ pariccheda etāvad rūpatayā

tadvilakṣaṇībhāvena nīlapūtasukhaduḥkhatacchūnyatādyaśamkhyābhāsaayogena avabhāsyate, tataḥ caitreṇa cetate ity ucyate. evaṁ ca vimarśaḥ svātmani avimarśo 'pi. svātmani ity asiddham etat. vimarśo hi sarvaṁsahaḥ param api ātmīkaroti, ātmānaṁ ca parīkaroti, ubhayam ekīkaroti, ekīkṛtaṁ dvayam api nyagbhāvayati ity evaṁ svabhāvaḥ. pratyavamarśaś ca āntarābhilāpātmakaśabdanasvabhāvaḥ, tac ca śabdanam

saṅketanirapekṣam eva avicchinnacamatkārmakam antarmukhaśironirdeśapra-khyam akārādīmāyīyasāṅketikaśabdajīvitabhūta nīlam idaṁcaitro' ham ityādi pratyav amarśāntarabhittibhūtatvāt, pūrṇatvāt parā, vakti vīśvam abhilapati pratyavamarśena iti ca vāk, ata eva sā svarasena cidrūpatayā svātmaviśrāntivapuṣā uditā sadānastamitā nityā aham ity eva. etad eva paramātmāno mukhyam svātantryam aiśvryam īśitṛtvam ananyāpekṣitvam ucyate. parāparam tu idambhāvarūpasya

pratyavamarśasya akhyātiprāṇasya udbodhamātre 'pi ahaṁbhāva eva vīśrānteḥ śṛisadāśivādibhūmau paśyantīdaśāyām. aparaṁ tu idambhāvasyaiva nirūḍhau māyāgarbhādīhikṛtānāmevaviṣṇuvirīṇcendrādīnām, tattuteṣāṁparamēśvaraprasādaḥ eva. iti anyanirapekṣataiva paramārthata ānandaḥ, aiśvryam, svātantryam, caitan-yam. tasmāt yuktam uktam '... teṇa jaḍāt sa hi vilakṣaṇaḥ' iti. pradhānāgameṣv api etat pradarśitam eva iti nirūpayati:

sā sphurattā mahāsattā deśakālāviśeṣiṇī/saiṣā sāratayā proktā hṛdayaṃ parameṣṭhinaḥ (ĪPK 1.5.14).

[Abhinavagupta] iha ghaṭaḥ kasmāt asti, khapuṣpaṃ kasmāt nāsti ity uktā iti vaktāro bhavanti ghaṭo hi sphurati mama na tu itarat iti. tad etat ghaṭatvam eva yadi sphurattvaṃ sphuraṇasambandhaḥ, tat sarvadā sarvasya sphureṇa na kasyacidvā, tasmāt mama sphurati iti ko 'rtaḥ, madīyaṃ sphuraṇaṃ spandanam āviṣṭam iti. spandanaḥ kiñciccalanam, eṣaiva ca kiñcidrūpatā yat acaḥ api ca ābhāsate iti, prakāśasvarūpaṃ hi manāḡ api nātiricyate, atiricyate iva iti tat acaḥ eva ābhāśabhedayuktam iva ca bhāti. tata uktam:

'ātmaiva sarvabhāveṣu sphurannirvṛtacidvapuh / aniruddheccāprasaraḥ prasaraddṛkkriyāḥ śivāḥ //

iti. tathā: atikruddhaḥ prahrṣṭo vā kiṃ karomiti vā mṛṣaṇ / dhāvanvā yatpadaṃ gacchet tatra spandah pratiṣṭhitaḥ // iti ' . . . spandatattvaviviktaye'iti. guṇādispandanīḥṣyandāḥ . . . 'iti ca. loke 'pi spandavattvam. sattā ca bhavanakarṭṛtā sarvakriyāsu svātantryam. sā ca khapuṣpādikam api vyāpnoti iti mahatī, deśakālau nīlādivat saiva sṛjati iti tābhyāṃ viśeṣaṇīyā na bhavati, yat kila yena tulyakakṣyatayā bhāti tat tasya viśeṣaṇaṃ kaṭaka iva

caitrasya. na ca deśakālau vimarṣena tulyakakṣyau bhātaḥ tayoḥ idantayā tasya acaḥ ahanatayā prakāśe tulyakakṣyatvānupapatteḥ. evaṃ deśakālāsparsāt vibhūtvam nityatvaṃ ca, sakaladeśakālasparśo 'pi tannirmāṇayogāt iti tato 'pi vyāpakatvanityatve. tad uktam: 'mahāsattā mahādevī viśvajīvanamucyate'

iti. sārām iti yat atucchaṃ rūpaṃ tat iyameva vimarśaśaktiḥ, grāhyagrāhakaṇāṃ yat prakāśātmakaṃ rūpaṃ tasyāpi aprakāśavailakṣyaṇyākṣepikā iyaṃ eva iti śrīśāraśāstre 'pi nirūpitam: 'yat sārām asya jagataḥ sā śaktir mālinī parā' iti. saiṣā iti śaktipratyabhijñānaṃ darśitam. hṛdayaṃ ca nāma pratiṣṭhāsthānam ucyate, tac ca uktanīyā jaḍānāṃ cetanam, tasyāpi prakāśātmakatvam, tasyāpi vimarśaśaktiḥ iti viśvasya parame pade

tiṣṭhato viśrāntasya tasya idam eva hṛdayaṃ vimarśarūpaṃ paramantrātmakaṃ yatra tatra abhidhīyate. sarvasya hi mantra eva hṛdayaṃ, mantras ca vimarśanātmā, vimarśanaṃ ca parāvācchaktimayam. tata evoktam: 'na tair vinā bhavec chabdo nārtho nāpi ceter gatī'iti. 'tatra tāvatsamāpannā mātṛbhāvam. . . 'ityādi ca, ityāgameṣu. tatrābhavad bhartṛhariṇāpi: 'na so 'sti pratyayo loke yaḥ śabdānugamād ṛte / anuvīdham iva jñānaṃ sarvaṃ śabdena gamyate // vāgrūpatā ced utkrāmed avabodhasya śāsvatī / na prakāśaḥ prakāśeta sā hi pratyavamarṣiṇī // iti. 'saiṣā saṃsārināṃ saṃjñā bahir antaśca vartate / yad utkrāntau viśaṃjñō 'yaṃ dṛśyate kṣāṭhakuḍyavat // 'ityādi ca. tat etena viduḥ ity etat nirvāhitam. bauddhair api adhyavasāyāpekṣaṃ

prakāśasya prāmāṇyaṃ vadadbhiḥ upagataprāya eva ayam arthaḥ abhilāpātmakatvāt adhyavasāyasya iti.

nanu asaṃkhyāśaktiśreṇīśobhitavapuṣi paramaśīve vimarśaśaktireva

iyam itthaṃkāram abhiṣicyate kasmāt ityāśaṅky āha:

ātmānam ata evāyaṃ jñeyīkuryāt prthak sthiti / jñeyam na tu tadaunmukhyāt khaṇḍyetāsya svatantratā // (ĪPK 1.5.15).

svātantryāmuktamātmānam svātantryādadvayātmanah /
prabhurīśādisaṃkalpāirnirmāya vyavahārayet // (ĪPK 1.15.16).

[Abhinavagupta] sarvāḥ śaktoḥ kartṛtvaśaktiḥ aīśvaryaṭmā samākṣipati. sā ca vimarśarūpā iti yuktam aśyā eva prādhānyam iti tātparyeṇa uttaramuktam. śabdārthas tu ayam, prakāśātmā parameśvaraḥ svātmānam jñātrekarūpatvāt ajñeyam api jñeyīkaroti iti yat saṃbhāvyate kāraṇāntarasya anupapatteḥ darśitatvāt dṛḍhena saṃbhāvanānumānena,

tadata eva vimarśaśaktiḥ lakṣaṇāt kartṛtvāt hetoḥ bhavati, yato hi ayam ātmānam parāmṛśati tato viśvanirbharatvāt tathā nīlāditvena cakāṣti. nanu eṣaiva kutah saṃbhāvanā, ātmānam jñeyīkaroti iti? āha, prthak prakāśāt bahirbhūtā sthitiḥ yasya tāḍṛk jñeyam naiva bhavati. tuḥ avadhāraṇe. tatra ca uktā yuktayaḥ. abhyuccayayuktīm api āha, yadi vyatiriktaṃ jñeyam syāt tat jñātrrūpasya ātmano yat etat jñeyaviśayaṃ aunmukhyam

svasaṃvedanasiddhaṃ dr̥śyate tat na asya syāt, tena vyatirikta viśaya unmukhyena anyādhīnatvaṃ nāma pāratantryam asya āñiyate. pāratantryaṃ ca svātantryasya viruddham. svātantryameva ca ananyamukhaprekṣitva ātmanaḥ svarūpam, iti vyatiriktonamukha ātmā anātmāiva syāt. anātmā ca

jaḍo jñeyam prati na unmukhībhavati iti prasaṅgaḥ. tataḥ prasaṅgaviparyayaḥ idamāyātam avyatiriktonmukhaḥ svatantraḥ san ātmānameva jñeyīkaroti iti.

na ca kevalaṃ nīlādīrūpam eva jñeyam, yāvat atyaktakartṛsvabhāvaṃ svātantryeṇa aparityaktamevasantamātmānamnirmāyavyavahāreṇadhyānopāsanārcanopadeśādīnā yojayati iti yat saṃbhāvyate tad api ata eva iti saṃbandhaḥ. nanu svātantryayuktaṃ ca nirmāyate ca iti viruddham idam? atrāha advayātmanaḥ saṃvidekarūpasya svātantryāt hetoḥ idam na na yujyate, yat kila māyāpade atidurghaṭaṃ pratibhāti, tatsaṃpādane yat apratihataṃ svātantryaṃ tad eva punaḥ svātantryaśabdena darśitam. ata eva ity anena tu

vimarśasaktirūpam iti apunaruktaṃ. atha vā ata eva svātantryāt iti sāmānādhikāraṇyena ślokadvayena saṃbandhanīyam. udāharaṇam atrārthe darśayati, nīlādinirmāṇavat asya svatantranirmāṇasya aprasiddhatvāt, īśvaro bhagavān ātmā nityo vibhuḥ svatantraḥ ityevamātau hi pramātuḥ, pūjayituḥ, dhyātuḥ vā 'prthagbhūtaṃ tat prameyam, pūjyam, dhyeyam ca bhāti iti tat tāvat nimitam, na ca anīśvaram evaṃ hi īśvara iti, anīśvara iti saṃkalpadhyānādeḥ tulyatvaṃ syāt, na ca evam phalabhedasya upalabdheḥ iti, tasmāt svātantryaśūnyatābhāsanena svātantryayuktatābhāsanena ca yat idam ubhayaṃ jñeyam ātmarūpam eva paramēśvaro bhāsayati tat vimarśasaktibalāt eva, iti saiva pradhānam iti.

namu prakāśabalāt bhāvavyavasthā, sa ca prakāśo vimarśasāra iti vimarśābhede tad eva tat iti vaktuṃ yuktaṃ īśvara ātmā ityādisaṃkalpeṣu ca nimitasya idantayā parāmarśaḥ, svātantryaṃ tu ahaṃparāmarśarūpam, iti

nimitasya tadrūpatvābhāve kathaṃ svātantryāmuktatvaṃ iti? tat etatparihartum āha: nāhantādiparāmarśābhedaśāśūnyatātmanaḥ / ahaṃr̥śyatayaivāsya sṛṣṭeṣṭiṇvācyakarmavat // (ĪPK 1.5.17).

[Abhinavagupta] svarūpe bhāvapratyayaḥ, ādigrahaṇāt ātmeśvarādiparāmarśaḥ, tiṅgrahaṇam kriyāvācīpratyaḥopalakṣaṇam, karmagrahaṇam asattvabhūtasaktirūpopalakṣaṇam. tat ayam arthaḥ, ahaṃ ityevaṃ svarūpo yaḥ

parāmarśo yaśca īśvaraḥ pramātā ātmā śiva ityādiḥ anantaprakāraḥ parāmarśaḥ, tasya yady api bhedo 'nyonyarūpatā, tathāpi tadbhedāt hetoḥ asya ātmano nirmāṭrūpasya ahaṃparāmarśamayasya nirmeyarūpasya ca īśvarādiparāmarśāspadasya yo bhedaḥ śāṅkitāḥ sa na yuktaḥ. yata īśvara ityapi yaḥ parāmarśaḥ, sa īśanaṣṭile jñātrtvakartṛtvatattve viśrāmyati, jñātrtvādi ca jñānātau svātantryam ananyamukhaprekṣitva avicchinna jñānayaogaḥ, avicchedaś ca jñāmi karomi iti asmad arthaviśrāntiḥ iti asya īśvarasya

ātmanaḥ sṛṣṭeḥ sṛjyamānasya ahaṃvimarśanīyatvameva. sṛṣṭer iti vā hetau pañcamī. asya īśvarasya yataḥ īśvarādisaṃkalpeṣu api ahaṃparāmarśanayogyasyaiva sṛṣṭiḥ. arhe kṛtyaḥ yathākriyākāra kasamuccayavikalpādisaktayo yathāśvaṃ tīntrīyādicavādi—prayogāvaseyaparāmarśaparamārthāḥ pākāḥ kartā samuccayo vikalpaḥ ityādisābdaiḥ abhidhīyamānāḥ sattvabhāvamāpāditā api pacati caitreṇa ca vā ity evaṃ rūpe mūlaparāmarśe viśrāmyanti, anyathā tu tāḥ pratītiḥ naiva bhaveyuh. tadvat atrāpi. etad uktaṃ bhavati. parāmarśo nāma viśrāntisthānam, tac ca pāryantikaṃ eva pāramārthikaṃ, tac ca ahamīty evaṃ rūpameva. madhyaviśrāntipadaṃ tu yat vṛkṣamūlasthānīyaṃ grāmagamane tasya tadapekṣayā sṛṣṭatvaṃ ucyate iti ko virodhaḥ. anena nīlādeḥ api idaṃ nīlam iti madhyaparāmarśe 'pi mūlaparāmarśe ahaṃ ityeva viśrānteḥ ātmamayatvaṃ upapāditameva. 'nīlam idam vedmi' ityapi hi ahaṃ prakāśe ityattatvaṃ. yathoktaṃ idam ityasya ityādi. mūḍhas tu nīlādivimarśāt eva arthakriyādiritoṣābhīmānī iti nīlādeḥ svātantryanirmuktatvaṃ uktaṃ. ātmātau tu tanmūlaparāmarśaviśrāntim antareṇa pratītiparisamāptim arthakriyāṃ ca mūḍho 'pi na abhimanyata iti tasya nimittau api anujjhitasvātantryam uktaṃ.

nanv evaṃ viśvaparāmarśānām aham ityeva viśuddhaikaparāmarśaviśrāntir
eva tattvam tat katham idam ucyate jñānasmṛtyādikā asya śaktaya iti, jñānasya ca
saṃśayanirnayādibhedah nīlādīnām ca vaicitryam? iti

āsāṅkāyāṃ parihāramāha māyāśaktiā vibhoḥ saiva bhinnasaṃvedyagocarā/kathitā
jñānasaṃkalpādhyavasāyādināmabhiḥ // (ĪPK 1.5.18).

[Abhinavagupta] anupapannam avabhāsanam māyā iti ucyate, tataśca bhinnam
prakāśāt sarvam avabhāśajataṃ māyā, tatra ca cittattvasyaiva svātantryam
māyāśaktiḥ, tayā bhinnam yat saṃvedyam pramātuśca anyonyataśca, māyāśaktiā
bhinnena pramātuḥ anyonyato vedyāc ca karaṇavargeṇa yat saṃvedyam sa eva gocaro
viśrāntipadam yasyāḥ tādṛśī satī, saiva pratyavamarśātmā citiḥ parāvāgrūpā jñānam
iti, saṃkalpa iti, adhyavasāya iti ca ucyate, ādigrahaṇāt saṃśayaḥ smṛtiḥ ityādi. tathā
hi yat indriyena sphuṭagrāhiṇā bāhyena viśayeṇa sphuṭena ca

nīyantritam saṃvittattvam tat jñānam. manasā viśayeṇa ca asphuṭena saṃkalpah.
buddhyā viśayeṇa ca viśayatvaparyantabhājā adhyavasāyo niścayaḥ. viśayasya ca yat
bhinnatvam bahirantaḥ karaṇānām ca

tatprakāśābhedāt anupapannam cittattvena bhāsyate iti bhede yato viśrāntiḥ, na tu
bhedasya abhede tīsvarasadāśivādivat, tato jñānasaṃkalpādayo bhinnāḥ tasya apradhva
astavasvabhāvābhedasya

saṃvittattvasya anusaṃdhātuḥ śaktaya iti uktāḥ, saṃśayādāyaśca bhinnā nīlādi-
vaicitryam ca iti sarvam akhaṇḍitam.

nanu pratyavamarśātmatvam citiśakteḥ saṃkalpasmarāñādisaktiḥ savikalpātmikāsu
bhavati. yā tu nirvikalparūpā sāṅskārikaraṇalakṣaṇānubhavaśaktiḥ, tatra katham. praty-
avamarśo hi abhilāpaviśeṣayojanāmayaḥ, abhilāpaviśeṣayojanā ca saṅketasmarāṇam
apekṣate. tac ca saṃskāraprabodham. so 'pi tādṛśadrśam, iti evaṃ prathamasaṃmaye
katham abhilāpayogaḥ iti parasyavyāmoham apohitum āha:

sāṅskātikāraṅgaṇe 'pyasti vimarśaḥ katham anyathā / dhāvanādy upapadyeta prati-
saṃdhānavarjitam // (ĪPK 1.5.19).

[Abhinavagupta] iha tāvat caitanyasya ātmabhūto 'ngulinirdeśādirakhyo
'bhilāpayogaḥ, anyathā bālasya prathamam vyavahāre drśyamāne vyutpattir eva na
syāt. nirvikalpakajñānaparamparayā hi tam śabdaṃ śṛnoti, tataḥ tam artham puraḥ
paśyati, punastadviviktaṃ bhūtalam paśyati iti ghaṭam ānaya naya iti vyavahārāt
katham asya ayam artha

iti hṛdi parisphureti, idam ghaṭa iti, idam ānaya iti, idam naya iti, itijojanāprāṇo hi
ayamarthaḥ, yojanā ca vikalpavyāpārāḥ. atha bālasya prāḡjanmānubhūtasāṅketasmṛteḥ
evaṃ, tathāpi saṅketakāle sa śabda viśayatvena idambhāvena pratyavamarśyamānatvāt
bhedāt pracyutya nirbhāsamāno vijñānaśarīre viśrāntaḥ san vācaka iti bhavati,
tad vijñānasya svarūpaṃ cet bhāti tat abhilāpamayam eva iti, yathā viśayasya
sukharūpatvābhāve 'pi jñānam sukhātmakam tathā mā bhūta abhilāpātmā rūpādīḥ
viśayaḥ, tathāpi vijñānam tadātmakam avabhāśisyate. atra tu darśane viśayasyāpi
vimarśamayatvāt abhilāpamayatvam eva vastutaḥ, staimityādyavasthāpi yadi na
parāmarśamayī tarhi asyāṃ vikalpātmakapramāṇvyāpārānullāsāt sambhavaḥ
śāpathaparamārtha eva, smaraṇam ca na syāt, rūpaviśayādhyavasāyī hi yadi vikalpa
udiyāt kim anyat, sarvacintāsaṃharaṇena staimityam nāma na syāt, iti tatrāpi asti
antaḥ parāmarśaḥ, sakalena ca śabdagrāmeṇa śabdanaṃ hi sahante vastūni, tatra ca

nīyataśabddayojanam kriyate. tathā hi bālasya puraḥ piṇḍe sahajo yaḥ parāmarśaḥ,
aham ity avicchedena idam iti vicchedena vā tatprṛthe eva gaura iti gauḥ iti vā
śabda āropyaṭe, so 'pi abhyāsāt pramāṇmayo bhavati, tatprṛthe ca anyāḥ śukla iti,
anyat balīvarda iti, ity evaṃ saṅketatattvam. tasmāt asti sāṅskātikāre pratyavamarśaḥ.
apiśabdasya ayamāśayaḥ. iha sāṅskātikāro vastutaḥ paśyāmi ityevambhūtavikalpanavyā
pāraparyanta eva. vikalpo hi pratyakṣasya vyāpāra iti paro 'pi manyate. na ca vyāpārāḥ
tadvato bhinnō yuktāḥ, tatsvarūpabhūto hi

saḥ. bhavatu vā kṣaṇamātrasvabhāvaḥ sāṅskātikāraḥ, tatrāpi asti vimarśaḥ. avaśyam
caitat. katham anyathā iti. yadi sa na syāt tat ekābhisamdhānena javāt gacchan,

tvaritaṃ ca varṇān paṭhan, drutaṃ ca mantrapustakaṃ vācayan, na abhimatameva gacchet, uccārayet, vācayet vā. tathā hi tasmin deśe jñānam—ācikramiṣā—ākramaṇam—ākrāntatājñānam—prayojanāntarānusaṃdhānam—tityakṣā—deśāntarānusaṃdhiḥ, tatrāpi ācikramiṣā ityādinām yojanaviyojanarūpeṇa pratyavamarśena. vinābhimata-deśāvāptiḥ kathaṃ bhavet. evaṃ

tvaritodgrahaṇavācanādau mantavyam. tatra viśeṣataḥ sthānakaranākramaṇā-diyogaḥ. atra ca yataḥ paścādbhāvisthūlavikalpapakalpanā na saṃvedyate, tata eva tvaritatvam iti sūkṣmeṇa pratyavamarśena saṃvartitaśabdabhāvanāmayena bhāvyam eva. saṃvartitā hi śabdabhāvanā prasāraṇena vivartyamānā sthūlo vikalpaḥ, yathā idam ityasya prasāraṇā ghaṭaḥ śukla ityādiḥ, tasyāpi pṛthubudhnodarākāraḥ śuklatvajātiyuktaguṇasamavāyītyādiḥ. dhāvu gatiśuddhau iti pāṭhāt dhāvistvaritagatau svasaktivaśāt vartata iti.

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